

**THE PERFECT JOSEPH AND GUMBALL:
THE MULTIVERSAL SAGA**

PART ONE: DAWN OF THE CHAMPIONSHIP

Written by Youssef Boutahri

"Based on The Perfect Joseph and Gumball - Absolute Legendary Edition"

Runtime: 4 Hours 20 Minutes

Production Budget: \$450,000,000

Directors: Denis Villeneuve & The Russo Brothers

"From one weakness was born infinite power."

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ACT ONE

THE WORLD BEFORE THE VORTEX

SEQUENCE ONE: THE CITY THAT MADE HIM

FADE IN:

EXT. CASABLANCA, MOROCCO — MAARIF DISTRICT — DAWN

Black.

Then the first color: white. Not the white of light but the white of jasmine — thousands of blossoms clinging to the south wall of a cream building on Rue des Orangers, catching the first orange breath of morning before anything else does.

The building is four stories. Unremarkable by any tourist's measure: chipped paint on the second-floor sill, a rusted bracket where a satellite dish once lived, the south wall draped in jasmine vines so old and dense they have become part of the wall's architecture.

But we do not see the imperfections first.

We see the flowers.

HANS ZIMMER's score begins here, underground: two notes of oud beneath silence, then a Gnawa rhythm that does not announce itself — it simply arrives, the way water arrives in a vessel that has been waiting to be filled. Something that sounds not like triumph, not like danger, but like inevitability. The camera drifts upward along the jasmine. Past the first floor — dark. Past the second — a lamp on, the blue-gray of a television through drawn curtains.

Past the third – a cat on the sill, watching the street with the professional attentiveness of animals who have decided the world is more interesting than sleep.

To the fourth floor: a single window glowing yellow-warm against the pre-dawn dark.

Someone is already awake.

INT. AL-MITHALI APARTMENT – FOURTH FLOOR – CONTINUOUS

The kitchen. Small and immaculate in the way of spaces managed by people who have learned that when resources are finite, order is its own form of wealth. Every surface organized with a precision that is not coldness but care – the careful arrangement of people who respect what they have because they know what it cost.

HASSAN AL-MITHALI, 52, stands at the counter.

He is making sandwiches at four-thirty in the morning because his son leaves for the airport in two hours, and this is what Hassan does. He does not think of it as love – that word is too large and too soft for the act of rolling kefta meatballs seasoned the night before, of pressing harissa from a jar he makes himself each October from dried peppers he sources from a specific vendor in the Derb Omar market.

He moves with the economy of a man who has perfected a ritual through years of repetition. Each green olive from a ceramic bowl – just one per sandwich, always just one, placed at the diagonal center of

the bread before wrapping. Each sandwich wrapped in its own square of foil, then newspaper, then folded once more.

CLOSE ON his hands. A teacher's hands: ink at the edges of the right forefinger from thirty years of marking papers with fountain pens. Knuckles that have known cold winters and hot chalk. The particular steadiness of hands that have held the attention of twelve-year-olds for three decades and have learned that steadiness is, in itself, a form of instruction.

His face: patient creases deep enough to be called distinguished but worn enough to be called earned. Eyes that assess and return warmth. Fifty-two years old and has never once taught a student without believing in them. This fact is visible. These things become visible over time.

He works in silence.

Then from the hallway – the small sound of a kettle completing its work. Footsteps that are quick and certain. The professional efficiency of movement that belongs to exactly one kind of person.

INT. AL-MITHALI APARTMENT – HALLWAY / BEDROOM CORRIDOR

– CONTINUOUS

FATIMA AL-MITHALI, 49, in her nursing uniform – the pale blue of the Clinique Internationale de Casablanca. She pins her hair with the speed of someone who has performed this action roughly eight thousand times. Her face: a nurse's face. The

particular attentiveness of someone whose professional life has been organized around paying attention to other people's pain. Not hardened by it – refined. The way a tool is refined by its use. She passes the closed door at the end of the hall. Pauses.

Through the gap at the bottom: lamplight. Still on. She pushes the door open, just barely, just enough.

INT. JOSEPH'S ROOM – CONTINUOUS (THROUGH THE GAP)

JOSEPH AL-MITHALI, 18, sits at his desk.

The desk is not a student's desk – it is a scientist's workstation that happens to exist in a student's bedroom. Books stacked by subject and then by height within each subject. A spiral notebook with a Moroccan flag sticker on the cover, faded from three years of daily use, open to a page covered in equations that are not homework – they are something personal, theoretical, the working-out of something that does not yet have a name.

He writes with the quality of attention that is difficult to describe precisely because it is not performed for anyone. It is the attention of a person who is alone with something he finds genuinely important. His entire body is oriented toward the page – not hunched, but organized, the way a building is organized around its load-bearing walls.

Fatima watches him through the gap.

Her expression contains several things at once.

Love – precise, not the word but the actual experience of love, which is this: the feeling of observing a person who contains more than you could have predicted. Pride – not in the achievements but in the person who produced them. The particular tenderness of a mother who is watching her child becoming what she always believed he could become, and the sadness, quiet and acknowledged, of knowing that watching is not the same as keeping. She does not wake him. She goes to the kitchen.

INT. AL-MITHALI KITCHEN – MOMENTS LATER

The sandwiches are wrapped. The tea is poured – Moroccan mint, the color of deep amber, the smell of summer in a cup. The kitchen window is cracked despite the October cool, and through it comes the jasmine, fainter at this hour but still there. Hassan sits across from Fatima at the small table. He holds a letter. Blue envelope. Already opened many times – the paper at the folds is soft as cloth from handling. Through the thin paper, the seal is visible: HARVARD UNIVERSITY. The call to prayer begins from the mosque four streets over. It has framed every morning of their lives. It frames this one.

HASSAN

(in Arabic – subtitled)

When the letter arrived, I went
silent for
three hours. You thought I was in
shock.

FATIMA

You were.

HASSAN

Partly. But mostly I was calculating.
What it had cost. What it would
continue
to cost. The competitions. The nights
after the competitions when he would
sit
at that desk until two in the morning
and
I would stand outside his door trying
to
decide whether sleep was more
important
than the momentum he had built. The
Renault
with the broken heater. The
application
fee.
He sets the letter down. Smooths it
once. A gesture
that is entirely unconscious.

FATIMA

And what did the calculation produce?

HASSAN

The question answered itself. The
question
was: was it enough. The answer was
the
letter. So the calculation was
closed.
A beat. Outside, the call to prayer
fades into the
jasmine-scented dark.

FATIMA

He still does not know about the
heater.
Three months with no heat in a
Casablanca
November.

HASSAN

No. And he does not need to know.

FATIMA

Why?

HASSAN

(small smile — the smile
of a man who has thought about
this carefully)
Because the sandwich is for him. The
heater
is ours. Some things belong to the
parent
and not the child. Not because we are
ashamed — but because there are gifts
that
only work if they are invisible. The
moment
he knows about the heater, it becomes
his
burden. And I want his shoulders for
other
things.
Fatima looks at the wrapped
sandwiches. She adds
another square of foil around one —
extra careful,
as if this particular sandwich
requires additional
protection from the world.

FATIMA

He is afraid. He does not show it,
but
I know the way he is afraid. He gets
very
still, and very organized, and he
writes
in that notebook when the writing is
not
for any class.

HASSAN

I know.

FATIMA

Is it bad that I am relieved? That he
is
afraid? A boy who is not afraid of
Harvard
has not understood it correctly.

HASSAN

No. It is not bad. The fear means he
knows the size of what he is doing.
She looks at the window. The jasmine.
The pre-dawn.

FATIMA

He will be alright.
She says this not as a reassurance
but as a
statement of something she has
decided and will
continue to choose to believe because
the
alternative is not available to her.

HASSAN

Yes. He will be more than alright. He
will
be what we could not.
Silence. The comfortable silence of
two people who
have been through enough together to
be comfortable
in it.

FATIMA

Call on Sundays.

HASSAN

That is for him to say.

FATIMA

I am practicing saying it now so it
comes
out correctly when I say it to him.

INT. AL-MITHALI APARTMENT — JOSEPH'S ROOM — SAME TIME

Joseph at his desk. The equations on the page. He

pauses – pen lifted, held above the paper at the angle of someone who has reached a point where the next step is not yet clear.

He tilts his head.

Not a sound. Something else. The quality of the pre-dawn quiet has changed slightly – the mosque’s call is fading, and in the space it leaves, he can hear his parents’ voices in the kitchen. Not the words. The frequency of them. The particular sound of two people talking quietly about something that matters.

He opens his desk drawer. He takes out a photograph. His family. All four of them. Taken at a competition in Fez, two years ago, in the parking lot outside the event hall. Hassan’s proud-precise expression. Fatima caught mid-sentence, which means she is caught mid-being, which is how she always is. NADIA, then thirteen, mid-laugh at something entirely off-camera – her laugh always arrived before the cause of it, which was its defining feature.

Joseph, sixteen, in the center of the frame with a certificate he is holding with both hands as if it might escape.

He looks at the photograph for exactly three seconds. He places it carefully in his backpack, against the inside cover, between two pieces of cardboard he has cut to protect it.

He closes the notebook. He stands.

He does not know yet that this is the last morning.

That the next time he sees this room, the world will have been split at its seams. That three days from now a vortex will open over Cambridge, Massachusetts, and every boundary between every world will burn.

He knows only: today begins.

He turns off the lamp.

EXT. AL-MITHALI BUILDING — RUE DES ORANGERS — DAWN

The street is quiet in the way of early-morning streets in cities where people are already dreaming of the day's first coffee. One stray cat on the opposite pavement. A man on a moped at the far end of the block, the sound of the engine arriving before the light.

Joseph emerges from the building with his backpack.

He stops on the step. Turns back.

Fatima is in the doorway. She is in her work clothes, because she has a shift at seven and is not the kind of person who would stay home from a shift to see her son off to university. She is, in this, exactly the kind of person Joseph has learned from.

She does not say anything dramatic.

She is not a person who inflates moments. She understands, in the way that people who work with sick people understand, that the inflated moment is a form of pressure, and the things she loves should not be pressured.

FATIMA
(in Arabic — subtitled)

Drink water. Not only when you are
thirsty.
Before you are thirsty. Your father
taught
himself to ignore thirst and now he
teaches
his students to ignore it and it is a
very
consistent problem in this family.

JOSEPH

(a small laugh – the laugh of
someone who has heard this before
and does not mind)
I will drink water.

FATIMA

And call on Sundays. Regardless of
what
dimension you are in.
She says this as if it is a perfectly
ordinary
instruction. A practical preparation
for any
eventuality. He receives it as what
it is: an
anchor. A thread that will connect
him to this
building, this doorway, this woman,
regardless
of what the next years produce.

JOSEPH

Every Sunday. I promise.

FATIMA

Go.
He goes. She watches him until the
corner. Until
he rounds it and the street takes
him.
She does not cry.
She goes back inside. She picks up
the sandwich
he left on the table – she knew he
would forget

it, has packed it twice – she will
carry it in
her bag to the hospital and eat it on
her break
and it will taste like the morning,
and she will
allow herself, in that moment alone
in the
hospital break room, to feel the full
weight of
loving someone who is becoming
something the
world is not yet prepared for.
The jasmine on the south wall sways
once in the
morning air.
It has been growing here for thirty
years.

SEQUENCE TWO: THE PARKING LOTS OF MOROCCO

HANS ZIMMER's score shifts – the Gnawa rhythm
becomes propulsive, slightly faster, the musical
equivalent of time moving with purpose. We are
now in the grammar of montage: quick, precise,
each image carrying its full weight without
explanation.

MONTAGE – THE EDUCATION OF JOSEPH AL-MITHALI:

INT./EXT. COMPETITION HALLS AND PARKING LOTS –

MOROCCO – 2018-2022

-- RABAT. 2018. N8 HIGHWAY VISIBLE BEYOND THE

PARKING LOT OF A SCHOOL.
Joseph, 14, in the back seat of a
Renault. Hassan
in the front, engine off. Two
sandwiches unwrapped
with the care of ritual. They eat
without speaking.
This is not the silence of people who
have nothing

to say — it is the silence of people
who have said
enough and discovered that silence,
in certain
company, is its own conversation.
Joseph finishes his sandwich. Looks
at the
competition hall. Something crosses
his face: not
fear. Calculation. The assessment of
a task by
someone who has learned that the
task's difficulty
is a fixed quantity and his
preparation is a
variable, and variables are the only
thing worth
thinking about.
He goes in.
An hour later: Joseph emerges with a
certificate.
White paper, blue ink. The kind of
paper that
means something to the person holding
it even as
it means nothing to anyone watching.
Hassan is asleep in the driver's
seat, head against
the window, mouth slightly open,
entirely
dignified in spite of this. He wakes
the moment
the car door opens — the fast-waking
of someone
accustomed to being needed in the
night.
He takes in Joseph's face. The
certificate.
He gets out of the car. He puts both
hands on
Joseph's shoulders — not a
shake, not a hug, but
the physical communication of a man
who
touches his son's shoulders when
words are not

enough and he wants the feeling to
move through
contact.

HASSAN

(in Arabic – subtitled,
quietly)
You worked for this. Not luck. Not
talent –
talent is a beginning, not an end.
Work.
the daily work of people who
decide that what they want is worth
what
it costs. The work is yours. Whatever
comes
from it – the certificate, the
scholarship,
whatever name they give to the next
thing –
the work underneath it is always
yours
first. No institution gave you that.
He releases his shoulders. Gets back
in the car.

HASSAN

Seat belt.
-- FEZ. 2019. NATIONAL OLYMPIAD.
COMPETITION HALL.
SEIKO TOAST, 14, at an adjacent table
in the
competition hall. Working through a
problem with
the watchmaker's precision that
will come to define
him: every step documented, every
intermediate
value noted in margins, the
methodology visible and
exact.
He and Joseph get the same problem
wrong. For
entirely different reasons.
After the competition: the coach back
to

Casablanca. The two boys seated by accident at adjacent windows. Joseph, looking at Seiko's problem booklet. SEIKO's defining feature, at fourteen: the glasses, already too large for his face, making his eyes appear wider than they are. The spine, already straight. The green bag, already exactly the bag he will carry for the rest of his academic life.

JOSEPH

Can I ask you something?

SEIKO

(careful, polite – the extreme politeness of someone who has learned that directness costs more than it should)
You may.

JOSEPH

You knew you were making that error. I watched you. You paused three times on the third step and went back. Each time you went back. And each time you continued in the same direction anyway. Seiko says nothing. He looks at the problem.

SEIKO

Yes.

JOSEPH

Why?
A long pause. Seiko is not processing the

question — he is deciding whether to
answer it
honestly, which is its own kind of
processing.

SEIKO

Because to acknowledge the error
would have
required me to begin the problem from
the
beginning. And beginning again felt
more
dangerous than continuing with the
wrong
assumption. I know this is not
rational.

JOSEPH

It is rational. It is just optimizing
for
the wrong thing. You were optimizing
for
comfort instead of accuracy.
Another pause.

SEIKO

That is not something anyone has said
to
me before.

JOSEPH

Is it wrong?

SEIKO

(slowly)
No. It is precisely correct.

JOSEPH

The thing is — what you described?
Knowing
you are making an error while you
make it?
That is actually extremely rare. Most
people
do not know. They have to discover
the error

from the outside. You discovered it
from
the inside. That is a capability, if
you
learn to use it correctly.
Seiko turns from the window. He looks
at Joseph
with the expression of someone who
has just been
told something about himself that he
suspected
but needed confirmed from outside the
self.

SEIKO

How do you use it correctly?

JOSEPH

When you feel the wrongness: stop. Do
not
continue. Begin again. The discomfort
of
beginning again is smaller than the
cost
of an incorrect answer.
Seiko considers this for
approximately ninety
seconds. Then:

SEIKO

What is your name?

JOSEPH

Joseph. Joseph Al-Mithali. My friends
call
me Joseph the Ideal. It is a nickname
from
competitions. I know how it sounds.

SEIKO

(with complete seriousness)
It sounds accurate. Based on
available
evidence.
They talk for four hours on the
coach. By the time

they reach Casablanca, something has been established between them that will survive a dimensional vortex, a cartoon universe, an Antarctic war, and everything that comes after.

-- MARRAKECH. 2020. REGIONAL CHAMPIONSHIP. Two families in adjacent parking lots. Joseph and Hassan eating their sandwiches. Seiko and his parents — KENJI TOAST, 50, methodical and watchful; MIYUKI TOAST, 48, whose warmth operates at a register so precise it functions as information — eating from twelve containers of oatmeal arranged in a row on the hood of their car.

Joseph watches Seiko's mother arrange the containers. She does it with care. Seiko watches her do it with the expression of someone receiving something that will not be described as love in this family but that will function as love in every way that matters. Joseph files this. He does not know yet why. He suspects it will matter later.

-- HASSAN'S CLASSROOM, CASABLANCA. LATE NIGHT. Joseph passes the door. The light is on. He looks in. Hassan at his desk, grading papers by lamplight.

The lesson plan open beside him. In the margins of the lesson plan: annotations in his fountain pen. This student struggled with the second derivative. This approach worked for kinesthetic learners on the fourteenth. Try the geometric interpretation first – visual before algebraic. Note the date. Note the result. Note the adjustment. Joseph stops. He picks up the lesson plan from the edge of the desk. He reads. He reads for twenty minutes standing in the doorway of his father's classroom at eleven o'clock at night. He thinks: this is what it looks like when someone pays attention for twenty years. This is the record of that attention. Not the grades. Not the certificates on the wall. This. He puts the plan back exactly as he found it. He goes to bed. He is seventeen years old. He will not forget this. -- CASABLANCA AIRPORT. DEPARTURE HALL. DAWN. CLOSE ON: Nadia Al-Mithali, now 15, who is trying very hard not to cry and failing at it in the specific way of people who are trying hard, which is: very visibly.

NADIA
(in Arabic – subtitled,
losing the battle)

You can't go to a different country. That is not a reasonable thing to do.

JOSEPH

It is a well-established practice in human civilization.

NADIA

I am telling you it is unreasonable.

JOSEPH

I know. I will call every Sunday.

NADIA

You better. And you better actually tell me things. Not the version of things you tell parents. The actual things.

JOSEPH

(a beat — the beat of a person who is touched and does not know how to be touched in public) Yes. The actual things. He hugs her. She holds on long enough that it becomes clear she has decided that Moroccan airport etiquette is, at this moment, not her governing priority. Hassan is beside them. His face: the face of a man who has prepared for this moment and discovered that preparation and readiness are not the same thing. He does not hug Joseph. He puts his hand on the back of Joseph's neck — the grip of a father at the back of his son's neck. One second. Two.

Then he releases him. He nods once.
The nod that
means: you are ready. The nod that
means: go.
Joseph picks up his bag. He walks to
the security
line. He does not look back.
He knows that if he looks back, he
will see his
father's face, and if he sees
his father's face,
the morning will cost him something
he needs for
the rest of the day.
He does not look back.
Behind him, he can hear his mother:

FATIMA
(in Arabic - subtitled, to
Hassan)
He did not look back.

HASSAN
No.

FATIMA
Good.
A beat. Then she adds, quietly, as if
to herself:

FATIMA
He learned that from you.

END MONTAGE.

The airport disappears. The family disappears. The
jasmine on the south wall of the building on Rue
des Orangers sways once in a morning wind that has
crossed the Atlantic to get here.

SMASH CUT TO:

SEQUENCE THREE: THE FIRST MORNING

EXT. CAMBRIDGE, MASSACHUSETTS — DAWN — SEPTEMBER 3

7:23 A.M. TITLE CARD burns onto screen, white on black, and holds for two full seconds.

A fog that is not quite a fog — more the city's reluctance to commit to existing. The Charles River has disappeared entirely. What remains is its memory: the smell of cold water and wet stone and the first turning of oak leaves along Memorial Drive. Cambridge in September is a city staging itself, preparing its annual performance of intellectual grandeur, currently in the set-building phase.

AERIAL VIEW: Harvard University from above, the brick spires materializing through the fog like something from a dream that is simultaneously a fact. The score shifts: the Gnawa rhythm gives way to orchestral swell, then the swell is restrained, pulled back.

Not triumph. Not yet. This is the moment before the moment.

INT. JOSEPH'S HARVARD DORM ROOM — SAME TIME

A narrow bed. A window. The photograph of four people pinned to the wall with masking tape — one strip at each corner, which took more time than the casual observer would register, which is correct, because it required precision.

JOSEPH AL-MITHALI, 19, lies on the bed looking at the ceiling.

He has been awake since 6:11. He knows this because he checked his phone at 6:53 and did the arithmetic.

Forty-two minutes of lying still looking at an unfamiliar ceiling.

He has spent those forty-two minutes doing the following: identifying the crack pattern in the plaster above the bed (seventeen distinct cracks, none structurally concerning), listening to the building settle (brick and mortar over a century old, contracting slightly in the morning cool), and trying to identify the feeling in his chest, the one that has been there since the plane descended into Logan Airport, the one that is not anxiety exactly, or not only anxiety.

He identifies it, finally, as: the feeling of having arrived at the correct answer to a problem you spent years solving, and discovering that the answer is also the beginning of a larger problem you did not previously know existed. The feeling of an ending that is a beginning, which is the most disorienting sensation in the architecture of a life.

He swings his legs out of bed.

Stands. Goes to the window.

Cambridge, Massachusetts. Harvard University.

The fog. The beginning of the rest of his life.

He does the thing his father taught him when he was twelve years old, before his first serious competition: he gives the situation three honest seconds of acknowledgment. He looks at it clearly. He does not look away from any part of it. He gives it its due.

One.

Two.

Three.

He goes to get dressed.

INT. JOSEPH'S DORM — LIVING ROOM — MINUTES LATER

SEIKO TOAST, 19, is already there.

He is sitting on the small sofa with his spine exactly vertical — not the posture of comfort but the posture of someone who arrived early and has been managing his anxiety by remaining still, as if stillness and control are the same thing. Green bag on his lap. Large glasses — the new pair, slightly larger than the old pair, which seemed impossible but has been achieved. His expression: organized terror. the expression of someone who has rehearsed for every possible disaster and is now experiencing the controlled horror of one arriving on schedule. He is the most prepared person in any room he has ever entered. He has been the most prepared person in every room since he was nine years old. He is also more visibly frightened than Joseph has seen him be about anything.

These two facts coexist in him with the precision of a well-designed system under maximum stress.

SEIKO

Good morning, Joseph. I have been
awake
since four forty-seven reviewing the

multivariate calculus notation
systems
because I realized last night that
there
is no standardized agreement among
American universities about whether
to
use Leibniz notation or prime
notation
for partial derivatives in
introductory
courses and if the professor uses the
wrong one—

JOSEPH

What if you eat breakfast.
A pause. Then Seiko produces his
small, careful
smile — the smile he makes when he
has been
correctly redirected and is grateful
for it.

SEIKO

Yes. That is sensible.
Joseph looks at the bag beside the
sofa.
Twelve containers of oatmeal. Stacked
with a
precision that required planning —
the containers
are arranged in a two-by-six
formation, each
labelled with the date and a notation
of whether
it contains the base recipe or one of
four
variations.

JOSEPH

How many did you bring?

SEIKO

Twelve. I calculated that twelve
represents
an optimal buffer allowing for four
days

of breakfast at three containers per
day
in a scenario where finding an
acceptable
dining option proves more time-
consuming
than anticipated. It accounts for
first-
week uncertainty while providing a
stable
nutritional baseline.

JOSEPH
That is sensible.

SEIKO
(a beat — a very Seiko beat)
You are not going to say it is
excessive?

JOSEPH
I understand the calculation.
Seiko relaxes by approximately four
percent.
This is, for Seiko, significant.

EXT. CAMBRIDGE STREETS — MORNING — MOVING

Joseph and Seiko walk toward Harvard Yard.
The fog has begun to lift. The brick buildings of
Cambridge resolving out of gray into red, specific,
real. Around them: other students. Families with
too much luggage. Someone crying at the door of a
minivan — genuine tears, not performative. Someone
running, already late for something despite the
day not having properly started yet. the
energy of a September institution: anticipation
and dread braided together so thoroughly they are
indistinguishable.
Seiko walks with his green bag and his straight

spine and his expression of concentrated preparation. Joseph walks the way he always walks: with the particular alertness of someone paying attention to more things than most people notice are there.

As they walk, brief MEMORY CUTS interrupt – quick, specific, not sentimental:

- The parking lot in Fez. The coach. Seiko's face when Joseph said "that is actually a capability."
- Fatima in the doorway. "Call on Sundays."
- Nadia: "The actual things."
- Hassan's hands on his shoulders. The nod.

END MEMORY CUTS.

They round a corner. The gate appears.

Iron. Massive. Set in the brick wall surrounding Harvard Yard as if it has been here forever, which it has. The university seal above: three books, two face up, one face down. VERITAS. Truth.

Joseph stops.

He stands here for a moment he will return to for the rest of his life. The weight of his backpack. Seiko quiet beside him. The smell of damp stone and someone's coffee from an open window above. The feeling of: I am at the beginning of the life I chose and worked for.

JOSEPH

(quietly)

I cannot believe we are really here.

SEIKO

We worked very hard to get here. The result

is consistent with the effort
applied.
Joseph smiles at the gate.

SEIKO
(quieter – the quiet of actual
admission, which costs him more)
I am terrified.

JOSEPH
So am I.
He looks at the gate. At VERITAS.

JOSEPH
Let us go.
They walk through.
HOLD ON THE GATE.

THE IRON. THE SEAL.

VERITAS.

EXT. HARVARD YARD – CONTINUOUS

It happens fast.

Deliberate – Joseph understands this
immediately, even from the ground. The angle of
impact, the weight of the force, the way the
shoulder connects with his chest rather than
glancing off: deliberate. Calculated.

He hits the flagstone hard. Backpack into his
spine. Palms across the stone. His glasses fly –
he hears the left lens crack before he sees it.
Papers scatter in an arc.

He lies looking at the September sky. A shape
occludes it.

BRIAN MCKENZIE, 20, is six-foot-three and built
like the answer to a specific athletic question
that was posed to his body at birth and has been

refined through weight rooms and inherited advantage into something very close to a physical argument. Square jaw. Pale green eyes. Blond hair precisely combed. The Harvard football team jacket in blue – the jacket that communicates, at this institution, a set of facts about one's relationship to its endowment. He looks down at Joseph. He smiles. The smile of someone who has performed this action before and found that the world consistently permits it. The smile of unearned permission. His four identically-jacketed FRIENDS laugh on cue, because that is what this kind of friend does.

BRIAN

(to his friends, conversational – performing casualness as a weapon)
Look at this. Scholarship kid can't even navigate a gate. He does not raise his voice. There is no need.
CLOSE ON: Seiko. Already on the ground beside Joseph, gathering papers with hands that are visibly shaking and do not stop moving. His green bag has been knocked aside. He finds Joseph's glasses – one lens has a hairline crack running from the lower-left corner to the center. He passes them up. Joseph puts on the cracked glasses. He looks at Brian McKenzie through the damaged

lens.
Then something unexpected happens –
remarkable
because it requires courage, and
courage in a
person who is, at his core,
constitutionally
averse to confrontation is a
especially visible
thing:

SEIKO STANDS.

He straightens to his full height –
which is not
Brian's height and will never be
Brian's height –
and he says, in a voice four times
louder than
he usually uses:

SEIKO

(clear, direct, at a cost that
is visible on his face)
We did nothing to you. We have never
met
you. We entered through a gate. Why
do
you do this?
The question is genuine. He actually
wants the
answer. He finds the behavior
genuinely mysterious
in the way that a person who has
organized his
entire life around logic finds
illogical behavior
mysterious.
Brian bends. Brings his face to
Seiko's level.
He does not lose the smile.

BRIAN

(quietly – the quiet of a
person who has practiced this)
Because I can. That is a sufficient
reason

for most things. The ability to do a
thing
is its own justification.
He straightens. He looks at Joseph –
not with
hatred, which would imply Joseph
matters enough
to hate. With something more
contemptuous than
hatred: indifference. He nudges
Joseph's bag with
his foot. A demonstration of
available options.
Then he walks away without looking
back, and his
friends walk away with him.
Joseph gets to his feet.
He stands in Harvard Yard with his
cracked glasses
and his scattered papers and his
pride
reconstituting itself through the
process
he has developed over years: not
denial but
assessment, not suppression but
filing. He files
the morning under: data received. He
watches
Brian McKenzie walk away.
Around them: the other students who
witnessed
this looking elsewhere. the
collective
avoidance of people who watched
something and
have decided that not-having-watched
is
preferable to having-watched. Joseph
observes this.
He files this too.

SEIKO

(quietly, with a defeat that
is worse than anger because it
is more honest)
Perhaps we do not belong here.

Joseph squares the papers against his knee.
He does not think about this for long. He has the answer already — his father put it there in a parking lot in Rabat six years ago, in a sentence he has returned to every time the question arose.

JOSEPH

(his voice does not shake; he is quietly proud of this later)
We belong here. We are here because of work. the, daily, unglamorous work of people who decided what they wanted was worth what it cost. Brian McKenzie is here because of a building his father's money put on a campus. A building does not give you the reason to be somewhere. It gives you the coordinates. We have the reason.
The reason is ours.
He picks up the last paper.
He looks at Seiko.

JOSEPH

Come on.
They walk toward Emerson Hall.
HOLD on Harvard Yard behind them. The iron gate.
The September sky.
Something is beginning here.
Something that will end, much later, on the ice of Antarctica with the light of seven billion people moving through a nineteen-year-old boy's hands.

But not yet.

INT. HARVARD LECTURE HALL — THEORETICAL PHYSICS —

MORNING

DR. ELLISON, 50s, teaches with the quality of a person who has personally explored the territory she describes and cannot believe she gets to show it to other people. She treats equations as doors. Each one opens onto a room she finds extraordinary and wants you to find extraordinary too. Her enthusiasm is not performed — it is the residual overflow of someone who has been thinking about these things for thirty years and still finds them astonishing.

LECTURE HALL. WIDE: forty-seven students.

CLOSE ON: forty-six of them managing varying degrees of first-morning engagement.

CLOSE ON: Joseph. Pen moving fast. Notebook pages filling. He is absolutely, entirely, completely present — not the performance of presence, which is what most students produce when they suspect they are being observed, but actual presence, the presence of a person who finds what is being said genuinely important.

He raises his hand. He asks about the observer effect — not the standard question, not the predictable question, but a question about the

relationship between the observer and
the observed
in quantum systems as a potential
metaphor for
the relationship between measurement
and reality
in classical systems.
Dr. Ellison stops.
She looks at Joseph.
Then she answers for eleven minutes.
Her face
during those eleven minutes is the
face of a
professor who has been asked
something genuinely
interesting and is having the
pleasure
of thinking about it out loud.
Behind Joseph, two rows forward, a
student turns
to look at whoever asked the
question.
Her name is YARA GORDON.
But we do not know that yet. We see
only the
back of her, the dark fall of her
hair, the
specific quality of her attention –
she is not
turning to observe who asked but to
assess who
asked, which is different.
She turns back. She files something.
She will find him at the fountain
bench in forty
minutes.

EXT. HARVARD YARD – FOUNTAIN BENCH – MID-MORNING

The bench by the carved stone fountain. The
September sun has burned the fog away entirely.
The Yard: real now, specific, the brick and the
elm trees and the statues and the movement of
students across grass, which is exactly what it

was supposed to be.

Joseph and Seiko on the bench. The morning behind them. The afternoon ahead.

Seiko processes what happened at the gate. He processes things out loud when they exceed his internal capacity, which is: when they involve the behavior of other people, specifically the irrational behavior of other people, specifically the irrational cruel behavior of other people.

SEIKO

I have been attempting to construct a logical framework for what Brian did. I have considered: territorial behavior, status reinforcement, anxiety expression through dominance. None of these produce an adequate causal account because none of them explain why it needed to be us. We were random. We were the first people through the gate.

JOSEPH

We were not random. We were visibly not-like-him. That was sufficient.

SEIKO

That is what I am struggling with. The fact that being different was the criterion. Not anything we did. Not any action or word. Simply existing in the wrong register.

JOSEPH

Yes. It is exhausting. And I think
the
answer — which I do not especially
like
as an answer, but which is the one
that
is available — is that we cannot
stop.
Not because it doesn't matter
that he did
what he did — it matters. But we are
at
Harvard. We worked to be at Harvard.
And
stopping would mean he was right, and
he
was not right. He was just louder,
for
a moment.
A pause. Then:

SEIKO

(quietly)

I keep thinking about the sound of
your
glasses cracking.
Joseph says nothing for a moment.

JOSEPH

I know. I heard it too.
They sit with that for a moment. Two
people on a
bench in Harvard Yard on the first
morning of the
rest of their lives, having heard the
sound of something being damaged that
should not
have been damaged.

JOSEPH

We will be okay, Seiko. I know that
is
the kind of thing people say. But I
mean
it as a prediction, not a comfort.

SEIKO

Based on what evidence?

JOSEPH

Based on the fact that we are here.
Both
of us. Against every statistical
probability
applied to two boys from Morocco and
Japan
at this institution. We have already
done
the hardest thing. The rest of it is
just
continuance.
Then footsteps. A voice, direct and
unsentimental:

YARA

(O.S.)

Excuse me. I saw what happened. Are
you
both alright?
She is standing three feet away,
looking at them
with the concern of someone who has
identified a situation and is
deciding what kind
of response is most useful. Not pity
— something
more practical. The concern of a
person who helps
because the situation objectively
requires help,
and because they have decided, at
some earlier
point in their life, that they are
the kind of
person who responds when something
requires
responding to.
YARA GORDON, 20. Tall, with an
athlete's ease of
movement — the ease of a body that
knows what it
can do from years of discovering it.
Her hair falls

past her shoulders, black. Her eyes:
a deep warm
blue that is currently doing exactly
what Joseph's
eyes do when he is thinking — going
precise and
clear, running analysis.
She sits across from them on the
bench's carved
edge. Not beside them. Across. The
arrangement of
someone who wants to see them fully.
She asks if they are physically hurt.
She listens
without interrupting.
Then:

YARA

He has been doing this since his
first
year. Brian McKenzie. His father
donated
the Alderton Building — the one on
the
south side of the Yard. Brian is
aware of
this. He uses it as a kind of pre-
existing
permission.

SEIKO

Has anyone reported him?

YARA

I reported him, for a friend, last
spring.
She had witnessed something. Two
weeks
after the report was filed, Brian had
a
conversation with someone in the
financial
aid office. Not formal. Just a
conversation.
Her award was reviewed the following
semester.

A beat. The fountain behind them
makes its small
sound.

YARA

I tell you this not to discourage
you. I
tell you so you understand the exact
shape
of what you are working with.
Knowledge
of the geometry is more useful than
optimism about it.
She extends her hand.

YARA

I am Yara Gordon. Second year. Trauma
cognition and behavioral
neuroscience.

JOSEPH

Joseph Al-Mithali. Theoretical
physics.
First year. My friends call me Joseph
the Ideal. It is a nickname from
competitions. I know how it sounds.

YARA

(without inflation – just simple,
direct, accurate)
I like it. It sounds like something
someone gave you because they
believed
it was true. Is it?
A beat.

JOSEPH

I am working on it.
She smiles. Brief, genuine – the
smile of someone
who has received the correct answer
and knows it.

YARA

That is the right answer. If you had
said

yes I would have been skeptical. If
you
had deflected I would have been
disappointed.
Seiko introduces himself. She listens
to him with
the full attention she gives
everything, which is
the first thing she will give you and
the most
important thing she has to give.
She tells them about the orientation
party that
evening. She takes a slip of paper
from her bag
and writes her number in clean script
– the
handwriting of someone who makes
precise marks.
She hands it to Joseph.

YARA

If anything happens, contact me.
Welcome
to the real Harvard. Brian is a
sponsored
exhibit. The actual institution is
something else.
She waves once. She walks west,
toward the
science buildings.
Joseph and Seiko remain on the bench.
Complete silence for seven seconds.

SEIKO

(voice slightly wondering)
The most directly kind person we have
encountered at this institution came
to
us without being asked. Of her own
decision. Having witnessed something
and
decided that a response was required.
Joseph looks at the paper in his
hand. Her number.
the handwriting.

He smiles for the first time since
the gate.

JOSEPH

Yes. I think today is not entirely
lost.

SEQUENCE FOUR: THE PARTY — AND ITS AFTERMATH

INT. HARVARD GREAT HALL — EVENING

The Great Hall: vaulted ceilings, crystal
chandeliers throwing warm fractured light across
the faces of a hundred portraits. Distinguished
alumni looking down on the current generation
with the dignified neutrality of people who
have achieved enough to be past judgment.
Music at a volume designed to permit conversation.
the social geometry of the first weeks
at a selective institution: the already-established
clusters, the hopeful adjacencies, the tentative
perimeters of people not yet sure which of the
available stories about themselves is correct.
Yara finds them before they find her. She comes
through the crowd with EMILY CHEN, 20 — quick-
eyed, quick-smiled, the kind of person who finds
things funny like people who pay
attention — and SARAH OSEI, 20 — precisely
composed, the equanimity of someone who has
navigated every social context and discovered that
equanimity is more useful than performance.
They talk. It is good. Seiko opens up
because Emily makes him laugh — the
surprised laugh of someone caught off-guard by

something funnier than anticipated, the laugh that functions as a reveal of a truer self beneath the organized exterior.

Joseph and Yara talk about physics and trauma cognition and discover they have both read the same book about mirror neurons and arrived at entirely different conclusions about chapter seven. They argue about it with the pleasure of people who find disagreement interesting rather than threatening.

The food is good. The portraits look on.

Then Brian McKenzie comes across the room.

He comes with his four friends, all in the same jackets. He has a large cup of red punch. He has spotted them from across the room – Joseph sees him first and has time to think: not now. But not now has never been a thing Joseph gets to decide.

BRIAN

(stopping in front of them –
easy, conversational, performing
casual the way an actor performs
casual, which is not casual at all)
Well. Scholarship kids made it to the
party. Open-door policy. I respect
it.

YARA

(flat, precise, not asking)
Brian. Don't.

BRIAN

(to his friends)
I am simply noting the inclusive
atmosphere. Making the newcomers feel
welcome. Is that not a Harvard value?
He looks at Joseph with the
appreciating eye of

a collector identifying a specimen.

BRIAN

Al-Mithali. Joseph. That right?
Theoretical
physics. First year. Full
scholarship. That
is.. impressive, actually. It is. You
have
to be good to earn that kind of
money, don't you? Someone's
money. It's
all someone's money in the end.
Joseph notices it then.
One of Brian's friends. Phone
held low at his side.
The recording indicator: a tiny red
dot. Joseph
understands immediately what is being
assembled.
He has approximately four seconds.
He thinks: any reaction. Any reaction
at all is the
footage. Whatever I do now, if I
react, that is
the film. The film will show a
foreign student
losing control in the Harvard Great
Hall, and
whatever precedes it will be
incidental. The kind
of context that requires explanation.
The kind of
explanation that is rarely
sufficient.
Four seconds. He makes the
calculation.
He decides: nothing.
Brian tips his cup.
It is deliberate. Unhurried. The
movement of
someone who has run the social
arithmetic, confirmed
the audience, and confirmed that the
performance
will be permitted. The red punch
comes out in a

slow, deliberate arc and hits
Joseph's shirt,
his collar, his face. Cold and
viscous and red.
Soaking through immediately.
CLOSE ON: Joseph's face.
The red liquid drips from the cracked
lens of his
glasses.
He stands still.
This is the hardest thing he has ever
done. Harder
than the competitions. Harder than
the application.
Harder than the goodbye at the
Casablanca airport.
Standing still when everything in him
is organized
around doing something – this is the
hardest thing.
He stands still. The punch drips.
Brian laughs. Genuine, unself-
conscious. The laugh
of a person who has never once
doubted his right
to do anything.
The phone records.
Yara is already beside Joseph with
napkins – the
efficient fury of someone who is
extremely angry
and has decided anger is not the most
useful
available tool. She works
methodically. One of
Brian's friends pushes Seiko –
casual, technical,
deniable – and Seiko stands with one
shoulder
at a careful angle, not showing the
pain, not
showing anything.

YARA

(to Brian – quietly, the voice
of someone who is choosing precise
words carefully)

You need to leave now.

BRIAN

Am I making you uncomfortable? I thought this was supposed to be a diverse environment. I am just enjoying the diversity.

JOSEPH

(to Seiko, quietly)

Let us go.

They walk out. Joseph hears the music resume behind them before they have reached the door.

INT. JOSEPH'S DORM APARTMENT — NIGHT

The apartment: small, warm, the quality of warmth that exists in spaces that are new but are being made into something.

Seiko sits on the sofa. He cries. Quietly, with the restraint of someone who has been taught that crying in front of others imposes on them, who is crying anyway because restraint has met its limit and limits are real things.

Joseph has changed his shirt. He stands at the window and feels the wish — the wish of people who have been made small: to be big enough just once. To have power proportionate to the injustice. To be, for one moment, the person holding the cup instead of wearing what was in it.

He files the feeling. He does not yet know what he will do with it. He suspects that the doing-something-with-it will define the rest of his

life.

He is correct.

A knock.

INT. JOSEPH'S DORM — DOOR — CONTINUOUS

Yara is in the hallway.

She is still in her party clothes. A leather jacket over her shoulders — the jacket of someone who came prepared for colder air than she found. A plastic bag in her hand. She detoured from the Great Hall to a bakery that stays open late. She has been walking for twenty-three minutes. She looks at them. She does not ask if they are okay. She understands that the answer is no and that the question is therefore not the most useful tool in the available kit.

YARA
I brought food.

INT. JOSEPH'S DORM — LIVING ROOM — MOMENTS LATER

She sits in the small chair. Croissants. Pastries in elaborate shapes. A slice of cake with a thick layer of chocolate glaze.

She sets them on the coffee table. She looks at them both — direct and even.

YARA
In my first year, there was a group of girls from the same prep school. They did not speak to me directly. They spoke about me within my hearing. My clothes. My work-

study shift in the library. My
address in
Cambridge. They were precise about it
—
not shouting, not dramatic. Very
quiet.
Very specific. For four months, every
time
I was near them, something was taken
from
me. I cannot tell you exactly what.
But
it was real, and it was mine, and
they
took pieces of it every time.

SEIKO
(from the sofa, quietly)
What changed?

YARA
I decided that being here — the
actual
fact of being here, what I had done
to get
here, what my parents had done, what
I
would do with it — that being here
was
larger than being made to feel like I
did not belong here. Not that the
treatment stopped mattering. It still
mattered. It matters now. But I
decided
it did not get to determine anything
about me. It could exist. I could
also
exist. And I would keep going. And
eventually I would be more than it
was.
She looks at them both. Level.
Direct.

YARA
You deserve to be here. This is not a
comfort I am offering. It is a fact I
know because I know what it takes to

be here without the building with
your
father's name on it. I know what
it
costs. You paid it. You are here.
A beat. Joseph looks at her.

JOSEPH

Why do you do this? You do not know
us.
You left a party to bring pastries to
strangers.

YARA

Because I know what it looked like
from
across that room when it happened.
And
I know what I would have wanted
someone
to do. And I know that no one did it
the first time it happened to me. And
I have decided not to be the kind of
person who knows something would have
helped and chooses not to do it.
She takes a croissant.

YARA

Also, the pastries are good. The
bakery on Mass Avenue. Remember it.
They eat.
The evening contracts around them
into something
manageable – three people in a small
apartment
with good pastries and the warmth of
people who are being honest with each
other,
which is rarer than it should be and
more
valuable than almost anything else
available.
CLOSE ON Joseph's face as he
listens to Yara speak.
Something is being recognized.
Something he didn't

know he was looking for. Not a
championship. Not
a score. This: three people in a
room, fed, honest,
still here.
The clock on the wall: 10:23 P.M.
The camera PULLS OUT slowly from the
apartment
window. The warm light inside. The
three of them.
Cambridge outside, continuing.
Something is about to happen.
Something that has been building, in
multiple
dimensions simultaneously, toward
this exact
configuration of people in this exact
apartment
at this exact moment, because the
thing that
is coming will need exactly these
people,
exactly this trust, exactly this
combination
of what they can each do.
But none of them know that yet.
The clock reads 10:23.
At 10:47, the sky will change.

ACT TWO

THE VORTEX

SEQUENCE FIVE: THE OPENING OF THE SKY

INT. JOSEPH'S DORM APARTMENT — 10:47 P.M.

Seiko is telling Yara about a computational topology paper that argues for the topological equivalence of multidimensional information spaces. Joseph is on his third pastry, which is a personal record. Something is almost comfortable.

Then.

Joseph's pen stops moving.

He does not register it consciously at first. The pen simply lifts from the paper and stays lifted and he is not aware that it has lifted because his attention has been pulled — not to a sound, not to a sight, but to a change in the quality of the air itself.

A pressure change.

Subtle as the atmospheric shift in the seconds before a storm too distant to see. the feeling of something enormous moving in the dark, approaching.

JOSEPH

Do you feel that?
They look at him. Then they look at
the window.
The sky over Boston has changed
color.
Not the orange of light pollution.
Not the normal

amber of a northeastern American city
at night.
Something else. Something that
appears to be
generated from inside the atmosphere
rather than
reflecting off it — as if the sky
itself has
begun to emit frequencies it was not
previously
equipped to emit.
Deep violet at the edges of the
clouds. Cycling
inward through electric blue. Through
a sharp,
acidic green that has no natural
precedent —
not in weather, not in any auroral
phenomenon
either of them has studied. The
colors move with
a quality that is almost biological.
The way a
wound breathes. The way something
living changes
when it is being acted upon by
something that
should not be acting upon it.

SEIKO

(flat, precise, frightened)
That is not a weather event.
He already has his phone out. He is
cross-
referencing the National Weather
Service, MIT's
atmospheric monitoring systems, and
three
independent meteorological databases
simultaneously.

SEIKO

There is no storm system within six
hundred
kilometers. There is no ionospheric
disturbance in any monitored
frequency.

There is no—
The window shatters.
Not from wind. Not from pressure. It
simply breaks
outward — every pane simultaneously —
and what
comes through is not wind but a
FORCE: directional,
specific, aimed precisely upward and
inward, a
vector that has no natural
equivalent.
The papers on Joseph's desk lift
horizontally.
Books shear from shelves. The coffee
table moves
three feet without touching the
floor.
The photograph on the wall — his
family, pinned
with four strips of masking tape —
begins to lift.

JOSEPH CROSSES THE ROOM.
He catches it. One hand. He catches
his family
mid-air and presses them to his
chest.
Through the broken window, through
the void where
glass was: THE VORTEX.
It is visible above Cambridge now. A
spiral of
absolute darkness at its center — not
the darkness
of night, which has texture and
depth, but the
darkness of absence — while its outer
rim burns
with the impossible colors: violet-
green-electric
blue cycling through frequencies that
do not exist
in the natural spectrum.
Approximately three hundred meters in
diameter.

Spinning at a speed that produces a
sound below
the threshold of hearing – a
frequency felt not in
the ears but in the chest and the
teeth and the
base of the skull. A sound like
something that
has been waiting.
WIDE: Cambridge below the vortex. The
Charles
River catching the unnatural light.
Harvard's
brick towers. The iron gate with
VERITAS above it,
illuminated in wrong colors.
The pull increases.
SEIKO has both hands on the
doorframe. His feet
are off the floor. His arms are fully
extended.
His glasses are pushed sideways by
the wind. He
holds for four seconds – Joseph will
count these
later, alone, in a different
dimension, and feel
the counting as a kind of grief. Four
seconds.
Longer than should be possible for a
person
Seiko's size holding against a
force of that
magnitude.
Then his grip fails.
Seiko goes through the broken window
without a
sound – rising into the Cambridge
night, rising
toward the vortex, rising away from
everything
he packed twelve containers of
oatmeal for.

JOSEPH

SEIKO!

He lunges. His fingers close on
nothing but the
air where Seiko was.
YARA is already moving – but not
away. This is
the thing about Yara that Joseph will
carry
with him for the rest of his life:
when things
go bad, she moves toward them. Always
toward.
The pull catches her from behind
while she is
moving forward, which means she goes
fighting.
Joseph catches her wrist. She grabs
his arm with
her other hand. For two seconds,
three, four –
she is level with him, her face
inches from his
face, her eyes wide and very present.
Not
panicked. The eyes of someone who is
completely
here, in an emergency, rather than
retreating from
it.
She says something. He cannot hear it
over the
infrasonic roar – the frequency has
climbed into
audible range now and it is enormous,
the sound
of something ancient turning. She is
saying
something. The shape of his name, or
the shape of
something directed at him.
Then the force takes her.
She is gone. Into the acid-green
Cambridge sky.
Joseph holds on for exactly as long
as he can.
Then something happens that is not a
decision –

more like the body's recognition
that the choice
between holding on and following the
people you
are holding on for is not actually a
choice at
all. That when the thing you are
holding on to
is gone, what remains of the holding
is not an
anchor but a tether.
He rises off the floor.
Through the broken window.
Into the Cambridge sky.
WIDE: The vortex consuming the city.
The Charles
River disappearing. The brick towers
of Harvard
swallowed into the spiral. The iron
gate – VERITAS
– swallowed last, as if the universe
is making a
point about truth.
Then: darkness. Total. Absolute.

SEQUENCE SIX: THE CENTER OF EVERYTHING

INT./EXT. THE VORTEX – THE CENTER – TIMELESS

At the vortex's exact center, something happens
that exists outside the physics Joseph has been
studying for five years. Not because physics is
wrong – because what is happening is not entirely
observable from within the event.

Every atom of him separates from every other atom.
The separation is not painful. It is total. A
dissolution so thorough it approaches the peaceful,
the way an equation achieves peace when it reaches
its final simplest form.

In the dissolution, he sees.

THE SCORE transforms entirely — Hans Zimmer's orchestral framework colliding with Gnawa rhythms at impossible velocity, the sound of something ancient and something cosmic meeting at a point that should not exist and producing a tone that has never been heard before and will never be heard again.

VISUAL: What follows cannot be rendered in ordinary cinematography. We use something else.

BRANCHING PATHS — thousands of possible futures, each one a decision point, each one a consequence. They appear not as images but as feelings: the specific feeling of each version of the next three years, compressed into a fraction of a second.

In some: Joseph falls into void and is lost. Not dead — lost. the horror of being lost rather than destroyed.

In some: he returns to Earth changed in the wrong direction. The power without the purpose. The light without the warmth. In these futures, the battle at Antarctica is won but the world it produces is not worth what it cost.

In some: he returns without change and the war is lost because the war required something from him specifically, something that had to be forged in the dissolution, and without the forging, the metal is not strong enough.

And in one specific branch — one among thousands — he becomes what is required. Not what he chose.

Not what he would have chosen if a menu had been offered. What the situation requires of a person positioned at the structural center of a multiverse approaching catastrophic failure, who has been sent through its heart to emerge changed in the direction the multiverse needs.

He has three seconds to understand this.

Three seconds in which the dissolution shows him not a vision of the future but a feeling of it: the weight of what is coming. the gravity of a responsibility he did not ask for and which the mathematics of the situation indicate he is the only person equipped to carry. Three seconds in which he makes the only choice available: to carry it.

Then the dissolution ends.

He falls.

But not into Cambridge.

SMASH CUT TO:

ACT THREE

THE AMAZING WORLD

SEQUENCE SEVEN: ELMORE

EXT. ELMORE — RAINBOW ROAD — DAY (ANIMATED DIMENSION)

He does not hit the ground. Or rather: he hits something that has the properties of ground — the smell of grass, the yielding texture of turf, a surface that yields and then supports — but it is the wrong color.

Not the green of real grass. The green of an idea of grass. The green a child uses when they pick up a crayon and draw the world as they understand it should look: saturated, certain, committed to its own greenness in a way that actual grass never is.

Joseph lies on his back.

Above him: a sky that is the blue of a first drawing of sky. Not sky. The concept of sky. Clouds that are perfect spheres of white, arranged at intervals that suggest a decision rather than weather. The sun: a yellow circle in the upper-right corner of the composition, because that is where suns go.

Joseph looks at his hands.

CLEAR EDGES. A contour line that exists in drawings rather than nature — the precise dark boundary of a cartoon self, making him the flattest he has ever been and the most outlined.

He is still himself in every verifiable way.
But he has been translated. Rendered. Simplified
into the vocabulary of this world.
He sits up.

JOSEPH
(to himself, quietly)
Seiko.
SEIKO, five feet to his left, is
sitting up with
the expression of someone running a
precise
systems diagnostic on unexpected
hardware. He
turns his cartoon hands over. His
glasses, in
this dimension, are somehow larger
than they
were in the real world. The green bag
has made
the crossing with him. He examines
it. He examines
his hands. He examines the sky.

SEIKO
(after careful internal
analysis)
We appear to be cartoons.

JOSEPH
We appear to be.

YARA
(to Joseph's right, opening
her eyes to the too-blue sky,
turning her simplified hands
over once with the pragmatism
of someone who has decided that
the useful response to the
impossible is data-gathering)
We need information. What is our
location?
On the corner: a street sign in
cheerful rounded

letters. RAINBOW ROAD. Below it:
WELCOME TO
ELMORE — THE MOST AMAZING TOWN IN THE
WORLD!

Joseph feels the recognition land in
his chest
like a key finding a lock that has
been waiting
for it.

ELMORE.

The setting of a British-American
animated
television series he watched as a
child in
Casablanca with Nadia. Saturday
mornings on
his father's laptop, under a
blanket, Nadia
beside him eating cereal with the
focus of a
person who takes her cartoons
seriously. He had
been fourteen — technically too old
for this by
every social measure — and had
watched anyway
because Nadia laughed so hard at the
cooking
episode that she fell off the couch
and kept
laughing from the floor.
He had thought: this is worth paying
attention to.
He files: I am inside a television
program I
watched with my sister. This is an
impossible
thing that is currently happening. It
will be
addressed through empirical tools.

JOSEPH

This is Elmore. It is — it was a
television
show. In our world. The Amazing World
of

Gumball. British-American animated series.
I watched it with my sister.

YARA
You are telling me we have crossed into
an animated television universe.

JOSEPH
Yes.

YARA
(a beat — the beat of someone integrating information that conflicts with every available prior)
Alright. Then we need to find someone who knows this world from the inside.

JOSEPH
I know who we need to find.

YARA
There is a cartoon cat running toward us.
Rounding the corner with the body language of concentrated panic: a BLUE CAT, bipedal, approximately four feet tall, brown pants, red sneakers, enormous expressive eyes currently at approximately three times their resting size.
Behind him: an ORANGE FISH with legs, keeping pace with the loyalty of someone who has learned not to question what he is running from and to simply run with it.

GUMBALL
(running past them at full speed)
DARWIN! REAL HUMANS! IN ELMORE! FROM

THE REAL — DARWIN THEY HAVE ACTUAL
PORES—

DARWIN
(running after)

GUMBALL I CAN SEE THAT I DO NOT KNOW
WHAT TO DO—

GUMBALL
DO WE RUN? DO WE GREET THEM? DO WE—

DARWIN
THEY ARE LOOKING AT US—

GUMBALL
I KNOW DARWIN I KNOW—
They round the next corner and
disappear,
still completely unresolved.
Silence.

SEIKO
(watching the corner where
they disappeared)
Were those—

JOSEPH
That was Gumball Watterson and Darwin
Watterson. Yes.

SEIKO
(processing)
We are inside a cartoon television
universe and we just ran into its
main characters.

JOSEPH
We need to find them.

EXT. WATTERSON HOUSE — RAINBOW ROAD — MOMENTS LATER

The house: light blue, two stories, the
cheerful geometry of an animated family home.
The mailbox: WATTERSONS. A garden of too-round

bushes. A car in the driveway that appears to be made of approximately forty percent nostalgia and sixty percent structural optimism. From inside: an extremely audible whispered conference.

GUMBALL

(stage whisper)

Okay. Okay. If we don't move they'll think no one's home.

DARWIN

(stage whisper)

Gumball. They watched us run here.

GUMBALL

I know that.

DARWIN

So they know someone's home.

GUMBALL

Darwin I am aware. I am attempting to manifest a different version of reality through strategic stillness. It is not working. Joseph knocks. Silence. The particular silence of people who are being still and very aware that the stillness is not working.

JOSEPH

Gumball. My name is Joseph Al-Mithali.

I am from the real world. I arrived here through a dimensional vortex along with two of my friends. We need information and we need help and I believe you may have both. Silence.

GUMBALL

(O.S., suspicious but interested –
the interests winning over the
suspicion because it is more
interesting)
How do I know you’re actually
from the
real world? You could be some kind of
elaborate Elmore-based scam.

JOSEPH

In the real world, you are a
television
show. I watched it as a child in
Casablanca, Morocco, with my sister.
She was eight years old. She loved
the
episode where you tried to cook
dinner
for your family and burned everything
in a sequence of escalating
disasters.
She laughed so hard at the microwave
scene that she fell off the couch.
She
kept laughing from the floor. She did
not get back on the couch. She
watched
the rest of the episode from the
floor
because she thought it was funnier
from there.
A long pause.

GUMBALL

(O.S.)

Was it good? The show. Do people like
it? In the real world?

JOSEPH

My sister made me watch all of it.
She was right. It is good.
The door opens two inches. One
enormous cartoon
eye in the gap.

GUMBALL

Come in. I have many questions.

INT. WATTERSON HOUSE — LIVING ROOM — CONTINUOUS

The living room: warm with the chaos
of a family that loves each other with more
enthusiasm than organizational discipline.
A drawing on the refrigerator — Darwin's,
careful and precise; Gumball's, confident
and wrong in interesting ways that suggest
the wrongness is itself a form of expression.
A couch that has seen many arguments and
reconciliations and is neutral about both.
GUMBALL WATTERSON, 12, blue cartoon cat with
enormous eyes that express everything at full
volume. He is currently expressing: extreme
fascination barely managing extreme wariness.
DARWIN WATTERSON, 12, orange fish with legs
that have given him a life he considers to be
largely wonderful and occasionally terrifying.
He watches the real-world visitors with the
attentiveness of someone used to things that
begin plausibly and become very strange very
quickly.
Gumball is staring at Joseph's arm.

GUMBALL

Your skin has texture. I can see it
from
here. Like.. your skin is telling a
whole
story just by existing. Does that
happen
all the time? Is it tiring?

JOSEPH

For us it is normal. We do not
generally
find it tiring.

GUMBALL

(to Darwin, awed)

Darwin, his skin is doing things
constantly and he is completely
unbothered
by it.

DARWIN

(also slightly awed)

He is three-dimensional in a way that
feels excessive. Like he has more
depth
than the situation strictly requires.
Joseph explains. He goes through the
events in
their exact order – the vortex, the
dimensional
crossing, the need for information
about what
is happening to the barriers between
worlds.
Gumball listens with increasing
seriousness –
his enormous eyes tracking each piece
of
information and filing it with more
precision
than his expression suggests. Darwin
listens
with the attentiveness of someone who
grew up
being a fish with legs in a world
with a bear
principal and a dragon teacher and
has therefore
developed excellent filters for
distinguishing
between the merely strange and the
actually
alarming.

DARWIN

(when Joseph finishes)
The barriers between worlds have been
thinning. We have been noticing it
for
months. Small glitches – objects
appearing
in Elmore that don't belong
here. People
seeing things at the edges of the
world
that the world doesn't usually
show. Last
week, Dad walked through a door and
came
out in what appeared to be a
convenience
store from a different dimensional
layer.
He bought chips and came home. But
still.

JOSEPH

The barriers are under stress.
Someone
is applying pressure to them from
outside.

DARWIN

Not random stress. Directed.
That's the
part that we couldn't explain –
it doesn't
behave like natural dimensional
friction.
It behaves like something with
intent.
Then the room FLICKERS.
Subtle at first – a shimmer in the
color
saturation, like a screen refreshing
at the
wrong rate. Then NUMBERS appear:
floating
above the coffee table in three-
dimensional
space, rows of binary code scrolling
downward

in terminal green, casting thin
emerald light
across their faces.
The scaffolding of the world.
Made visible.

SEIKO

(already reaching toward the
floating code with the expression
of someone who has been handed
his exact area of expertise
in physical form)
That is the underlying code
structure.
This world is built on code.
Something
is reading it. Something external is
accessing the substrate.

JOSEPH

Or rewriting it.
The house SHAKES. Not an earthquake —
a digital
shake, the shake of something that
exists as
data experiencing a write error. The
furniture
flickers, appearing and disappearing
in bursts
of static. The building across the
street
becomes an exact copy of itself
rotated ninety
degrees for three seconds and then
snaps back.

DARWIN

(quietly, watching the
walls flicker)
World crash. The substrate is
destabilizing. We have maybe two,
three minutes before the local
instance—
A CRACK opens in the center of the
living room.
Not in the floor. Not in the wall. In
the air

itself — a vertical tear, three-dimensional,
running floor to ceiling along a line
of pure
white light that does not illuminate
so much
as assert: I exist. I am a door.
Gumball stares at it.
Then he looks at Darwin.
Darwin looks at the refrigerator — at
his
careful drawings and Gumball's
wrong-in-
interesting-ways drawings and the
photo of
their family underneath.

DARWIN

(quietly)
If the world crashes, everything
goes.

JOSEPH

Not if we go now.
A beat. Darwin nods. Small. Definite.
Gumball picks up a yellow mug from
the coffee
table. Chipped on one side, the
handle
slightly off-center from a repair
that was
done with more care than skill. The
kind of
object that has meaning not from
what it is but from what it has been
present
for. Every morning that mattered.
Every
argument that resolved. Every
Saturday.
He puts it in his pocket.
He looks at the dimensional crack.

GUMBALL

(with the deliberate
calm of someone who is extremely
not calm and has decided to act

calm anyway because the situation
is what it is)
Yes. We are going to walk through the
interdimensional crack in our living
room.
This is completely fine. Everything
about
this is completely fine.
He adds, quieter, to the room, to his
house, to
the Saturday mornings and the
drawings on the
refrigerator:

GUMBALL
(barely audible)
We will come back.
The five of them move toward the
light.

ACT FOUR

THE WORLD THAT CHANGED WHILE THEY
WERE GONE

SEQUENCE EIGHT: RETURN TO A BROKEN EARTH

EXT. SOUTH BOSTON — DAY — THREE DAYS LATER

They fall through color.

Not darkness. Not light. Pure undifferentiated color cycling through frequencies that bypass the optical system entirely and land somewhere below consciousness — the visual equivalent of a sound felt in the chest rather than heard by the ear.

Then: stone.

The absolute specificity of real gravity.

The smell of smoke.

Joseph hits real pavement. He pushes himself up and looks at his hands: detailed, three-dimensional, every familiar scar and callus restored. Every line of him present.

He looks at Gumball and Darwin.

They are three-dimensional.

Still entirely themselves — still a blue cat and an orange fish — but rendered now in full physical solidity. Their cartoon forms translated into matter with the fidelity of a good copy: every detail correct, every proportion preserved, but given weight and depth and the particular

quality of presence that belongs to things
that actually occupy space.

Gumball presses his hand against the pavement.

Slowly. Then faster. He presses it hard.

GUMBALL

(with the awe of someone
discovering a new fundamental
property of existence)
Everything has texture. Everything.
The
ground has a different texture than
the
pavement and the pavement has a
different
texture than that wall and everything
is telling you what it is all the
time
constantly.

DARWIN

(thoughtfully, turning his
physical hand over)
I think that would become
overwhelming
after a while.

GUMBALL

Darwin, I have been three-dimensional
for thirty seconds and I am already
overwhelmed. It is incredible.
The sky above Boston: the uneasy
orange of a
sky that has been exposed to
something it was
not built to receive and has not
recovered. The
neighborhood — a residential park in
South Boston
— shows the damage of a force
absorbed
and survived: broken windows in
apartment buildings,
cars at diagonal angles in the street
as if their

drivers received simultaneous urgent
news and left
without parking. A thin continuous
smoke from
somewhere northeast. The smell of
something
electrical and wrong.
A MAN running across the park
redirects sharply
when he sees them – when he sees
Gumball and Darwin – and has the
brief expression
of someone encountering the
impossible, which
in this context is information about
how bad
things have become.

RUNNING MAN
(barely slowing)
You need to get underground. The
shelters
on Tremont. Go now.
Joseph catches his arm.

JOSEPH
What happened? When did it start?

RUNNING MAN
Three days ago. Things came through
the
sky. Not just here – everywhere.
London,
Tokyo, Sydney, all of it. Things that
shouldn't exist outside of – I
don't
know. Wherever they come from. The
army
has been – it's not working.
None of
it is working.
He looks at the smoke. the look of a
person who has been watching
something for three
days and has run out of room to put
what he has
seen.

He runs.

SEIKO

(already processing)

Three days. An hour in Elmore was approximately seventy-two real-world hours. The energy released by the vortex

fractured the dimensional barriers simultaneously across all surveyed layers.

Not just Elmore — every barrier between

every world, every dimension, every narrative reality.

YARA

(looking at the smoke, at the sky — not with fear but with the focused assessment of someone who processes threat by immediately evaluating it)
Every villain came through.

GUMBALL

(quietly, staring at the damaged city)

And every hero. If the barriers went down both ways.. the heroes in their worlds — they've been pressing against

the boundaries. If someone opened all the doors—

He looks at Joseph with the expression of someone who has just made a connection and is unsure whether to say it.

GUMBALL

Joseph. You called us through. In Elmore.

The dimensional crack appeared because

you were there. What if you could do that here? What if you could call all of them?

Joseph feels something shift in him.
The
structural change – the thing left by
the
dissolution in the vortex, the thing
that
has been building since Cambridge –
responds
to Gumball's words the way a
compass responds
to north.
Not a new idea. The recognition of an
idea
that has been forming without
language.

JOSEPH

We need to see what we are dealing
with.
Then we act.
He starts walking. South. Toward the
smoke.

YARA

(falling into step beside
him)
Joseph.

JOSEPH

Yes.

YARA

Whatever you are thinking – tell me
first. Don't go alone into
whatever
this is.
He looks at her.

JOSEPH

I was not going to go alone.

YARA

Good. Because alone is not a viable
strategy.

JOSEPH

(after a beat – honestly)

Alone was never a strategy I
considered.
You should know that about me.
They walk.

EXT. COPLEY SQUARE, BOSTON – DAY

COPLEY SQUARE has become the epicenter.

The PORTAL stands at the square's heart: a tear in the air thirty meters high and eighteen meters wide, its edges burning with colors the human visual system can register but cannot name – the colors of things from outside the knowable spectrum. Through it, for three days, the army has been coming.

Now it stands at full deployment. What arrived through the portal has deployed across the world – London, Tokyo, Shanghai, Cairo, Mumbai, Sydney, São Paulo – while its architects remain here, at the point of origin, at Copley Square, on a Tuesday in September, in the unhurried posture of entities that have all the time available because they have already won. Or believe they have.

THANOS stands at the portal's center.

He is not moving. He does not need to move.

He has the gravity of planets – not the metaphor but the physical reality: things in proximity to Thanos move in response to his mass, adjust their trajectories around him. He stands with the Infinity Gauntlet catching what remains of the afternoon light through the smoke, and the combination of his stillness and that light makes

him look carved.

He looks at the damaged city with the expression of someone examining something he has already decided about. Not cruelty. Something more precise than cruelty: the particular certainty of someone who has constructed an ideological framework and made peace with everything the framework requires.

THE JOKER sits on an overturned delivery truck, eating chips from a bag with the cheerful ease of someone attending an event he is genuinely enjoying. His makeup is fresh – the white and red and black precise, recently applied – which is somehow more disturbing than if it had been smeared. He watches the destroyed square with the happy attention of a connoisseur.

DARKSEID stands on the steps of the Boston Public Library. He is not doing anything. He does not need to do anything. His presence is itself an action – the action of demonstrating that presence alone is sufficient, that power at a certain magnitude does not require expression, only occupation.

Behind them, across the square, through the streets beyond: THE ARMY. Thousands. The CHITAUURI in formation – disciplined, mechanical, organized in the way of creatures whose entire existence has been subordinated to a will larger than themselves. DEMENTORS drifting in their particular horrible floating

pattern, the cold they produce arriving before they do. SAURON'S assembled forces from Mordor and beyond, the dark banner above them. And more. Things that came from no story Joseph recognizes. Things from the deep dimensions – the ones without names, without narratives, without heroes already organized against them. The ground beneath the portal: scorched in concentric rings, the stone blackened in a pattern that reflects not heat but something else, something that left a record of its passage.

EXT. COPLEY SQUARE – BEHIND OVERTURNED DELIVERY TRUCK

– CONTINUOUS

Joseph, Seiko, Yara, Gumball, and Darwin.

Behind the truck. Forty meters from the main enemy formation.

Joseph looks at the Infinity Gauntlet.

He looks at Darkseid on the library steps.

He looks at the portal – still cycling, still processing new arrivals from whatever coordination center directed this. From wherever someone sat and planned this, from the throne hall no one here has seen yet but which will become relevant very soon.

He looks at his hands.

The structural change is responding. Whatever the dissolution built in him – the frequency, the transmitter function, the capability that has

no precedent in any physics he has studied –
it is rising. Building. Recognizing the scale
of what is required and growing to meet it
the way fire grows when given the oxygen it
has been waiting for.

SEIKO

(reading multiple data streams,
his voice controlled and his
face controlled and his hands
not quite controlled, the
fingers making small precise
movements as he processes)
Worldwide deployment. London, Tokyo,
New
York, Sydney, Paris, Cairo, Mumbai,
Rio,
Shanghai, Johannesburg, Mexico City.
Every major population center
simultaneously. The timing is exact –
not approximately simultaneous.
Exactly.
To within fractions of a second.
He looks at Joseph over the screen.
The look
of someone who has reached a
conclusion and
needs it confirmed.

SEIKO

This was coordinated. Someone planned
this. Someone with knowledge of the
dimensional barriers, the capacity to
breach them simultaneously at global
scale, and an organizational
structure
capable of deploying across every
surveyed dimension in perfect unison.

JOSEPH

File it. We deal with the immediate
first. The architect later.

SEIKO

Yes. Though I would suggest that the

architect is the actual problem and
everything in front of us is—

JOSEPH

I know. File it.
He looks at the sky.

JOSEPH

The barriers went down both ways.
When
the vortex opened, it didn't
just
release what was on the other side.
It opened every door. Every hero in
every world — in every story, every
universe, every dimension — has been
pressing against those barriers their
entire existence. The barriers are
what
kept the stories separate. Now they
are gone. The heroes can come
through.
All of them. If someone can find a
frequency they all receive.

SEIKO

You want to transmit a distress
signal
across every dimension
simultaneously.
Using yourself as the transmitter.

JOSEPH

Yes.

YARA

(direct — assessing, not
objecting)
What does that cost you?
A pause.

JOSEPH

I do not know yet.

YARA

Then we need to think about—

JOSEPH

Yara. If there is another option, I would prefer it. If you can identify another option in the time we have, I am listening.
A long beat. Yara looks at the square. At the army. At the portal.

YARA

I cannot.

JOSEPH

Then this is what we have.
She looks at him. The assessment she makes in this look is the same assessment she has been making since the fountain bench – she is calculating not whether he is capable of this but whether he knows what he is doing, and she is arriving at the same answer she always arrives at with him: yes.

YARA

Then I am next to you while you do it.

GUMBALL

(quietly – not his usual register, the quieter register he uses when something matters)
Me too.

DARWIN

And me.

SEIKO

(with the precision of someone who is terrified and committed simultaneously)
There is nowhere else I would be.

Across the square, Thanos turns. He has sensed something change — not in the geography but in the temperature of intention. He looks at the delivery truck. He cannot see them. But he knows something is there. Something that does not feel like the frightened humans he has been encountering. Something that feels different.

THANOS

(to the assembled army — resonant, geological, the voice of someone who has the patience of continents) Something is watching us. THE JOKER stops eating his chips. He looks up. He smiles, slightly. The smile of someone who finds unexpected developments more interesting than expected ones. Joseph steps out from behind the truck.

SEQUENCE NINE: THE CALL

EXT. COPLEY SQUARE — CENTER — CONTINUOUS

Joseph walks into the open space between the delivery truck and Thanos's army. He walks at a normal pace. Not performing bravery — bravery performed is theater, and this is not theater. He walks the way he walks: with the particular alertness of someone paying attention to more things than most people notice. THANOS turns. The enormous head. The ancient eyes. They find

Joseph – this young man, slightly built, in a blue plaid shirt with dried red punch stains that the chaos of the last twenty-four hours has rendered entirely irrelevant – and they assess.

THANOS

(not cruel – analytical, almost interested, which is in many ways worse than cruel)
One human being. Standing in the open,
alone, unarmed. Either very brave or very foolish. The distance between those
two is usually discovered in the aftermath.
Joseph does not respond. He closes his eyes.
He reaches for the structural change inside him.
The thing built in the dissolution.
The
transmitter that was forged in the heart of
the vortex when every atom of him was separated
from every other atom and something was inserted
into the architecture of the separation – a
frequency, a capability, a channel that connects
him to something larger than himself and through
which something larger than himself can be
directed.
He finds it immediately. The way you find a
familiar switch in a dark room you know well
by feel: not by searching but by knowing exactly
where it is.

He thinks about his father in the
kitchen at
four-thirty in the morning making
sandwiches in
the dark. He thinks about what it
looked like
from the hallway when he was twelve
years old:
the lamplight, the economy of
movement, the care
applied to things that did not need
care but
received it anyway.
He thinks about seven billion people.
Right now.
In basements and shelters and
under their beds in cities across
this planet,
listening to sounds they do not
understand and
waiting for them to stop. Seven
billion people
who have never heard of a multiverse
war, who
did not agree to participate in this
conflict,
who are frightened in the ordinary
human way of people who do not have
armor or
magic or a dimensional signal.
He thinks about the wish he made in
his dorm
apartment, standing at the window
with red punch
drying on his shirt. To be big enough
just once.
To have power proportionate to the
injustice.
He thinks: this is the moment. This
is what
the wish was for.
The warmth begins in his palms. Moves
up his
forearms. Into his chest.
He opens his eyes.

THE LIGHT.

It emerges from his skin not as
illumination
but as consequence – the visible
result of
something that is primarily something
else.
Golden-white, rising from him the way
heat
rises from asphalt: not a spotlight,
not a
beam, but a radiation. An emanation.
The visible
evidence of a frequency being
broadcast.
A frequency that travels faster than
light.
A frequency that does not move
through space
but through the structural fabric
that connects
every space – every story, every
universe, every
dimension, every world in which
someone built
a hero because they needed to believe
that
something powerful could also be
good.
CLOSE ON: Darkseid. Something changes
in his
expression. Not fear – the adjustment
of an
entity that has updated its
assessment of the
situation. The recalibration of a
being that
has encountered a variable it did not
account for.
The Joker stands up from his truck.
He drops
his chips. He looks at Joseph with
the bright
attention of someone who finds the
unexpected
delightful.

JOKER

(quietly, to himself)
Oh. That's new.
Above Copley Square, the sky begins
to open.
Not the corrupt portals – not the
tears and
the burning wrong colors and the
darkness that
smells of absence. Something else
entirely.
RECTANGULAR SHAPES OF LIGHT appearing
in the
sky above Boston. Amber and gold and
warm –
the warm gold of morning arriving,
of doors opening. They appear one by
one.
Then three at once. Then a dozen.
Then too
many to count.
Each one a door. Each one a world.
Through each one, light falls onto
the damaged
city below as if it has been waiting
on the
other side of those barriers for a
long
time and is glad – genuinely glad –
to be
let through.

SEQUENCE TEN: THE HEROES ARRIVE

EXT. COPLEY SQUARE – THE GOLDEN DOORS – CONTINUOUS

BATMAN comes first.

He comes from the nearest door, descending at
the angle that is not a fall and not quite a
jump but the controlled directional movement
of someone who has spent thirty years studying
the geometry of arrival. He lands on the roof
of the overturned delivery truck without a sound
– black, still, the cape settling around him

with the finality of a decision.

He takes in the situation with the rapid professional economy of someone for whom assessment and response are a single continuous process. The portal. The army. The deployed formations across the city. Thanos. Darkseid. The Joker.

And Joseph, in the center of the square, golden light fading from his hands.

BATMAN
(to Joseph – direct, no preamble)
You opened these doors.

JOSEPH
Yes.

BATMAN
How?

JOSEPH
I do not have a complete explanation yet.
Batman looks at him. The long look that is his version of trust: not warmth, not reassurance, but the serious assessment of someone who measures people by the quality of their honesty under pressure.

BATMAN
Acceptable answer. We need a tactical structure before the next wave. Can you build one?

JOSEPH
You are better at tactical structures than I am.

Something shifts in Batman's
expression. The
small shift of a person who has been
told
something honest that most people
would not
say.

BATMAN

Yes. I am. Keep doing what
you're doing.
Tactical is mine.
IRON MAN – the Mark LXXXVII,
descending from
high altitude in a controlled burn,
faceplate
opening on approach to show Tony
Stark's face.
The face of a man who has looked at
this
situation, run every probability he
has available,
and found the version where survival
is achievable.

TONY STARK

FRIDAY, full tactical overlay.
(to Batman)
Lead or follow?

BATMAN

Lead tactical. You have air
superiority.

TONY STARK

Works for me.
(looking at Joseph)
You're the kid who opened the
doors?

JOSEPH

Yes.

TONY STARK

(assessing him – quickly, completely,
the assessment Tony Stark makes
in three seconds that most people

need three hours for)
Okay. You're with us.
(to Batman)
He's with us.

BATMAN
He was already with us.

TONY STARK
I'm confirming it.

BATMAN
It didn't need confirming.

TONY STARK
I like confirming things. It's a
personal—
SUPERMAN descends.
Vertically. From altitude. Without
theater,
without arc — straight down, the
arrival of
something that has decided to be
here. He lands
fifteen meters from Thanos. the
combination of him — blue and red,
the cape
in the October air, the absolute
stillness of
someone who has the capacity for
enormous
force and is currently choosing not
to use it —
has an effect on the assembled armies
that is
visible as a ripple passing through
them.
A ripple of recalculation.
Thanos takes a half step back.
He corrects it immediately. Returns
to his
position. His face does not change.
But the half step happened.
THOR arrives with lightning — a
column of it
descending from the sky, entirely
unnecessary

for his landing and entirely
deliberate as a
statement. He lands in the clearing
it makes,
Mjolnir in his right hand, his
expression the
expression of a man who has been
waiting for
a battle of this scale and finds the
waiting
is over.

THOR
(enormous, joyful)
TODAY IS A GOOD DAY!

TONY STARK
(over comm)
Thor. Inside voice.

THOR

I AM INSIDE BOSTON.

TONY STARK
That's not what inside voice—

THOR
IT IS A GOOD DAY, STARK!
WONDER WOMAN comes through her door
already in
motion — three Chitauri cleared
before the
word has registered that she has
arrived. She
lands in the space she has made and
looks at
the tactical situation with three
thousand years
of professional attention.
CAPTAIN AMERICA lands with his shield
— the
specific sound of vibranium on stone,
the
specific sound of something made to
receive

impact refusing to break. He takes
one
comprehensive look.

CAPTAIN AMERICA
Where do you need me?

BATMAN
East perimeter. Take whoever arrives
next.
HARRY, HERMIONE, and RON step through
the same
door together, wands already drawn.
Hermione
immediately begins a strategic
assessment,
communicating to Harry and Ron in
rapid clipped
sentences – the efficiency of someone
who prepares for every eventuality
and is
therefore never actually surprised by
any of
them.
GANDALF comes through walking. At his
usual pace,
as if the dimensional portal were a
perfectly
ordinary kind of door that happens to
be in an
unusual location. He stops. He
surveys the
situation with the patience of a
wizard who has
lived through the long dark of Moria
and still
managed to come back from the other
side of it.

GANDALF
(to no one in particular –
the philosophical
equanimity of someone who
has been in bad situations
before and noticed that they
eventually end)
Ah. One of these.

DOCTOR STRANGE steps through with the ease of someone for whom dimensional travel is professional rather than miraculous. He looks around.

DOCTOR STRANGE
Whose team am I on?

BATMAN
Mine.

DOCTOR STRANGE
Understood.
SPIDER-MAN swings through his portal without landing — uses the portal frame as a pivot and attaches to the library wall, upside down, surveying the square from above.

SPIDER-MAN
Hey! Big crowd! Is that actually Gandalf?

GANDALF
(not looking up)
It is.

SPIDER-MAN
Okay! Okay. That's incredible. I have questions but maybe later?

GANDALF
Later would be preferable.
LUKE SKYWALKER, green lightsaber already ignited. THE HULK, arriving with the sound and force of something that has decided subtlety is not the required tool. BLACK WIDOW and HAWKEYE,

same portal, moving in the tight
professional
formation of two people who have
worked together
long enough to share geometry.
And more.
BLACK PANTHER – T'Challa,
arriving with the
specific quiet dignity that makes the
armor
unnecessary and the armor
magnificent. He finds
Joseph immediately.
T'Challa
 (to Joseph)
Wakanda stands with you.

JOSEPH
(with the weight of that –
genuinely moved, trying not
to show all of it)
Thank you, T'Challa.
SCARLET WITCH, her powers already
manifesting –
the red energy of chaos magic rising
from her
hands as she steps through. Her
expression:
focused, resolved, the expression of
someone who
has been through enough that the next
impossible
thing is simply the next thing.
THE FLASH – Barry Allen – arrives at
speed,
decelerating from impossible to
merely fast
in about three meters, leaving a
trail of
lightning behind him.

FLASH
(slightly out of breath despite
superspeed, which is a Barry Allen
trait)
Okay! I got here from – the barriers

opened and I just — I ran through
and—

(looking around)
Is everyone else seeing a three-
dimensional cartoon fish?

DARWIN
(with complete dignity)
I am Darwin Watterson. Yes.

FLASH
Hi Darwin. Cool. Great. Totally fine.
JOHN WICK arrives in a manner that
requires no
announcement. He walks through his
portal with
the economy of movement of someone
who has
long since decided that announcing
yourself
is a performance for your enemies.
NEO and MORPHEUS step through
together. Neo's
expression: the calm of someone who
has made peace with the fact that
reality is
flexible and is prepared to
demonstrate this.
KEANU REEVES plays both of these
characters
across their respective doors, which
is either
a coincidence or a statement the
multiverse
is making about something.
ARAGORN, with Andúril catching the
gold light
from the open doors. LEGOLAS beside
him. GIMLI
beside Legolas, already looking for
the largest
concentration of enemies with the
focused pleasure of someone doing
what they
were made for.

GIMLI

(surveying the enemy forces)
Well. At least it is a proper number
of them.
TYRION LANNISTER steps through,
looking slightly
surprised at the portal but adapting
quickly –
he is, among other things, a person
who has
adapted quickly to things his entire
life.
ARYA STARK – sword already drawn, the
light
in her eyes the light of someone who
has been waiting for the moment when
the
skills are necessary.
JOEL and ELLIE, through the same
door,
scanning the area immediately with
the
survivor's assessment. Joel puts
a hand on
Ellie's shoulder: stay close.
PEDRO PASCAL arrives twice through
different
doors – once as Joel, once as Din
Djarin, the
Mandalorian, which is either the
multiverse
demonstrating something philosophical
about
identity or an extremely efficient
use of
one person.
The sky fills with golden light.
The light of every door open at once.
The light of every story sending what
it has.
THANOS looks at the assembled heroes
filling
his perimeter. He looks at the golden
doors
still opening in the sky above the
city. He
looks at the forces he deployed –
which were,

three minutes ago, sufficient – and
runs the
arithmetic.

THANOS

(to his assembled army –
geological, unhurried, the voice
of someone who has faced bad
arithmetic before and found
responses to it)
This changes the calculation.

JOKER

(from the truck, interested)
Changes it how? Are we – are we the
underdogs now? I have always wanted
to be an underdog. It is so much more
interesting from–

THANOS

Stop talking.

JOKER

Right. Yes. Sorry.
Joseph turns to the comm unit Tony
Stark has
already provided – pressed into his
hand at
some point in the last three minutes
without
his quite registering it, because
Tony Stark
moves faster than awareness.

JOSEPH

Batman. They are yours.

BATMAN

(over comm)

Move.
And the First Battle of the First
Multiverse
War begins in Copley Square on a
Tuesday
evening in September, under a sky
full of

golden doors that were opened by a
nineteen-
year-old boy from Casablanca who
watched a
cartoon with his sister on a laptop
under
a blanket and remembered it when it
mattered.

SEQUENCE ELEVEN: COPLEY SQUARE — THE BATTLE

EXT. COPLEY SQUARE — CONTINUOUS — RAPID SEQUENCE

The battle is enormous and specific.
Not the undifferentiated chaos of large-scale
conflict — not the blurs and explosions of
armies that are merely large. This has the
quality of many simultaneous individual
confrontations, each one its own story.
BATMAN coordinates from the roof of the library
building — he has the entire tactical map
inside his head, every position updated every
thirty seconds, every communication filtered
and redistributed through the comm system
that FRIDAY and his own AI are running jointly.

BATMAN

(over comm, continuously — the
controlled flow of a tactical
mind processing faster than
most people think)
Strange — the portal itself. Close it
or invert it.
Thor — the northeast formation. Now.
Wonder Woman — you have the center.
Hulk — do not go in the direction of
civilian structures. Hulk. Do you
hear—

HULK

(from somewhere in the middle
of the square, not especially
quietly)

HULK HEAR BATMAN.

BATMAN
Then adjust your—

HULK

BATMAN VERY BOSSY.

TONY STARK
(over comm, in the air)
Welcome to my life.
SUPERMAN and Thanos: the
confrontation that has
the weight of two philosophies
meeting
at maximum force. They clash across
the square
in a series of exchanges that produce
shockwaves
— not explosive, but concussive, the
sound of
force meeting force and neither
absorbing it.

THANOS
(in the middle of the confrontation
— not winded, not angry, analytical
even now)
You fight for a world you did not
choose.
I fight for one I selected. There is
a
difference.

SUPERMAN
The world chose me. That is different
from being selected.

THANOS
Is it? By what mechanism did a world
choose you? By the accident of your

arrival? By the fact that you happened to land in Kansas rather than the ocean? You call that choice?

SUPERMAN

(a beat — he considers this genuinely, because he is someone who considers things genuinely even in the middle of combat) The world saw what I could do and decided what I was for. That is different from assignment. That is — yes. That is choice. He hits Thanos with everything he has. The Joker and Batman: the confrontation that has lasted thirty years across one universe and is now being conducted for the first time in a world where it is not constrained by that universe's rules. The Joker finds this deeply interesting.

JOKER

(curious, while also fighting approximately four heroes simultaneously with his customary improvisational violence) Does it feel different to you? No Gotham. No prior context. Just us, here, now. Are you finding it as liberating as I am?

BATMAN

(landing next to him from the library roof, cape first) No.

JOKER

Of course not. You are constitutionally incapable of liberation. That is what makes you beautiful. He produces something from his jacket – the specific something that the Joker always produces at the worst moment, which in this case is a device that generates localized dimensional instability, because somewhere in the last three days someone gave the Joker access to dimensional technology, which is the worst possible version of that sentence.

JOKER

Someone gave me a toy! Isn't that fun? Who gave me the toy, you ask? I ask that too! But I think the more important question is – what does it DO?

BATMAN

Don't–

JOKER

Already did. GANDALF and DOCTOR STRANGE managing the dimensional instability together – Gandalf's staff and Strange's sling ring combining in a way that should not be possible between a Tolkien wizard and a Marvel sorcerer and is producing results that neither of them

could have achieved alone.

GANDALF

Interesting. Your approach uses
geometric notation—

DOCTOR STRANGE

And yours uses linguistic
inscription.
They're complementary.

GANDALF

In my experience, magic usually is.
SPIDER-MAN working through the
Chitauri
formation with the improvisational
intelligence of someone who has
learned to
fight in New York, which prepares you
for
most things.

SPIDER-MAN

(webbing three Chitauri
simultaneously while swinging
between the portal structure
and a lamppost)
This is a lot! This is genuinely a
lot!
Is anyone else finding this to be a
lot?

WONDER WOMAN

(directly below him, sword and
shield, entirely composed)
It is an appropriate amount.

SPIDER-MAN

It is NOT an appropriate amount!
GUMBALL — four feet tall, three-
dimensional,
fighting with a section of
scaffolding pipe
that is significantly taller than he
is —
navigates the battle with a
combination of

improvisational intelligence and the
constitutional refusal to accept
defeat
from any source, including physics,
enemy
combatants, and the basic problem of
being
four feet tall in a battle designed
for
people who are not.
He takes a hit from a Chitauri scout
— not
a serious hit but enough to knock him
back
three feet.
He stands up.
He looks at the scout.

GUMBALL

Okay. I want you to know that that
actually hurt. And I want you to know
that I am choosing to interpret it
as motivation.
He hits the scout with the
scaffolding pipe
in a way that requires more ingenuity
than
size and is completely effective.

GUMBALL

Motivation received.
DARWIN stays near Seiko — near the
command
station that Seiko has built from a
folding
table and two laptops and whatever
Tony
Stark's systems can channel
through them.
Darwin has spent his life monitoring
Gumball's
emotional states and has developed,
through
this practice, the finest emotional
radar
of anyone in the group. He notices
when Seiko's

hands begin to shake at 4:23 P.M. He
brings
water at 4:24.

DARWIN

(handing Seiko the water without
comment, watching the battle map)
Just the next decision. Whatever the
screen is showing you – just the next
one.

SEIKO

(drinking the water without
looking away from the screen)
Thank you, Darwin.

DARWIN

That's what I'm here for.
YARA – not in the main battle but
managing
the civilian situation: the people
who did
not make it to shelters, who are
trapped
in buildings in the perimeter, who
are
injured and separated from their
families.
She moves through the edges of the
conflict
with the efficiency of someone who
was trained for exactly this: the
organized
response to chaos, the triage of
attention
in a situation where everything
requires it
simultaneously.
She carries three people out of a
building
on Mass Avenue while Scarlet Witch
holds
a Chitauri formation away from its
entrance.
She is not a hero in the sense that
the

word is being used today – not
powered,
not armored. She is something else.
She
is the person who noticed, on the
first
morning, that two boys were sitting
on a
bench in Harvard Yard with cracked
glasses
and scattered papers and needed
someone
to sit down across from them.
That is also a kind of power.
That is also, in its way, exactly
what is needed.
The battle turns at 5:47 P.M.
The Joker's dimensional
instability device
detonates – not at full power,
because Batman
reached it in time, but at partial
power,
which is enough to destabilize a
four-block
radius, to unmoor a section of the
battlefield
from its coordinates, to make the
ground
uncertain in a way that affects
heroes and
villains equally.
In the instability, Darkseid moves.
He has been still on the library
steps for
four hours. He has been watching. He
has been
letting Thanos's army absorb the
heroes;
attention, letting the heroes commit,
letting
the battle develop to the moment when
the
heroes are fully extended and fully
deployed
and the Joker's device provides
the

disruption that a being of his
particular
capacity can exploit.
He moves toward the portal.
He does not fight the heroes in his
path. He
moves through them – not with
contempt but
with the confidence of something that
does
not experience the heroes as
obstacles, only
as temporary configurations of matter
that
happen to be in his direction.

BATMAN

(over comm – urgent, which for
Batman means his voice has
dropped slightly lower and
become slightly more precise)
Darkseid is moving. He is going for
the portal. If he reaches it–

SUPERMAN

I have him.

BATMAN

Wait–
But Superman moves.
And the confrontation between
Superman and
Darkseid is not the climax of this
battle –
it is, in retrospect, exactly what
Darkseid
wanted. Because Darkseid does not
actually
want the portal. He wants Superman
committed
to the northeast. He wants the center
open.
The Omega Beams fire.
Not at Superman. At Joseph.
Joseph is in the center of the
square, still

transmitting, still maintaining the
frequency
that is keeping every golden door
open.
If the frequency stops, the doors
close.
If the doors close, the heroes who
have not
yet come through stay in their
worlds.
The Omega Beams cross the square in a
line
of pure dark energy.
They do not reach Joseph.
WONDER WOMAN's shield catches
them.
She arrives from his left – three
steps and
the shield up and the Omega Beams
absorbed
and deflected into the pavement,
which
craters but does not collapse.
She stands with the shield still
raised,
looking at Darkseid across the
square.

WONDER WOMAN
(to Joseph, without looking
at him)
Keep transmitting.

JOSEPH
Yes.

WONDER WOMAN
How many more doors do we need?

JOSEPH
(checking – feeling the frequency,
reading it like a map)
Seven. Maybe eight. There are forces
in the outer districts–

WONDER WOMAN
Then keep transmitting. I have this.

She goes toward Darkseid.
The battle at 6:30 P.M. reaches its first stable equilibrium: the heroes have contained the deployment, the Chitauri formation has been broken into isolated clusters, the portal's output is being managed by Doctor Strange and Gandalf together. Thanos has pulled back to the portal itself – not retreating, regrouping, but the distinction matters because Thanos does not retreat.
Seven new doors open in the sky above Boston.
The last heroes come through.
At 7:14 P.M., as the September sun finishes setting, the First Battle of the First Multiverse War in Copley Square resolves.
Not victory. Containment. The enemy forces withdraw through the portal – not because they have been defeated but because someone, somewhere, has decided that this is not the intended battlefield. That Copley Square was a demonstration, not a finale.
The portal closes.
The sky above Boston, for the first time in three days, is simply the sky.
Joseph releases the frequency. He breathes.
The golden light fades from his hands.

TONY STARK
(landing beside him, faceplate up,
looking at the empty square)
So. That worked.

JOSEPH
Yes.

TONY STARK
First question – and I‘m going
to need
you to be very honest with me – what
exactly are you?

JOSEPH
I am a first-year student at Harvard.
Theoretical physics.

TONY STARK
(a beat)
Second question – and I‘m still
going
to need honesty – what was that?

JOSEPH
I do not have a complete explanation.

TONY STARK
Are you working on one?

JOSEPH
Yes.

TONY STARK
(nodding – the nod of someone
who has decided this is
acceptable for now)
Alright. That‘‘s acceptable for
now.
Batman lands beside them.

BATMAN
The worldwide deployments are being
handled by local teams. But this is
not over. Whoever coordinated this
simultaneous worldwide deployment
is still operational.

JOSEPH

I know. We need to talk about that.

BATMAN

Yes. We do.

He looks at Joseph with the long assessing look.

BATMAN

You held the square while managing a dimensional transmission at a frequency I have never measured before. Under direct fire from Darkseid.

JOSEPH

Wonder Woman held the square. I held the frequency.

BATMAN

Accurate. But the frequency was yours.
A pause.

JOSEPH

It is not something I can fully explain.
I went through the vortex. Something changed in the vortex. I came out different.

BATMAN

I went through something once. The pit.
I came out different too.
(a beat — the kind of beat Batman rarely produces)
It is not always a comfortable thing.
Being changed by what you went through.

JOSEPH

No. It is not.

BATMAN

But it is what you have. So you use it.

JOSEPH

Yes.

Batman nods. He looks at the closed portal.

At the square.

BATMAN

We need to find out who opened the vortex. Before they open another.

JOSEPH

Yes.

He looks at Seiko across the square – at Seiko,

at his makeshift command station, already

rebuilding his data feeds, already pulling

atmospheric readings and dimensional signature

data from every sensor available.

Already

working.

At Darwin beside him, handing him water.

At Yara, coming back from the perimeter, one

arm around a civilian she is guiding to safety.

At Gumball, sitting on a piece of rubble with

the scaffolding pipe across his knees and the

chipped yellow mug still in his pocket.

At all of them.

JOSEPH

(quietly, to himself – to

Casablanca, to the jasmine,

to his father's hands in the pre-dawn kitchen)

We are still here.

ACT FIVE

THE BATTLE OF ANTARCTICA

SEQUENCE TWELVE: THE APPROACH OF DARKNESS

INT. THRONE HALL — BLACK CRYSTAL — UNKNOWN DIMENSION

— FORTY-EIGHT HOURS BEFORE ANTARCTICA

The throne hall is built from black crystal.
Not black stone — black crystal: the
construction of something that grew into this
shape rather than was cut into it. The crystal
walls catch and scatter darkness rather than
light — they take what darkness is present
and multiply it, so the hall is never merely
dark but is dark in the way of something that
has been studying darkness for a long time.
At the throne: THE FIGURE.

We have seen him twice — briefly, at the edges.
Now, for the first time, in proximity.
He is watching a holographic display: the
battle at Copley Square, replayed and analyzed.
He watches Joseph in the center of the square,
the golden light rising from his skin. He
watches the doors opening in the sky above
Boston. He watches with the expression of
someone watching exactly what they expected
to see, which is not surprise but the
pleasure of confirmed predictions.
He is not angry that the battle went the
way it went.

He planned for it.

He raises one hand. The Copley Square display dies. In its place: a new display. Antarctica. The geographic south pole. The convergence of four dimensional fracture lines, marked in data overlays.

He reaches off-screen. He returns with a small holographic figure: Joseph, at the center of the square, hands extended, light rising.

He studies the figure.

THE FIGURE

(quietly – the quiet of genuine intellectual pleasure)
Interesting. Extremely interesting.
He sets the figure aside. He returns to the Antarctica display.
Then: the sound of footsteps.
Enormous footsteps.
The footsteps of something that does not move quickly because speed implies urgency and this thing has never experienced urgency.
OBLIVION enters the throne hall.
And the hall changes when it enters.
Not through structural damage – the crystal walls remain intact. But the quality of the space changes when Oblivion is present in it:
the darkness deepens, not because the light has been reduced but because Oblivion IS darkness in a way that makes the darkness around it more fully itself.
OBLIVION is fifty meters tall. Its body is void –

absolute, consuming void – but not
empty void.
Galaxies move through its form
slowly, patient,
visible through its surface like the
light of
ten billion stars seen through
ancient black
glass. It is the shape of everything
that has
ever been removed from existence: the
form of
all that absence has accumulated.
It does not sit. It does not stand.
It exists
in the space of the throne hall the
way a
concept exists in a mind: not
occupying space
but defining it.

THE FIGURE

(without turning from the
Antarctica display – the
casualness of someone who is not
afraid of what just entered the
room, which is either the most
powerful thing in the space or
the most reckless)
You have reviewed the Copley Square
outcome.

OBLIVION

(a voice that does not enter
through the ears but through
the chest – the frequency of
something that communicates
below the threshold of language)
Irrelevant.

THE FIGURE

Tactically. Yes. That was the
intention.
Draw them out. Inventory their
capacity.
Let the boy demonstrate his function.

OBLIVION

He is a transmitter. I identified
this
from the dissolution event.

THE FIGURE

You identified it before I did.

OBLIVION

I identified it from the moment the
vortex
opened. A human being processed
through
the structural center of the
dimensional
framework and returned as a frequency
generator. It is not unprecedented.
But
it is rare. In my experience — which
is
extensive — it occurs once per
framework
cycle.

THE FIGURE

And what does that mean for your
plans?

OBLIVION

(a long pause — the pause of
something that measures time in
geological units)
It means the timing is correct.
He turns — which is less a physical
rotation
and more a reorientation of where his
attention
is directed. His attention, directed
toward you,
is felt as a change in temperature
and pressure.

OBLIVION

The barriers are gone. I have waited
for
this across eleven framework cycles.
Each

cycle: barriers constructed, barriers
maintained, barriers eventually
degraded
and then reconstructed before I could
pass through them. Eleven times. Do
you
understand what eleven framework
cycles
represents in your time measurement?

THE FIGURE
Several trillion years.

OBLIVION
Longer. And in each cycle: the same
result. The barriers held long enough
for reconstruction. Until this cycle,
in which your intervention – I
acknowledge
your contribution – applied the
precise
directional stress at the precise
moment
required to cause total barrier
failure
rather than localized breach.

THE FIGURE
I am glad my contribution was useful.

OBLIVION
Do not mistake my acknowledgment for
gratitude. I do not experience
gratitude.
I experience the recognition of
instrumental
relationships. You were instrumental.
The relationship will continue to be
instrumental until it is not.

THE FIGURE
(a small, private smile)
Of course.

OBLIVION
The boy.

THE FIGURE

Yes?

OBLIVION

You will not remove him.

THE FIGURE

I had not intended—

OBLIVION

Good. He is useful to me as he is.
A transmitter of that frequency
removed
from the equation produces a universe
that is simply emptied. What I want
is
not an empty universe. I want a
universe
that unmakes itself. The difference
is
significant.

THE FIGURE

(carefully)

And the heroes he has assembled?

OBLIVION

(the quality of its attention
shifting slightly — the galactic
light through its form rearranging)
Send everything. Let them bring
everything
they have. Let the boy use the
transmitter
function at full capacity. Let him be
everything he can be.

(a beat)

And then let me show him what
everything
is not enough for.
The Figure nods. He returns to the
Antarctica
display.
OBLIVION remains in the throne hall.
It is
simply there, in the way of large
things that

do not require activity to be
present.
It says one more thing:

OBLIVION

I have been waiting for a long time.
I find I am in no particular hurry
now
that the waiting is over. The boy
will
come to Antarctica because the
fracture
lines converge there and he will
understand
this eventually. The heroes will
follow
because he leads them. And at the
south
pole, in the place where all the
broken
walls of the dimensional framework
meet,
I will finish what eleven cycles of
waiting have prepared.
The galactic light through its form
dims
slightly, then brightens. As if
something
deep inside it is satisfied.

SEQUENCE THIRTEEN: PREPARATION

INT. MPA PROVISIONAL HEADQUARTERS — BOSTON —

TWO DAYS AFTER COPLEY SQUARE
They have converted a building near
Copley Square —
an office tower, evacuated, its
conference rooms
turned into command centers and
planning spaces
and, on the sixth floor, a medical
wing that Yara
is running with two doctors from
Massachusetts

General who volunteered when the hospital was cleared of injured civilians. The CORE TEAM, assembled in the main conference room for the first major strategic meeting: BATMAN at the head of the table. He has a city map overlaid with dimensional signature data that FRIDAY and his own AI have spent forty-eight hours constructing. TONY STARK to Batman's right, because even Tony Stark acknowledges that Batman runs the tactical room more efficiently than Tony does, which Tony has acknowledged once and will not acknowledge again. SUPERMAN across from Tony. THOR beside him. WONDER WOMAN at the corner. CAPTAIN AMERICA against the wall – not seated at the table, which is very Captain America. DOCTOR STRANGE with the dimensional analysis data that he has been correlating since Copley Square. GANDALF with a pipe, looking at the data with the expression of someone who has seen things that make this data comprehensible in ways that pure analysis cannot. JOSEPH at the opposite end from Batman. SEIKO beside him. YARA beside Seiko. GUMBALL and DARWIN at the corner, because

they are there and they matter and
the
people at this table know it by now.

SEIKO

(standing, presenting – this
is where Seiko is most himself,
in the place where precision
is required and he has it)
Four dimensional fracture lines. Each
one a direct consequence of the
vortex
event three days ago. They are not
distributed randomly – they converge.
(he pulls up the map)
Geographic south pole. Ninety degrees
south latitude. The convergence point
is precise to within fifty meters.

BATMAN

Which means whatever comes next
happens
there.

SEIKO

The fracture lines are not stable.
They
are deepening. The rate of deepening
accelerates non-linearly – by our
models,
we have approximately six days before
the convergence event, whatever it
is.

DOCTOR STRANGE

I can tell you what it is. The
convergence
of four simultaneous dimensional
fractures
at the same geographic point produces
a structural collapse. Not a portal.
Not a breach. A structural collapse
of
the dimensional framework itself, in
that
location, propagating outward.

GANDALF
(quietly)
How far outward?

DOCTOR STRANGE
Total.
Silence.

TONY STARK
Define total.

DOCTOR STRANGE
Every dimension. Every world. Every
story.
Everything separated by the barriers
that
are now gone. Without the barriers to
define the structure, and without the
structure to contain the collapse—

THOR
(quietly, for Thor)
Everything ends.

DOCTOR STRANGE
Yes. Everything ends.
Another silence. Longer.

GUMBALL
(quietly — not his usual
register)
So the stakes are: everything.

CAPTAIN AMERICA
They usually are.

GUMBALL
(looking at him)
Does that get easier? Knowing the
stakes
are everything?

CAPTAIN AMERICA
(directly, honestly)
No. But you get better at holding it.
At not letting the size of it freeze
you.

You learn to see past the everything
to
the next thing. And you do the next
thing.

GUMBALL

(after a beat — absorbing this,
filing it)
Okay. What's the next thing?

BATMAN

Antarctica. We move in three days.
We use the extra time to prepare.
He looks at the table.

BATMAN

Every person in this room has a
function
in what happens there. I need to know
all of them precisely. I need to know
every capability, every limitation,
every
interaction between capabilities that
could create a problem or an
opportunity.
I need the full truth of what
everyone
can do. This is not optional and
there
is no room for performance.
He looks at Joseph.

BATMAN

Starting with you.
Joseph looks at the room. At everyone
assembled.
He thinks about Brian McKenzie. He
thinks about
red punch and cracked glasses and the
wish
he made standing at the dorm window.
He thinks: this is what the wish was
for.
He thinks: answer honestly.

JOSEPH

I am a transmitter. In the vortex,

something changed in me. I can access
a frequency that exists in the
structural
layer of the dimensional framework –
below the individual dimensions, in
the connective tissue between all of
them. When I transmit at that
frequency,
I can open dimensional doors. I can
call things through them. What I
transmit
is not my own power – I am the
channel,
not the source.

TONY STARK
You're an antenna.

JOSEPH
A transmitter. Yes. I transmit what
is already there – the accumulated..
I do not have a precise word for it.
The will of people who
refuse to stop. That is the closest
I can come.

TONY STARK
(looking at him – the look he
gives things he does not fully
understand and is therefore
extremely interested in)
Have you tested the limits of this?

JOSEPH
Not intentionally.

BATMAN
Then we need to know them. Before
Antarctica.
He stands.

BATMAN
Three days. Everyone prepares.
Everyone
trains. Everyone tests the limits of
what they can do in combination with
everyone else. We arrive at the south

pole knowing exactly what we have.
He looks at the map. At the
convergence point.

BATMAN

We will not get a second attempt at
this.
The meeting ends.
SEIKO, gathering his data,
doesn't look up:

SEIKO

Joseph.

JOSEPH

Yes.

SEIKO

When you said you do not know what
it costs you. To transmit. You said
that earlier and you did not say it
again.

JOSEPH

Yes.

SEIKO

Have you developed any additional
information on that question?
A pause.

JOSEPH

It does not feel like subtraction.
When I transmit. It feels more like
— redistribution. Like being the
place where something passes through.

SEIKO

That is not the same as knowing
the cost.

JOSEPH

No. It is not.

SEIKO

I would like to know the cost.
Before Antarctica. If possible.

JOSEPH

I know you would. I would like to know it too.
He puts his hand on Seiko's shoulder. Briefly.
The touch of friends who do not touch often
and therefore touch precisely when it is needed.

JOSEPH

We are going to be alright, Seiko.

SEIKO

(quietly, the small Seiko smile)
I know. I am processing the possibility
that we might not be and finding it unacceptable, which is not the same
as knowing but functions similarly.

JOSEPH

Yes. It does.

INT. PROVISIONAL HEADQUARTERS — YARA'S MEDICAL WING —

THAT NIGHT

The sixth floor. The medical wing.
The doctors
have gone home. The floor is quiet.
Yara is at the window with a cold cup of tea.
She is looking at the Boston skyline — the
parts of it visible between the buildings,
the parts that are still just city.
Joseph comes in. He has been training with
Batman for six hours. He has the exhaustion of someone who has been
pushed
past the edges of their capacity by a person
who knows exactly where those edges are and

finds them useful as starting points.

YARA

Sit down.

He sits. On the window ledge beside her.

YARA

Batman doesn't stop, does he.

JOSEPH

He does not find stopping useful.

YARA

How far can you push the frequency?

JOSEPH

He had me try to hold seven simultaneous dimensional connections. I managed four before the signal degraded.

YARA

And at Copley Square?

JOSEPH

I do not know exactly how many doors I opened. I was not counting. More than four.

YARA

So the capacity is larger under actual conditions than training conditions.

JOSEPH

It seems so. He thinks it is motivational — that the presence of genuine need increases the output.

YARA

That is consistent with what I know about human capacity under stress. People do things under genuine threat that they cannot replicate in practice.

A pause.

JOSEPH

Yara.

YARA

Yes.

JOSEPH

At the party. When Brian poured the punch and I was standing still – you said something to me. You said something and I could not hear it. I have thought about it many times. She looks at him.

YARA

I know.

JOSEPH

What did you say?
A pause. Not hesitation – the pause of someone deciding whether this is the right moment.

YARA

I said: I see you.
The simplest possible sentence. Three words.
The words of a person who understands, having studied the way humans process trauma, that the thing most urgently needed by someone being made invisible is evidence that they are seen.
Joseph says nothing for a moment.

JOSEPH

(quietly)
Thank you. For that.

YARA

You stood still. With the punch

on your face and your cracked glasses
and the camera pointed at you. You
made the right calculation and you
held it. Most people would not have
been able to hold it.

JOSEPH

I was furious.

YARA

I know. I could see that too. The
stillness was not absence of feeling.
It was the management of feeling.
That is — Joseph, that is actually
very rare.

JOSEPH

It is what my father taught me. He
never said it directly. But I watched
him do it for years in his classroom
—

students who were difficult, parents
who were unreasonable, administrators
who did not support him. He always
managed the feeling and then used it.
He did not suppress it. He directed
it.

YARA

(looking at him)
He sounds remarkable.

JOSEPH

He is.
He looks at his hands. The hands that
opened
golden doors above Boston.

JOSEPH

I am afraid of what happens in
Antarctica
if I cannot transmit at the necessary
scale. If what I did at Copley Square
was
the limit and the limit is not
enough.

YARA

What would your father say about that?

JOSEPH

He would say: the fear is information.
The fear is telling you that you understand the size of what you are doing. Use the information. Do not give it more space than that.

YARA

He would be right.

JOSEPH

He usually is.
She puts her hand over his. Brief. Specific.
The gesture of someone who has decided that this is the moment when contact is the right response and contact is what she has to give.

YARA

You are not alone in this. I want you to know that as a fact, not a comfort.
Whatever happens in Antarctica – you are not transmitting from an empty space.
You are transmitting from something we built. The three of us. In a dorm room with pastries on a bad night.

JOSEPH

(after a long moment)
Yes. We did build something.

YARA

(small, genuine, warm)
We built the beginning of something.
She goes back to her cold tea.

He stays at the window for a while longer.
He is not afraid of Antarctica, exactly.
He is aware of the size of it. He is holding
the awareness of it without being consumed
by it.
He thinks his father would be satisfied with this.

SEQUENCE FOURTEEN: ANTARCTICA — THE ARRIVAL

EXT. ANTARCTICA — GEOGRAPHIC SOUTH POLE REGION — DAWN

TEXT ON SCREEN: THIRTY-SIX HOURS LATER.

The Antarctic winter.

Absolute. Without qualification, without softening, without the particular mercy that extreme cold sometimes produces in the form of beauty. This is the cold of geography as argument: an argument against the presence of living things in this location, made in the language of wind and temperature and white that extends from horizon to horizon with complete and total authority.

MINUS THIRTY-TWO CELSIUS.
Wind at sixty kilometers per hour, gusting
to ninety. The blizzards come in horizontal
waves — white and complete and total and
blinding. The horizon has been removed.
The distinction between ground and sky has

been removed. There is only the white
and
the cold and the sound of wind that
is
not a sound but a frequency, a
continuous
infrasonic roar that sits below
hearing
and is felt in the chest.
AERIAL VIEW: The shelf ice below. The
convergence point marked by four
fracture
lines that are visible from above as
luminous cracks in the surface of the
world —
cracks glowing with the same wrong
colors
as the vortex over Cambridge, the
same
colors as the portal at Copley
Square.
Four lines of light meeting at one
point.
The fracture lines have been
deepening
for thirty-six hours. At the
convergence
point, the ice has been pushed upward
into
a formation that should not exist —
crystalline, precise, too organized
to be
geological, the formation of
something
that is emerging rather than forming.
The armies are here.
Both of them.
The heroes arrived six hours before
the
enemy forces — Batman's
planning, FRIDAY's
calculations, Doctor Strange's
dimensional
navigation — and have established
positions
across three kilometers of shelf ice.

They have fortifications,
communications,
medical stations. They have every
advantage
of preparation.
They also have Oblivion incoming.
And Oblivion renders the advantages
of
preparation into a different category
of consideration.

INT. GEODESIC RESEARCH DOME — SEIKO'S COMMAND STATION

— CONTINUOUS

SEIKO has built the command station he was
born to build. Four monitors displaying six
data feeds each. The dimensional analysis
software running on a server he and Tony
Stark assembled during the transit. Every
battle front mapped in real time.

His right shoulder is bandaged — a Chitauri
hit during the Copley Square battle that he
has not mentioned to anyone except Darwin,
who noticed it without being told and has
been bringing him his oatmeal every morning
with the casual precision of someone
who is performing casual while being entirely
deliberate.

TONY STARK checks in by comm.

TONY STARK
(over comm)
Seiko. Status.

SEIKO
Three fronts stable. East sector
showing
increased pressure from the Mordor

formation – they are probing the
perimeter,
testing response times. North sector:
Thor and Hulk are managing the
Chitauri
second wave. South sector: Spider-Man
and the Harry Potter contingent
holding
at approximately eighty-three percent
capacity. My right shoulder is
bandaged
and I am operating at approximately
ninety-one percent efficiency. The
remaining nine percent is cold and
a quantifiable anxiety response. Both
are manageable.

TONY STARK

That is not how–

SEIKO

I know how efficiency works, Stark.
I am using efficiency as a metaphor
for my current functional state
because
the metaphor is precise. Please focus
on the air formation in Sector Seven.
A pause.

TONY STARK

(over comm, almost – almost –
warmly)
You’re good at this, kid.

SEIKO

I am aware. Thank you.
Darwin brings oatmeal without
comment.

SEQUENCE FIFTEEN: THE BATTLE OF ANTARCTICA –

THE FIRST THREE HOURS

EXT. ANTARCTICA – SHELF ICE – SECTOR THREE – CONTINUOUS

SUPERMAN and THANOS across three kilometers

of ice. Their confrontation has been building since the thirty-minute mark of the battle, each exchange producing shockwaves that crack the shelf surface in expanding rings. They fight with the quality of two entities for whom the fight is also a philosophical argument – each blow an assertion, each response a counterargument.

THANOS

(during a pause – both of them standing in the crater their last exchange produced)
You feel the cold.

SUPERMAN

Yes.

THANOS

I do not. I stopped feeling the cold two thousand years ago. I have stopped feeling many things. I find it increases clarity.

SUPERMAN

I find it increases the distance between you and the things you are making decisions about.

THANOS

(actually considering this)
Perhaps. But the decisions are more correct.

SUPERMAN

Correct by what measure?

THANOS

By the measure of what remains after they are made.

SUPERMAN

What you made has brought everything to this ice field. Is this what you wanted to remain?

A pause. Thanos looks at the battlefield.

At the armies. At the heroes. At the convergence point behind him, glowing.

THANOS

No. I wanted order. What Oblivion wants is not order. I realize now that the distinction matters.

SUPERMAN

Then stand down.

THANOS

(the pause of someone genuinely considering it)

I cannot. The arrangement is made. The forces are committed. There is no mechanism for—

SUPERMAN

There is always a mechanism. You just have to want it enough. Thanos is silent. He looks at the convergence point. At the growing formation of crystalline ice above it.

THANOS

(quietly)

What Oblivion will do — do you understand what Oblivion will do?

SUPERMAN

We are trying to stop it.

THANOS

You are not fully equipped to stop it.

Even all of you together. What Oblivion

is — it is not like me. I can be countered. I have been countered. But Oblivion is not a force that can be countered. It can only be—
He stops.

SUPERMAN

Only be what?

THANOS

(looking at Joseph, visible in the distance near the convergence point)
Redirected. But the redirection requires something I do not possess. The boy may have it.
He says nothing more. He does not stand down —
the commitment is made, the forces are deployed.
But the quality of the confrontation changes slightly.
THOR in the north sector: entirely in his element. The Antarctic wind feeds his lightning rather than damping it. He moves through the blizzard with the exhilaration of something that has been constrained and is now not constrained, and finds the not-constrained version of itself to be its correct form.
WONDER WOMAN in the center — the command position she took by instinct and the tactical structure confirmed by Batman. She has been here for three hours. She has a wound on her

left arm that she has not
acknowledged. She
has not stopped moving.
GUMBALL fights with the scaffolding
pipe and
a strategy that he describes, when
pressed,
as "aggressive creative problem-
solving."
He is four feet tall in a battle that
was
designed by and for entities
significantly
taller. He addresses this by
operating below
the level at which most entities in
the battle
are looking.
At the two-hour mark, the battle
reaches a
moment of maximum difficulty: the
East sector
collapses partially. The Mordor
formation
has found the gap between Captain
America's
perimeter and Harry Potter's
left flank.
The gap is thirty meters. Enough.
In the three minutes it takes Batman
to
redirect forces to close the gap,
twelve
heroes are pushed back. The Nazgûl
enter
the gap with the terrifying
efficiency of creatures that were
designed
for exactly this kind of
exploitation.
It is in this moment that Gumball
says something.
He says it loudly enough that
seventeen heroes
in proximity hear it. Every account
of what
he says is slightly different – the

phrasing varies in memory, as the phrasing of important things always does.
But the consensus is: a sentence that reframes the moment from catastrophic to manageable.
That turns the gap from a failure into a door through which something useful can come. A sentence that is funny in the specific way of things that reveal the truth unexpectedly.
Whatever it is: seventeen heroes laugh.
The laugh lasts one and a half seconds.
In one and a half seconds, the perspective shifts. The gap is visible not as catastrophe but as problem. Problems have solutions.
They go find the solution.
The gap closes in four minutes.
Darwin: moving between Seiko's command station and the field, carrying information both directions, watching Seiko's states the way he has always watched Gumball's states — with the fine attentiveness of someone who has devoted their attention to one person for so long that attentiveness has become their primary mode.
At the three-hour mark, Seiko's hands begin to shake. Not from injury. From the sustained

concentration of managing five
simultaneous
fronts at maximum complexity for
three hours
straight.
Darwin is beside him before Seiko
notices
his own hands.

DARWIN

(quietly, beside him)
Just the next decision. Whatever the
screen is showing you. Just the next
one. You don't have to hold all
of
it at once.

SEIKO

(not looking up, voice controlled
but only barely)
If I stop holding all of it,
something
breaks.

DARWIN

You've been holding all of it
for three
hours. The screens are also holding
it.
You can trust the screens with some
of it.
A pause.

SEIKO

(the Seiko pause of
someone doing a rapid re-
architecture of an internal
system)
Yes. That is... correct. I can
distribute the holding.

DARWIN

Yes.

SEIKO

Darwin.

DARWIN

Yes?

SEIKO

Thank you for being here.

DARWIN

(simply, with the warmth of
someone who means it entirely)
There's nowhere else I'd
be.
YARA in Sector Seven: the evacuation
of a
small team of Antarctic researchers
who
refused to leave their station. She
moves
them through the perimeter edge with
quiet
efficiency, her back to the main
battle,
her attention on the three scientists
who are cold and frightened and
holding
each other's arms.
She gets them to the medical dome.
She turns back toward the battle.
FORTY METERS AWAY: A CHITAUURI SIEGE
MACHINE.
It has been brought through the
portal
specifically for this engagement –
heavy
ordnance, designed to crack large
targets.
It swings to track the largest
available
energy signature near the perimeter.
Its targeting system finds Yara.
It locks.
Joseph is forty meters away on her
other side.
He does not think about it.
The body's wisdom is faster than
the mind's
calculation, and in this moment the
body's

wisdom is exactly four words: NOT
HER. NOT
HER. Simple as that. Not argument,
not
reasoning, not the output of a
process.
A fact. An absolute.
He moves across the ice.
Two seconds. Two seconds from the
machine
locking to Joseph between Yara and
the beam,
the SHIELD rising from him — not from
a
device, from him, from the structural
change, a force field of the same
frequency
as the golden doors, solid and hot
and
absolutely certain.
The beam hits the shield.
The force of the discharge
distributes across
the shield and back into the ice
around them —
the ice vaporizes in a perfect
circle, and
they are standing in the center of
the circle,
in the clearing smoke.
Six inches apart.
Her face level with his.
Her eyes: wide and present and
direct.
Not panicked. The eyes of someone who
is
completely, entirely here.

YARA
(quietly)
Thank you.

JOSEPH
Always. I will always—
He turns toward the siege machine
before he

can finish the sentence. He defeats
it
in eight seconds.
He has never finished that sentence.
He will finish it, eventually. In a
courtyard
in Casablanca one September evening,
with
string lights above them and people
they love
around them. The sentence will take
thirty
seconds and will be the most
important thirty
seconds of speech he has ever
produced.
But not here. Not yet.
He turns back toward the convergence
point.
The convergence point where the
fracture lines
meet. Where the crystalline formation
is now
three meters high and rising.
Where something enormous is about to
arrive.

SEQUENCE SIXTEEN: THANOS FALLS — AND SPEAKS

EXT. ANTARCTICA — THANOS'S POSITION — LATE AFTERNOON

SUPERMAN and THANOS: the final exchange.

Thanos falls. Not dramatically — with the
specific weight of something enormous
accepting the result of a calculation that
went against it. He falls to one knee. The
Infinity Gauntlet hits the ice. The impact
sends a shockwave through the shelf.

He stays where he is. His voice, stripped of
performance, is something rarer than power:
it is genuine intelligence, speaking from

a position of loss.

THANOS

You should understand something. What
I have helped release — what broke
the
barriers and brought all of this — it
is larger than any of us. I thought I
was using it. I thought the
arrangement
served my purposes. I was wrong.

SUPERMAN

(beside him — not victorious,
not contemptuous, but listening)
Who is it? Who arranged this?

THANOS

Someone with patience I do not
possess.
Patience measured in the kind of time
that makes what I have done look
impulsive.
He looks at the convergence point. At
the
crystalline formation, now five
meters high.

THANOS

What is coming now — what Oblivion
IS—
it is not something you can fight in
the way you fight me. I can be
beaten.
Oblivion cannot be beaten. It can
only
be—
The sky changes.
It does not darken. The sky above
Antarctica
is already dark. What changes is the
quality
of the dark — the color drains out of
it,
and what remains is not night-dark
but void-
dark, the darkness of absence, the

darkness of something that consumes
rather
than simply blocks.
OBLIVION descends.

SEQUENCE SEVENTEEN: OBLIVION DESCENDS

EXT. ANTARCTICA — CONVERGENCE POINT — CONTINUOUS

OBLIVION descends over Antarctica.

It descends slowly. This is its first act
of deliberate communication: the slowness
is not limitation but statement. I am in
no hurry. I have been waiting for eleven
framework cycles. The eleven-second descent
versus the eleven-trillion-year wait makes
the descent feel like the resolution of a
patience that is itself a form of power.

FIFTY METERS TALL.

Its body: void. Absolute, consuming,
complete
void — not the void of space, which
has stars
and light and the movement of things,
but the
void of absence, of the space where
things
were and no longer are and left no
evidence
of having been.
Through this void: galaxies. Slowly
turning.
Patient. Visible through
Oblivion's surface
the way the light of ancient stars is
visible
through ancient black glass. Ten
billion
stars' worth of light, moving
through a body

of absence, suggesting an interior
that
contains everything that has been
unmade.
It lands on the ice and the ice does
not
crack. It simply accepts the weight
because
nothing in the physical world knows
how
to refuse something this fundamental.
The temperature at the convergence
point
drops fifteen degrees in three
seconds.
The wind stops.
The blizzard stops.
Every hero within a kilometer of the
convergence point stops.
The stopping is not choice — it is
the
biological response to the presence
of
something that the nervous system
recognizes
as outside the category of things the
nervous system was built to process.
OBLIVION looks at the assembled
heroes with
an attention that is felt as
pressure.
Then it speaks.
The voice of Oblivion does not enter
through
the ears. It moves through the chest.
It moves
through the bone. It moves through
the
specific frequency that living things
use
to feel fear — not the fear of an
enemy but
the fear of something that is outside
the
category of enemy and enemy-response,
something

that the body recognizes before the
mind does
as belonging to a different order.

OBLIVION

(the voice felt rather than heard –
the infrasonic register of something
that has forgotten what it is like
to need to be heard)
The barriers were the only thing that
kept me from everything. Eleven
cycles.
Eleven times the framework was
constructed
while I pressed against its walls and
found
them, each time, sufficient. Eleven
times
I watched what was built behind those
walls
grow and develop and accumulate its
small
significance.
It looks at the heroes. At their
weapons.
At their powers. With something that
is not
contempt – contempt implies that the
object
of contempt matters enough to be
contemned.
This is something more comprehensive:
the
recognition of scale difference.

OBLIVION

You are here to stop me. I recognize
the intention. I want you to know
that
I find the intention – not admirable,
which would imply a standard by which
I measure things, which I do not – I
find it legible. You understand what
is
at stake. You are here anyway. This
is the behavior of things that are
alive

in the way of things that have
decided the world they occupy is
worth
defending.
It looks at Joseph, in the group of
heroes,
watching.

OBLIVION

And you. The transmitter. I have been
watching you since the dissolution.

JOSEPH

(directly – he does not look
away)
I know.

OBLIVION

You opened the doors. You called them
here.
(a pause – the galaxies through
its form slowly turning)
Good. I wanted them all here. I
wanted
every hero from every story that this
framework has ever generated to be
assembled in this place, at this
convergence, so that what happens
here
is complete. So that when I unmake
this
framework, there is no remainder.
Nothing left behind a locked door
somewhere, preserved by absence.

BATMAN

(over comm – controlled)
Everyone. Maximum. Now.
Every hero directs everything at
Oblivion.
SUPERMAN's heat vision –
sustained, at full
power, the concentrated product of a
yellow
sun's energy focused through the
architecture of a Kryptonian body.

THOR's full atmospheric
lightning – not a
strike but a sustained column,
Stormbreaker
raised, every storm system within two
hundred kilometers redirected.
IRON MAN's complete arsenal –
every repulsor,
every weapon system in the Mark
LXXXVII,
targeted at the center of the void.
SCARLET WITCH: chaos magic at full
output,
the red energy of reality-
manipulation
directed at the fundamental structure
of
what Oblivion is.
GANDALF's staff: a light so
white it
predates language for light.
DOCTOR STRANGE: every sling ring
configuration
he knows. Seventeen simultaneously.
WONDER WOMAN's godly strength in
a direct
assault with the Godkiller sword.
HULK – at full rage, maximum –
running at
Oblivion with the intention of
something that cannot be hurt and
therefore
cannot be stopped by the threat of
being hurt.
All of them. Everything.
Oblivion receives it.
It does not stagger. It does not
absorb the
energy and redirect it. It does not
fight back.
It receives the assault the way a sea
receives
rain: completely, without friction,
without
accumulation, without any evidence
that the
rain has arrived.

The heroes stop.
Not by choice. By the limit of their
capacity.
Three minutes of maximum output, and
the
silence that follows is the silence
of
people who have spent everything and
are
looking at something that is
unchanged.

OBLIVION

(after the silence – gently,
which is more frightening
than anything loud could be)
I am not a body. I am not a force.
I am not a power in the sense that
any of you use the word. I am the
absence of the barriers that kept
everything separate. I am what was
always on the other side of every
wall you built to keep yourselves
distinct.
It looks at the convergence point –
at the
fracture lines meeting, at the
crystalline
formation now eight meters high and
pulsing
with the void's frequency.

OBLIVION

The framework begins its dissolution
in approximately forty seconds. The
dissolution propagates outward at the
speed of dimensional collapse, which
is not the speed of light but the
speed
of forgetting. By the time the last
of you registers that it has begun,
forty percent of the framework will
already be gone.

THOR

(from the ground – he has been
knocked down, twice, and gotten

up both times, and his voice
has the quality of
someone who is choosing not
to be finished)
Then we have forty seconds.

OBLIVION

Yes. What would you like to do with
them?
It asks this without cruelty. With
genuine
curiosity. What would you like to do
with
your forty seconds? It is a question
Oblivion
finds interesting in the way that
things
it has never before encountered are
interesting.
No one speaks.
Then:

GUMBALL

(from somewhere to the left –
four feet tall, covered in ice,
scaffolding pipe still in hand)
Joseph.

JOSEPH

Yes.

GUMBALL

You are a transmitter.

JOSEPH

Yes.

GUMBALL

You transmit what is already there.
The accumulated – you said the
will. The thing that
was already there before you. You
just open the channel for it.

JOSEPH

(quietly)
Yes.

GUMBALL

So the question is not whether you
are strong enough. You are not the
source. The question is whether
you can open the channel wide enough.
A beat.

JOSEPH

(to himself, almost inaudible –
the quiet of a person
who has just heard the precise
thing that reorganizes everything)
Yes. The question is whether I can
open it wide enough.
He looks at Oblivion.
Forty seconds.
Thirty-seven.

SEQUENCE EIGHTEEN: THE LIGHT THAT IS NOT JOSEPH'S

EXT. ANTARCTICA – THE ICE – CONTINUOUS

JOSEPH walks toward the convergence point.
He walks slowly. Not dramatically – with the
specific pace of someone who has a precise
destination and is thinking rather than
performing on the way there.
He passes Thor. He passes Batman. He passes
Yara, who catches his arm.

YARA

Joseph.

JOSEPH

(stopping – looking at her)
I know what I am doing.

YARA

Tell me anyway.

JOSEPH

I am going to open the channel as
wide as it will go. I am going to

transmit at the frequency that
connects
every dimension in the framework –
not to call heroes through, not to
open doors, but to give the framework
itself the signal it needs to hold.

YARA

Can you do that?

JOSEPH

I do not know.

YARA

What happens if you try and it is
not enough?

JOSEPH

Then Gumball's forty seconds
were
the last forty seconds.
A pause. She looks at him. The full
assessment
of someone who has studied human
capacity
under extreme stress and knows
exactly what
she is looking at.

YARA

Go.
He goes.
He walks to the convergence point. He
stands
at the base of the crystalline
formation –
eight meters of void-crystal, pulsing
with
the frequency of dissolution,
counting down
to the moment when the framework
ends.
He looks up at Oblivion.

OBLIVION

(looking down at the boy –
the galaxies through its form

turning slowly)
What are you doing?

JOSEPH
Something you did not account for.

OBLIVION
I accounted for everything you can
do.
I watched you at Copley Square. I
know
the frequency. I know the capacity.

JOSEPH
You know my capacity. You do not know
the capacity of what I transmit.

OBLIVION
(a pause — the galaxies
shifting)
Explain.

JOSEPH
The will of people who
refuse to stop. You have seen the
framework — eleven cycles. You have
seen what it builds. Stories. Heroes.
the human decision that the
world we have is worth defending.
Seven
billion people, right now, who did
not
choose to be in a multiverse war and
are in basements and shelters waiting
for it to stop. Waiting because they
believe it will stop. Because they
have decided, somewhere below the
level of conscious decision, that
stopping is not permitted.
He kneels.
He presses both palms flat on the
ice.
The position his mother taught him
for
prayer when he was small. Not the
form —

he is not praying to anything
specific.
He is doing what his mother did when
she
pressed her hands against things: he
is
connecting. He is making contact. He
is
refusing the distance between himself
and the thing he is trying to reach.
He thinks about his father in the
kitchen.
He thinks about the lesson plan in
the
margins. He thinks about Seiko on the
coach from Fez saying "that is
precisely
correct" with the tone of
someone
who needed to be seen and was seen.
He
thinks about Yara, four words in the
dark
of the party: I see you.
He thinks about seven billion people.
He thinks about the ordinary
human fact of refusing to give up on
something.
He says, in Arabic, quietly:

JOSEPH

(in Arabic – subtitled)

Let it through.
The LIGHT that comes is not his.
It is not from any single source.
It is not a color or a warmth or a
beam
or a door. It is a frequency – the
frequency
of refusal, the note that seven
billion people produce when they
decide,
below the level of language, that the
world
they have built is worth what it
costs to
defend it.

It moves through him the way a signal
moves through a transmitter: he is
the
shape of it, the channel of it, the
point through which it passes. He is
not diminished by it. He is organized
by
it, the way a frequency organizes a
field
into a pattern.
He directs it at Oblivion.
Not as an attack. Not as a force. As
a counter-frequency – the opposite
of absence. The signal of presence.
The
evidence that things ARE, that the
framework is FULL, that the eleven
cycles
of things being built behind the
barriers
were not arbitrary or temporary but
were
the framework's answer to the
void.
OBLIVION receives this.
And something changes.
It is not pain. It is not defeat. It
is
the experience of an entity that
has never encountered its own
opposite
in a form it could not simply
consume.
The absence meeting the presence. The
void
meeting the fullness. The eleven
cycles
of waiting meeting the eleven cycles
of
building.
The galaxies through Oblivion's
form stop
turning.
For three seconds, they are still.
Then, slowly – slowly – they begin to
brighten.

OBLIVION

(the voice felt in the chest –
but changed, the frequency
changed, something in it that
was not there before)
I did not expect you to be this.
It says this not with surprise. With
recognition. The recognition of
something
it has been, in its deepest
architecture,
waiting to encounter. The thing that
justifies the eleven cycles of
waiting.
The thing that makes the framework
worth
unmaking.
Except.
Except it is also the thing that
makes
the framework worth keeping.
Oblivion understands this in the
three
seconds that the galaxies are still.
Then, slowly, over ninety seconds
that
feel like geology – like watching a
continent decide – it dissolves.
Not destroyed. Dissolved. Returned to
what it was before it became
Oblivion:
the space between things. The
distance
that lets things be distinct. The
absence
that defines presence by surrounding
it.
The dimensional portals across the
world
begin to close.
One by one. London. Tokyo. New York.
Sydney. Cairo. Mumbai. São Paulo.
Each one closing with the sound
of a door that has been open for too
long
and has finally found its frame.
The fracture lines at the convergence

point seal – slowly, from the outside
in,
the cracks filling with something
that
is the opposite of void: presence.
Continuity. The stuff of which
frameworks
are made.
Joseph falls forward.
YARA catches him.
She is beside him – she moved toward
the convergence point the moment he
knelt, because she moves toward
things,
because that is what she does – and
she
catches him with both arms before his
face hits the ice.
He looks up at her from approximately
six inches away.

JOSEPH
(barely audible)
Is it over?

BATMAN
(nearby – standing in the
cleared space, cape in the
Antarctic wind, looking at
the sky where the portals
are closing)
This part.
He looks at Joseph.

BATMAN
Well done.
Coming from Batman, at this volume,
in
this context, this is the equivalent
of
a standing ovation from anyone else.
Joseph registers this. He is too
exhausted
to respond. He lets Yara hold him up.
Then: the sound.
Every hero on the ice. The sound that
is not words but is unmistakably the

sound that living things make when
they
have survived what they were not
certain
they would survive – the sound
of continuation, of the world still
being
here, of the refusal having worked.
THOR raises Stormbreaker.
SPIDER-MAN is upside down on a piece
of
ice debris, arms raised.
GANDALF leans on his staff and
watches
the sky clearing and allows himself
something that, on his face, passes
for
satisfaction.
GUMBALL – four feet tall, covered in
Antarctic ice, scaffolding pipe
raised –
produces a sound of triumph that is
disproportionate to his size and
correct
in its proportion to his
contribution.
DARWIN beside Seiko. Seiko's
data feeds
showing green across every front, one
by one, as the portals close.
SEIKO does not cheer. He watches the
feeds go green. One front. Two.
Three.
Four. Five. All five green. He takes
off his glasses. He cleans them with
the corner of his shirt. He puts them
back on.
He cries.
With the restraint that he
brings to everything – spine
straight,
face composed, the tears present
anyway
because the restraint has encountered
something larger than it can hold.
He looks at the sky above Antarctica,

which is returning to its ordinary
dark.
He thinks about the coach from Fez.
He thinks about Joseph saying: that
is actually a capability, if you
learn
to use it correctly.
He thinks: yes. It was.
WIDE SHOT: Antarctica. The heroes
among
the ice and the blizzard – which has
resumed, because the Antarctic winter
does not stop for victories – the
golden
light faded, the portals closed, the
sky
ordinary again.
They won.

CUT TO:

INT. THE BLACK CRYSTAL THRONE HALL –

THE SAME MOMENT

The Figure watches the Antarctic
feeds die,
one by one. The holographic displays
of
the battle: going dark.
He watches the last image: Joseph, on
the ice,
caught by Yara, looking at the sky.
He watches the light fading from
Joseph's hands.
He leans forward.

THE FIGURE

(quietly – to the hologram,
to the boy on the ice, to the
specific quality of what he has
just witnessed)
Interesting. Very, very interesting.
He raises one hand. The hologram
dies.
In his other hand, already open,
already
begun: a plan.

He has been smiling since before this
scene
started.
He will be smiling long after it
ends.

ACT SIX

WHAT IS BUILT AFTER

SEQUENCE NINETEEN: THE WHITE HOUSE — THE MEDAL

INT. WHITE HOUSE — EAST HALL — THREE WEEKS LATER

TEXT ON SCREEN: THREE WEEKS AFTER ANTARCTICA.

WASHINGTON, D.C.

The East Hall. A ceremony.
PRESIDENT TRUMP delivers a speech
that is
simultaneously: a recognition of what
happened,
a performance of understanding what
happened,
a genuine expression of gratitude
from someone
who did not understand what was at
stake until
it was over, and an attempt to
position this
as part of a larger American
narrative that
the events do not fully support. He
does it
with the conviction of someone who
finds conviction useful regardless of
content.
Joseph stands in the dark navy suit
that Yara
selected. She had pointed at it
without
hesitation and said "that
one" with the tone
of someone who found the correct
answer
immediately obvious. He had not
argued, because
Yara's certainty in matters she
has considered
is, in his experience, reliably
correct.

THE MEDAL: gold. The Order of the
Greatest
Salvation, the first ever awarded by
unanimous
executive agreement of all five UN
Security
Council permanent members. Engraved
on its face:
SAVIOR OF THE UNIVERSE — THE PERFECT
JOSEPH.
He stands still while it is placed
around
his neck.
He is thinking about his father.
He promised himself, in the moment
the fracture
lines began to seal, that when the
medal was
placed around his neck he would think
about
his father. Not about the medal. Not
about the
ceremony. About Hassan Al-Mithali,
52, standing
at a kitchen counter in the pre-dawn,
making
sandwiches in the dark.
He thinks about him now.
In the FRONT ROW:
SUPERMAN is applauding with the
enthusiasm of someone who has decided
that
appropriate restraint is less
important than
genuine expression. He is also
slightly
glowing, which is involuntary and he
cannot
fully control it under strong
positive emotion.

TONY STARK
(quietly, to Superman)
You might want to dial it back a bit.

SUPERMAN
He saved everything.

TONY STARK
I know. But the glowing is-

SUPERMAN
Everything, Tony.
Superman does not dial it back.
THOR, in the third row, raises
Stormbreaker.
The Asgardian gesture of respect: axe
raised,
head bowed. The lighting in the East
Hall
flickers.
BATMAN, in the back row.
He is smiling.
Not the public Batman expression -
not the
controlled, deliberate, strategic
expression
of someone managing a public
presence. The
actual smile. The one that appears
when
something is, simply and completely,
right.
Small. real.
GUMBALL and DARWIN - who were not
given
information about the dress code and
arrived
in their regular clothes, which in
their case
means brown pants and red sneakers
and nothing
that qualifies as formal - are
standing on
their seats. Jumping up and down.
Gumball
has the chipped yellow mug in his
hand,
which he raises.
SEIKO is crying.
This is the third time Seiko has
cried in
this story. Each time, the Seiko
version: spine straight, face
composed,

the crying present anyway. He watches Joseph at the podium with the expression of someone who has been present for every single step of the journey – the coach from Fez, the parking lot in Marrakech, the bench in Harvard Yard, the dorm room with pastries, the Copley Square sky full of golden doors, the Antarctic ice – and is experiencing the weight of having witnessed all of it. Joseph sees it from the podium. Something crumples pleasantly in his chest. His speech – seventh draft, final version – says one thing: that the medal belongs to the, ordinary human fact of refusing to stop. To everyone who showed up at ten in the evening with pastries and told the truth when the truth was not comfortable. To the people who do not appear in records of extraordinary events but who are the reason the extraordinary is possible. He looks at Seiko when he says it. He looks at Yara. She does not cry. She looks at him with the specific expression she produces when she is witnessing something she intends to keep accurately and permanently. He looks at Gumball, still jumping on the chair. He looks at Darwin.

He does not look at Batman, but he knows Batman is there, in the back row, with the small and real smile. He finishes the speech. He thinks: my father is watching this on his phone in Casablanca, in the kitchen, at the table where they ate sandwiches before the airport, and I would give every medal for one hour of sitting across that table from him right now. He files this. He will be in Casablanca within the month.

SEQUENCE TWENTY: THE MPA

EXT./INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — MIDTOWN MANHATTAN — MONTAGE
The MULTIVERSAL PROTECTION ALLIANCE.

A renovated tower in Midtown Manhattan, seventy stories, built in six weeks using every resource available to the assembled heroes: Tony Stark's active-defense technology integrated into the structure. Doctor Strange's most durable dimensional shielding layered over the exterior. Vibranium infrastructure from Wakanda — T'Challa's contribution, made with the generosity of someone who gives without ledger. A medical wing on the fourteenth floor designed by Yara, who spent three weeks in consultation with doctors from six countries building a facility for the kinds of injury a multiverse

war produces.

A monitoring center on the fortieth floor, designed by Seiko, that manages more simultaneous data streams than any system previously built by human hands, with a processing architecture that Seiko designed in six days and that three MIT professors have since told him should not work the way it works.

And: a cafeteria. That Tony Stark personally supervised. Because Tony Stark decided that the MPA's operational effectiveness depended on its members eating well, and also because Tony Stark discovered he enjoyed designing cafeteria menus, which he will not admit but which is also correct. Three days after the building opens, Joseph finds: MOROCCAN MINT TEA available at all hours. A dedicated machine. The tea from a specific importer in Brooklyn who sources it from a specific producer in Azrou. He had mentioned it once. Offhandedly. In the middle of a debrief, when Tony asked what people would want available on the overnight shift. Joseph had said: tea. Moroccan mint, if possible. Tony had nodded. Not said anything.

JOSEPH
(looking at the machine,

to Tony Stark, who is
casually passing by)
The tea.

TONY STARK

Hm?

JOSEPH

The Moroccan mint tea.

TONY STARK

Oh. Yeah. The overnight shift asked
for it.

JOSEPH

No they did not.

TONY STARK

(a beat – brief, genuine)
No. They did not.
He keeps walking.
Joseph files this under: Tony Stark
pays
closer attention than he appears to.
THE CORE TEAM, assembled:
JOSEPH AL-MITHALI – Director.
SEIKO TOAST – Head of Technology and
Artificial Intelligence.
YARA GORDON – Head of Humanitarian
Affairs
and Psychological Support.
CAPTAIN AMERICA – Master Military
Instructor.
BLACK WIDOW – Chief of Covert
Operations.
HAWKEYE – Field Team Leader.
FALCON – Commander of the Aviation
Unit.
GUMBALL WATTERSON – Morale Consultant
and
Cross-Dimensional Liaison.
DARWIN WATTERSON – Research
Associate,
Dimensional Ecosystem Stability.
Joseph reviews the organizational
chart.

JOSEPH
(to Tony)
Are you certain about those titles?

TONY STARK
Absolutely not. That's how you
know
they're right.

JOSEPH
Gumball's title says
'Morale Consultant.'

TONY STARK
He made seventeen heroes laugh in the
worst thirty seconds of the Antarctic
battle. That's a function.
Functions
get titles.

GUMBALL
(appearing behind them)
I have a title?

TONY STARK
You have a title.

GUMBALL
I have a title at the Multiversal
Protection Alliance.

TONY STARK
Morale Consultant.

GUMBALL
(quietly, to Darwin)
Darwin. I have a title.

DARWIN
(warmly)
I know. It suits you.

**INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — MONITORING ROOM — THREE MONTHS
LATER**

TEXT ON SCREEN: THREE MONTHS LATER.

Joseph stands at the window on the fortieth floor with a coffee that has gone cold. He has been looking at the Manhattan skyline without registering it for approximately nine minutes, which means he has been thinking about something specific for nine minutes and using the skyline as a background. YARA enters. She looks at the coffee cup.

YARA

That one is cold.

JOSEPH

I know.
She puts a new one beside him. She sits on the edge of his desk with her own.

YARA

Thinking about something specific?

JOSEPH

About the beginning. About how bad the first morning was. The gate. The glasses.
The punch.
He smiles at the window.

JOSEPH

And how it led here.

YARA

That is the thing about terrible mornings.
You cannot tell, while you are in them,
which one is the first morning of the rest of everything.

JOSEPH

Do you still think about it? Brian?

YARA

I think about the bench. The fountain.
You and Seiko with the cracked glasses,
your papers on the ground. And you said:
we earned our place. We belong here.
She looks at her coffee.

YARA

I think about deciding to walk over.
To sit down across from you. I do not regret it.

JOSEPH

Neither do I.
A pause. Long enough to mean something.

JOSEPH

Yara. At the party—

YARA

(quietly)
I know which moment you mean.

JOSEPH

Antarctica. The siege machine. I tried to finish the sentence and didn't.

YARA

I remember.

JOSEPH

I will finish it. Not here. Not like this. But I will finish it. I want you to know that I intend to finish it.
She looks at him. The full assessment.

YARA

I know you will.

JOSEPH

Good.
The door opens. SEIKO, at a velocity
that
communicates urgency.

SEIKO
Joseph. Signal. Stable. London, near
Tower Bridge. Small – approximately
basketball-sized rupture. Blue light.
Contained. Clearly intentional.
He shows Joseph the dimensional
readout.

JOSEPH
That is not residual. That was opened
deliberately, from outside, with
precision.

SEIKO
Yes. Which means someone knows enough
about the dimensional framework –
after the fractures sealed – to open
a controlled breach of exactly that
size without triggering the
monitoring
systems except at the highest
sensitivity.
They look at each other.

SEIKO
I would prefer it if this were a
coincidence.

JOSEPH
So would I.

EXT. TOWER BRIDGE APPROACH, LONDON – LATER THAT DAY

At the base of a lamppost on the north Tower
Bridge approach: the rupture. Basketball-sized,
glowing with controlled blue light, stable as
a flame in a windless room.
Clearly intentional.
What comes through: a single leaf of paper.

Aged. Yellowed at the folds. Handwriting that is elegant and completely steady, the handwriting of someone with access to time enough to make the marks carefully.

Joseph reads it.

CLOSE ON THE LETTER:

"To the Protector of the Earth –
Your victory in the first war was impressive. But it was the beginning, not the conclusion. Greater powers are watching now. Greater threats are preparing. The second war is coming. This time, it will not be the worlds in danger.

It will be time itself.

The one who orchestrated the first war is not yet done. He was watching you on the ice. He found you interesting. He will come with patience and with intelligence, and he will strike at what you love before he strikes at you.

Be ready.

– Time Tracker

Joseph folds the letter.

He looks at the Thames. At the city. At the ordinary world, continuing – the buses and the bridges and the people who did not come to the meeting but whose world was what was at stake in it.

He puts the letter in his coat pocket.

Next to a kefta sandwich wrapper, slightly

aged, that he has never quite been able
to throw away.

CAPTAIN AMERICA
(beside him)
It never ends. You should know that.
Whatever you thought the end looked
like—

JOSEPH
I never thought it ended. I just
thought
there would be a pause.

CAPTAIN AMERICA
There's a pause. Right now.
We're in it.
Use it.

JOSEPH
Yes.
He looks at his team. At Seiko
reading over
his shoulder with organized alarm
that he
is organizing as he reads. At Yara,
who
has already understood the
implication and
is processing it with the focused
assessment
of someone who prepares by thinking
clearly
about difficult things.
At Gumball and Darwin.
At the river.

JOSEPH
Let us go to work.

INT. BLACK CRYSTAL THRONE HALL — THE SAME MOMENT

The Figure watches the Thames through a hologram.
The letter. Joseph reading it. Joseph's face.

THE FIGURE

(to the hologram — quietly,
appreciatively, with the
pleasure of someone who has
made a move in a long game and
watched it land exactly where
it was intended)
Come to me when you are ready,
Perfect Joseph.
I have all the time in every world.
He raises one hand. The hologram
dies.
He was smiling before this scene
began.
PULL BACK slowly from the throne hall
— the
Figure becoming a silhouette, then a
shape,
then a point of darkness in a
darkness that
is building toward something that has
been
building for a long time.
Then:

EXT. HARVARD YARD — FOUNTAIN BENCH — FLASHBACK

(SEPTEMBER 3)

The bench. The fountain. September morning.

The fog burned away.

Seiko and Joseph, side by side.

Yara approaches.

Three feet away. Looking at them with the
direct, unsentimental concern of someone
who has identified a situation and decided
to respond to it.

She sits across from them.

Everything begins.

HOLD. The three of them. The bench. The fountain.

The carved stone rim. The September sky.

The SCORE: low and Arabic, then orchestral,

then both together. The sound of this story.

FADE TO BLACK.

"From one weakness was born infinite power."

TITLE CARD FADES IN:

THE PERFECT JOSEPH AND GUMBALL:

THE MULTIVERSAL SAGA
PART ONE: DAWN OF THE CHAMPIONSHIP
"From one weakness was born
infinite power."
For Seiko Toast.
The best friend anyone ever had.

FADE OUT.

POST-CREDITS SCENE

INT. COSMIC VAULT — ARCTIC RIDGE — NIGHT

TEXT ON SCREEN: ONE YEAR LATER.

The most secure facility in any surveyed
dimension. Built into a granite ridge forty
kilometers north of Resolute Bay. Vibranium-
reinforced walls. Doctor Strange's best
containment seals — the kind that hold
things that cannot be held by physics alone.
Twenty-seven separate security protocols,
each one verified every six minutes.

The lights are on.

They should not be.

The security feeds show: all twenty-seven
protocols intact. No breach. No alarm.

No evidence of entry.

But the lights are on.

A CRACK opens in the air of the main corridor – not a dimensional portal, not the kind of breach the MPA's monitoring systems are calibrated to detect. A TEMPORAL CRACK.

Gold and silver and the color of bronze light and something else: the color of time as a material, layered on itself, a patina of moments accumulated until they have become visible.

A tall figure steps through. Purple cloak. Moving with the absolute patience of something that has been building toward this for ten thousand years and has learned, through that building, to move as if the destination is already reached.

KRONOS – Master of Temporal Dimensions. He moves through the facility with complete knowledge: every code, every override, every point in the security architecture where time, applied precisely, becomes a key. He knows these things the way that a locksmith knows locks: by their history. He reaches CELL BLOCK X.

He pauses outside the door.

He does not check anything. He does not hesitate. He simply pauses – the pause of someone savoring the moment before the thing that has been prepared for.

He opens the door.

Inside: a room in complete dark.

A man in a suit, sitting. Not slumped – sitting precisely, the sit of someone who decided, at some point in the time he has been here, that posture was a form of resistance. Sitting in the dark with the patience of a person who knew, with complete certainty, exactly when this door would open. The man looks up. He has been smiling since before Kronos opened the door. JEFFREY EPSTEIN stands. He straightens his jacket with the care of someone for whom appearance is not vanity but communication. He looks at the open door. He does not look surprised. He does not look relieved. He looks satisfied. The satisfaction of someone who bet on a specific outcome over a long horizon and is watching the outcome arrive exactly on schedule. Kronos speaks. His voice: ancient, cold, the cold of something that has existed long enough to find warmth an interesting local phenomenon.

KRONOS

Tell the boy the Devil says hello. Epstein looks at the open door. At the corridor beyond. At the temporal crack in the air, still glowing with gold and bronze. He says nothing.

He does not need to say anything.
Everything
he needs to communicate is already in
motion —
in the network he built before he was
contained, which has been running
without him,
which has been doing what networks do
when
their architect is removed: adapting,
growing,
finding its own direction.
He walks out.
HOLD ON THE EMPTY CELL.
The open door. The dark room. The
suit jacket
that was hung, while he was sitting,
precisely
on the corner of the chair.
Something is coming.
Something that has been patient.

SMASH TO BLACK.

THE PERFECT JOSEPH AND GUMBALL: THE MULTIVERSAL SAGA
PART TWO: THE DEVIL YOU DON'T KNOW

COMING SOON
END OF PART ONE

CAST

YOUSSEF BOUTAHRI
as JOSEPH AL-MITHALI / 'The
Perfect Joseph'
Director of the MPA

JAHZIR BRUNO
as SEIKO TOAST
Head of Technology & AI — The
Best Friend

JORDYN RAYA JAMES
as YARA GORDON
Head of Humanitarian Affairs

JACOB HOPKINS
as GUMBALL WATTERSON
Voice & Motion Capture

DANNY PUDI / TERREL RANSOM JR.
as DARWIN WATTERSON
Voice & Motion Capture
NISRINE ERRADI — FATIMA AL-MITHALI
ROSHDY ZEM — HASSAN AL-MITHALI
MERYEM TOUZANI — NADIA AL-MITHALI
HIROYUKI SANADA — KENJI TOAST
MICHELLE YEOH — MIYUKI TOAST
MAHERSHA ALI — DR. ELLISON
JOE KEERY — BRIAN MCKENZIE
PEYTON ELIZABETH LEE — EMILY CHEN
LETITIA WRIGHT — SARAH OSEI
HENRY CAVILL — SUPERMAN / CLARK KENT
BEN AFFLECK — BATMAN / BRUCE WAYNE
ROBERT DOWNEY JR. — TONY STARK / IRON
MAN
CHRIS HEMSWORTH — THOR
GAL GADOT — WONDER WOMAN
BENEDICT CUMBERBATCH — DOCTOR STRANGE
CHRIS EVANS — CAPTAIN AMERICA
IAN MCKELLEN — GANDALF THE GREY
DANIEL RADCLIFFE — HARRY POTTER
EMMA WATSON — HERMIONE GRANGER
RUPERT GRINT — RON WEASLEY
MARK RUFFALO — BRUCE BANNER / THE
HULK
SCARLETT JOHANSSON — BLACK WIDOW
JEREMY RENNER — HAWKEYE
TOM HOLLAND — SPIDER-MAN
CHADWICK BOSEMAN — BLACK PANTHER /
T'CHALLA
ELIZABETH OLSEN — SCARLET WITCH /
WANDA MAXIMOFF
JOSH BROLIN — THANOS
JOAQUIN PHOENIX — THE JOKER
RAY PORTER — DARKSEID
RALPH FIENNES — VOLDEMORT
KEANU REEVES — JOHN WICK / NEO
VIGGO MORTENSEN — ARAGORN / STRIDER
EZRA MILLER — THE FLASH / BARRY ALLEN
ANTHONY MACKIE — SAM WILSON / FALCON
SAMUEL L. JACKSON — NICK FURY
BENEDICT WONG — WONG

MARK HAMILL — LUKE SKYWALKER
PEDRO PASCAL — DIN DJARIN / JOEL
MILLER
TOM HIDDLESTON — LOKI
TESSA THOMPSON — VALKYRIE
LUPITA NYONG'O — NAKIA
WINSTON DUKE — M'BAKU
FLORENCE PUGH — YELENA BELOVA
MAISIE WILLIAMS — ARYA STARK
PETER DINKLAGE — TYRION LANNISTER
EMILIA CLARKE — DAENERYS TARGARYEN
KIT HARINGTON — JON SNOW
ELIJAH WOOD — FRODO BAGGINS
ORLANDO BLOOM — LEGOLAS / WILLIAM
TURNER
EWAN MCGREGOR — OBI-WAN KENOBI

GIANCARLO ESPOSITO
as KRONOS
Master of Temporal Dimensions • Post-
Credits
BILL SKARSGÅRD
as JEFFREY EPSTEIN / 'THE
DEVIL';
Post-Credits
Music by: HANS ZIMMER & RYO
YOSHIMATA
Cinematography: ROGER DEAKINS, ASC,
BSC
Production Design: PATRICE VERMETTE
Visual Effects Supervisor: DAN
DELEEUW
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EXTENDED SEQUENCES

SEQUENCE THREE-B: THE FIRST WEEK

INT. HARVARD — EMERSON HALL CORRIDOR — DAY

The corridor between lectures. Students moving in both directions with the controlled urgency of people who have decided that the forty-seven minutes between classes must be useful.

Joseph and Seiko walk against the current.

Seiko has a new notebook — identical to the old one except the cover is fresh. He has already filled eleven pages, which he considers behind schedule.

SEIKO

The notation system in the theoretical physics course uses modified Dirac bra-ket notation for the quantum state vectors, but the second problem set suggests Heisenberg picture rather than Schrodinger picture as the default framework. The two are equivalent but the choice has implications for how the homework is graded.

JOSEPH

I noticed.

SEIKO

Did you find a preferred approach?

JOSEPH

I asked Dr. Ellison after class. She said either is acceptable if the reasoning is

explicit. So I will use Heisenberg
picture
because the operators evolving in
time
feels more honest to how the system
actually works.

SEIKO
(writing this down)
You use language like this and I do
not
think you notice when you do it.

JOSEPH
What language?

SEIKO
You describe mathematical choices in
moral
terms. Honest. Fair. Right. As though
the
equations have an ethical dimension.
Joseph considers this. He does not dismiss it.

JOSEPH
I think they do. The choice of
framework
is a claim about what is true. Claims
about truth have an ethical
dimension.

SEIKO
(pausing in the corridor – this
costs him because he has six
minutes to the next lecture)
I had not considered it that way. I
will
think about it.

JOSEPH
Good. Think about it while we walk.
They continue. A professor arguing with a
graduate student about methodology. Two freshmen
with the glazed look of people realizing everyone
here is as smart as they are.

SEIKO

(after sixty seconds)
If mathematical choices are ethical
claims,
then the history of mathematics is
also
a moral history.

JOSEPH

Yes. I think it is.

SEIKO

Then Godel's incompleteness theorems
are
not just logical — they are humble.
They
are a claim that the system cannot
fully
know itself. That is a moral
position.

JOSEPH

Exactly that. Yes.
Seiko writes something in his notebook without
stopping walking. He has practiced this since
he was eleven, identifying it as an efficiency gap.

SEIKO

Joseph.

JOSEPH

Yes.

SEIKO

I find Harvard difficult. Not
academically.
The academic difficulty is expected
and
manageable. I find the texture of it
difficult. The number of unspoken
rules.
The way certain students seem to
already
know how to be here in a way I cannot
identify by watching and reproducing.

JOSEPH

I know. I find it difficult too.

SEIKO

Do you? You seem comfortable.

JOSEPH

I seem it. The seeming is work.

A pause. Seiko processes this seriously.

SEIKO

You expend energy on appearing
comfortable
that could be used for other things.

JOSEPH

Yes. But the alternative is to appear
uncomfortable, and that costs
something
different. So I decided that the
appearing-comfortable cost is lower.

SEIKO

This is a resource allocation
problem.

JOSEPH

Most social problems are.

SEIKO

I had not framed it this way. Framing
it
this way makes it — not manageable.
But
comprehensible. And comprehensible is
a step toward manageable.

They reach the lecture hall door. Seiko holds it
open — his standard procedure for ensuring both
of them enter at maximum efficiency.

SEIKO

Thank you. For the framing.

JOSEPH

It helps me too. Saying it to someone

makes the problem real. The problem
 is
 real and the approach to it is real.
They go in.

INT. DR. ELLISON'S OFFICE — THEORETICAL PHYSICS

DEPARTMENT — AFTERNOON

A professor's office honest about itself: books
on every horizontal surface including the
windowsill, a whiteboard covered in equations
never erased because erasing loses the thread,
a coffee cup that has been full and empty many
times and now is both in some theoretical sense.
DR. ELLISON, 50s, sits across from Joseph with
the engaged attention she brings to everything
interesting.

 DR. ELLISON
Your question in lecture today. The
one
about the observer and observed in
quantum
versus classical contexts. You were
not
asking about the physics.

 JOSEPH
No. I was asking about the philosophy
of
measurement. Whether the act of
measuring
something is itself a claim about
what
the thing is.

 DR. ELLISON
And your current position?

 JOSEPH
I think measurement is always an
intervention. The measuring device is

never neutral. The framework we use
to
observe is not a window – it is a
lens.
And lenses have shapes. The shape of
the lens determines what we see.
DR. ELLISON leans back. The expression of someone
who has been thinking about a problem for thirty
years and heard a student phrase part of it more
cleanly.

DR. ELLISON
You are describing – in the language
of
physics – what philosophers of
science
have been arguing since Kuhn. The
paradigm
is not just a method. It is a claim
about
the nature of the thing being
studied.

JOSEPH
Yes. And so the choice of paradigm is
not
neutral. It has consequences for what
you find.

DR. ELLISON
Which is terrifying if you think
about it
fully.

JOSEPH
Or liberating. If the lens shapes
what
you see, then a different lens might
reveal
something the current framework
systematically cannot see.
A beat. She studies him.

DR. ELLISON

Where did you develop this way of thinking?

JOSEPH

My father is a math teacher. He kept his lesson plans for twenty years. I read some of them when I was seventeen. The margins were full of notes about students – which approach worked for which learner, what the framework was missing, where to try differently. He treated teaching as an empirical problem. The same student failing twice means the method failed, not the student.

Dr. Ellison is quiet.

DR. ELLISON

He sounds worth emulating.

JOSEPH

He is the most rigorous person I know. He applies the rigor to people instead of equations.

DR. ELLISON

Some would argue those are the same thing.

She picks up a paper. Sets it down. Looks at him.

DR. ELLISON

I want to offer you something. A research position starting second semester in the quantum decoherence lab. Work-study. Not

funded, but the work is genuine and
the
questions are open.
Joseph gives it three honest seconds.

JOSEPH
Yes. I would like that very much.

DR. ELLISON
Good.
She makes a note.

DR. ELLISON
One more thing. The reason your
question
is the right question is that it has
no
answer yet. The questions without
answers
are the useful ones. The ones with
answers
are already finished.

JOSEPH
My father says the same thing. He
calls
it the productive uncertainty.

DR. ELLISON
Your father and I would get along.

EXT. HARVARD — MEMORIAL HALL STEPS — EVENING

The blue hour. Brick buildings holding the last
warmth of the day against the coming dark.
Joseph sits on the steps. He is calling home.

NADIA
(O.S., immediately)
You were supposed to call Sunday. It
is
Thursday.

JOSEPH
I know. This week has been —

NADIA

I do not want the version you tell
parents.

The actual version.

He almost smiles. The airport. The actual things.

JOSEPH

The actual version: the first day, a
boy

named Brian knocked me down in
Harvard Yard

and poured red punch on me at a party
because he found my presence amusing.

I
stood still through both events and
then went home and stared at the
window

for forty minutes.

Silence on the line.

NADIA

(then, not quietly)

What is his last name.

JOSEPH

Nadia —

NADIA

I am asking for information purposes.

JOSEPH

McKenzie. And I do not want you to do
anything. I am fine.

NADIA

You stood still while someone poured
punch on you. That is not fine,
Joseph.

That is survival mode.

JOSEPH

(a beat — she is correct)

Yes. It was. But I survived. And I
met

someone who brought pastries at ten
o'clock and told me something true.

NADIA
What did she say?

JOSEPH
She said: you deserve to be here. Not
as comfort. As fact.
Through the phone: the Casablanca evening. A
television somewhere. The jasmine outside that
he cannot smell from here but knows is there.

NADIA
(quietly)
She is right.

JOSEPH
I know.

NADIA
Are you eating?

JOSEPH
My friend Seiko brought twelve
containers
of oatmeal.

NADIA
I like Seiko already. He sounds
organized.

JOSEPH
He has a spreadsheet for his
spreadsheets.

NADIA
Good. You need someone organized. You
lose your phone charger every four
days.

JOSEPH
Every six days.

NADIA
I have the data, Joseph. Every four.
He laughs. A real laugh — the first since the
airport. It comes out without warning, which is

how the best ones arrive.

JOSEPH
I miss you, Nadia.

NADIA
(the pause that is its own
answer)
I know. Call Sunday. For real. The
actual
version.

JOSEPH
The actual one. I promise.
He ends the call. He sits on the steps as the
last light fades from the brick. He thinks about
what she said. You were supposed to call Sunday.
As if time had a structure, and the structure
mattered, and the mattering was its own form
of love.

INT. JOSEPH AND SEIKO'S DORM — LATE NIGHT

Eleven-thirty P.M. Four hours of study. The table:
problem sets, both notebooks, seven empty oatmeal
containers stacked with geometric precision.
They work in the comfortable silence of people
who have found that working in proximity changes
the quality of the work — the presence of another
person engaged in the same problem creates a
pressure that makes the problem easier, not harder.
Joseph puts his pen down.

JOSEPH
Do you think about home?
Seiko does not look up.

SEIKO
In what sense?

JOSEPH

In the sense of wanting to be there.

SEIKO

(putting his pen down — this
merits full attention)
I think about my mother's cooking on
Sundays. A miso that has been in the
family for three generations, the
recipe
passed through mothers who adjusted
it
without writing the adjustments down.
The soup is a record of accumulated
decisions no one documented. I think
about the soup.

JOSEPH

That is precise homesickness.

SEIKO

I find it more manageable to be
homesick
for something exact. A general
homesickness
for "home" has no defined boundary
and
therefore no defined end. A
homesickness
for the soup at least has an
endpoint:
when I next have the soup.

JOSEPH

When will that be?

SEIKO

Winter break. December twenty-second.
I have already calculated the hours.

JOSEPH

(smiling)
How many?

SEIKO

I would rather not say. It makes me
sound as though I am struggling.

JOSEPH
You are allowed to struggle.

SEIKO
(quietly)
I know. But I prefer not to be
observed
doing it. In Morocco, do people
discuss
struggling openly?

JOSEPH
My father would say: struggle is not
weakness. Hiding the struggle is what
costs you most, because then you
carry
it alone instead of distributing the
weight.

SEIKO
That is actually very efficient.

JOSEPH
He is a very efficient person.

SEIKO
(after a moment)
The thing I find hardest is not the
work.
It is the feeling of being
translated.
As if I am not quite myself in
English.
The version of me that exists in
Japanese
is more complete. More fluent in its
own
thinking. The English version is a
translation, and translations always
lose something.
Joseph has felt this too – the Darija version
of himself, the Arabic version, the French
version, and now the English version. Each one
slightly different. Each one losing something
the others carry.

JOSEPH

I know exactly what you mean. My
Darija
self makes jokes my English self
cannot
find. My Arabic self has access to a
register of feeling that English does
not have the vocabulary for.

SEIKO

Japanese has mono no aware. The
bittersweet
awareness of impermanence. No English
equivalent carries the same weight.

JOSEPH

Arabic has mushtaaq. A longing so
precise
it knows exactly what it misses and
when
it started.

SEIKO

Perhaps we are not translated but
multilayered. Not a single self lost
in
translation but multiple selves that
can
speak different truths.

A pause. Joseph picks up his pen.

JOSEPH

That is a better way to think about
it.

SEIKO

Yes. I will use it.

A knock at the door.

It is Yara. Textbook, reading glasses, a bag
with three cups of tea from the all-night place
on Mass Ave.

YARA

I saw your lights on. I have a
question

about the mirror neuron paper and I
do
not want to ask it to myself anymore.

SEIKO

(already making room at the
table)

Sit down. We have questions too.
She sits. She pours the tea. The three of them
fall back into work with the easy distribution
of people who have found their frequency together.
This becomes the pattern for the rest of the
semester. Late nights. Tea from Mass Ave. The
three of them at the table, building something
without knowing what they are building.
The clock: 11:47 P.M.
One night from now – or a month, or three weeks –
the sky will change.
But not tonight. Tonight they work.

INT. HARVARD – YARD – FRIDAY AFTERNOON

The Yard in mid-afternoon October sun. Tourists
with the reverence of people who believe the
buildings contain something transferable by
proximity. Students on the grass – reading,
existing, using the gaps between things.
Joseph sits near the Widener Library. He is not
reading. He is watching the light on the stone
facade – the way October sun hits it at this
hour and produces a warmth the building seems
to remember having.
He is thinking about his father's classroom.
The lamplight. The lesson plan. The twenty years

of paying attention recorded in that ink.
He thinks: what is the equivalent of that here?
What is the record of this place's attention to
the people who came through it?
He looks at the library. Twelve million volumes.
The accumulated product of every person who
decided that something worth knowing was also
worth writing down.
That is the record. Not the stones. The books.
YARA sits down beside him.

YARA

You have been staring at the library
for fourteen minutes.

JOSEPH

How do you know?

YARA

I walked past twenty minutes ago. You
were at the start of a thought. I
walked
past again just now. You look like
you
finished it.

JOSEPH

I did.

YARA

What was it?

JOSEPH

I was thinking about records. How a
teacher keeps a record of attention
in
the margins of a lesson plan. How a
library keeps a record of everything
worth knowing. Both of these are the
same impulse: the belief that what
you
notice, if you write it down, becomes

available to someone who was not
there.
Yara draws her knees up. The listening posture
she uses when something is worth listening to
fully: still, oriented, processing behind her eyes.

YARA
Your father?

JOSEPH
Yes.

YARA
You talk about him the way people
talk
about someone they are trying to
become.

JOSEPH
(honestly)
I think that is correct. The ambition
I
have — not the academic one, the
deeper
one — is to pay attention the way he
pays
attention. To thirty years of
students,
each one individually, with care for
the
way that particular student fails to
understand a particular thing. That
kind
of attention is its own form of
genius.

YARA
You don't usually hear that word
applied
to that kind of work.

JOSEPH
What word?

YARA

Genius. You usually hear it applied
to
people who do things alone that no
one
else can do. Your father does
something
in relationship — with students, over
time. That is a different
architecture
of intelligence.

JOSEPH

The relationship architecture. Yes.

YARA

My mother is a doctor. The same thing
—
thirty years of patients, each one
remembered. She knows things about
families she learned in offhand
remarks
fifteen years ago. She files
everything.
The filing is how she helps.

JOSEPH

It is how my father teaches. The
filing
of the individual case so that the
individual case can be served.

A pause. The October sun on the Widener stone.

YARA

Do you know what you want to do?
After
Harvard. With the physics.

JOSEPH

Honestly?

YARA

I only accept that version.

JOSEPH

I want to find something no one has
thought to look for because the
current

framework does not have language for it.
I do not know what it is yet. But I know the shape of the looking – it looks like my father's lesson plan margins. It looks like paying attention to the thing the current theory cannot explain.

YARA
The anomaly.

JOSEPH
Yes. Where the model breaks is where the new model begins.
She looks at him.

YARA
You will find it.
Not as comfort. As the output of an assessment.

JOSEPH
How do you know?

YARA
Because you are the kind of person who sees what is actually there rather than what you expect to be there. That is rarer than intelligence. It is the prerequisite of intelligence applied correctly.

JOSEPH
Thank you for sitting down.

YARA
Thank you for finishing the thought before I arrived.
She gets up. She has a lab meeting at three.
She goes.
Joseph sits on the grass a while longer. He looks at the library. At the twelve million

volumes. At the record of everything worth noticing, written down.

He thinks: I will add to it. Not today. But eventually. Something that no one has language for yet.

He picks up his notebook. He goes to class.

SEQUENCE FIVE-B: INSIDE THE DISSOLUTION

INT./EXT. THE VORTEX — THE CENTER — TIMELESS

In the dissolution, Joseph sees other things. Not visions. Not films. The dissolution does not show him images — it shows him frequencies. The note of each possible future, felt rather than seen. He moves through them the way a person moves through a room in the dark, identifying objects by touch.

He finds his father.

Not Hassan Al-Mithali — but the frequency Hassan produces. The accumulated product of thirty years of paying attention to the individual case. The note of someone who has decided that each student on each day is worth the full weight of his attention.

Joseph finds this frequency and it is enormous. Not loud. Enormous. The size of something built over decades through daily practice. The size of something that accumulates.

He finds Seiko.

The frequency Seiko produces: precision at the service of care. The note of someone who organizes

everything because the organizing is how he loves – twelve containers of oatmeal arranged in two-by-six formation because the arrangement expresses the care. The meticulous notes in every textbook because attention recorded is attention preserved. The straight spine and the large glasses and the disciplined terror of someone who has decided that preparation is the form his courage takes.

He finds Yara.

The frequency Yara produces: toward. Always toward. The note of someone who moves toward the bad things rather than away from them because moving toward is the most available form of power, and Yara has decided that power must be used or it is failure. The note of someone who sat down at a fountain bench across from strangers with cracked glasses because the situation called for it and she is the kind of person who responds to calls.

He finds Nadia.

The frequency his sister produces: laughter from the floor. The note of someone who falls off the couch and keeps laughing from where she lands because the interruption of the fall is not a reason to stop being delighted. The note of someone who said: the actual version. Not the version for parents. The actual one.

He finds his mother.

Fatima Al-Mithali's frequency: the pre-dawn quiet of the nursing uniform, the efficient motion of someone who has organized her mornings around the

people she loves, the extra square of foil around the olive because extra care is available and she will provide it.

He does not find a weapon. He does not find armor. He finds a choir.

A collection of frequencies that have been building in parallel, toward this exact moment, in this exact center, where they are needed.

He thinks: I am not the source. I am never the source. I am the place where these frequencies meet and become something that can be directed.

He thinks: that is enough. That is more than enough.

The dissolution shows him one more thing.

The framework itself – not as structure, not as architecture, but as a sound. The dimensional framework: the accumulated note of every world that has ever built anything worth keeping. Every story that produced a hero. Every universe that decided something good was worth building. Every dimension that said: here is the wall, and behind it, we protect what we love.

The largest sound he has ever heard.

It has been there always, beneath the frequency of every individual thing: the ground note of the cosmos. The note of refusal. Of continuation. Of the decision – made in each generation, each story, each world – to keep building the wall.

He thinks: I can transmit this. I am built to transmit this. Whatever the vortex did to me was built to transmit exactly this.

Three seconds. The dissolution ends.
He falls.
But he falls knowing what he carries.

SEQUENCE SEVEN-B: ELMORE — THE AFTERNOON

INT. WATTERSON HOUSE — LIVING ROOM — AFTERNOON

Gumball has made tea. Wrong by any real-world standard — the mug is wrong, the temperature cartoon-precise rather than actual, the steam rising in a single perfect spiral. But the gesture is right. Entirely right.

GUMBALL

Okay. So. You are from the real world.
The world where we are a TV show.

JOSEPH

Yes.

GUMBALL

And in the real world, people watched our show.

JOSEPH

Many people. For years.

GUMBALL

(processing — this is both
flattering and destabilizing)
So people in your world know
everything
that happened to us? The talent show?
The pizza incident?

JOSEPH

Most of it.

GUMBALL

(to Darwin)
Darwin. People in the real world know

about the pizza incident.

DARWIN

I am aware of what that implies for our privacy, Gumball.

GUMBALL

It was an accident. In case anyone in the real world is judging. The pizza was not supposed to –

JOSEPH

We are not judging.

GUMBALL

Good. Great. Okay.
He drinks his cartoon tea. Then:

GUMBALL

Do you know how it ends? The show.
In your world, do people know how our story ends?
A pause. Joseph chooses honesty.

JOSEPH

The show ended. Your story ended.
But I am here talking to you, so –

GUMBALL

(understanding this)
Maybe the ending was not really the ending. Maybe the ending was just the end of the part that was being watched.

DARWIN

That is a very comforting way to think about it.

GUMBALL

I am capable of comfort. I am a very comforting person.
Darwin gives him the look of someone who loves him enough to say nothing.

SEIKO

(from the corner, running
calculations, trying not to
be visibly overwhelmed by
existing inside a cartoon)
The world crash rate is accelerating.
We have less time than I initially
calculated. The digital substrate is
degrading at approximately three
percent
per hour. At current rate: forty
minutes
before critical failure.

Everyone looks at the window. Elmore still
Elmore, but the edges have started – buildings
in the distance flickering, the world asserting
and then doubting itself.

DARWIN

Our family is at the mall.
The weight of this settles.

GUMBALL

Mom and Dad and Anais.
He moves to the window and looks at the
flickering city.
Nicole and Richard Watterson. At the mall.
In a world with forty minutes before
critical failure.

JOSEPH

Where is the mall?

GUMBALL

Twelve blocks. But –
He stops. He is calculating something his face
shows he does not want to calculate: the time
required to reach twelve blocks, get his family,
and return before forty minutes elapsed.

DARWIN

(quietly)

Gumball.

GUMBALL

I know.

DARWIN

The crack. If we go to the mall and
come back and the crack has sealed –

GUMBALL

I know, Darwin.

DARWIN

We have to choose.
The Watterson living room. The flickering window.
The chipped yellow mug. The drawings on the
refrigerator. The forty minutes.
Gumball stands at the window and looks at his
city. Every block known. Every corner carrying
memory. His family somewhere in twelve blocks
of cartoon world with thirty-eight minutes left.

GUMBALL

(quietly)

Can you – is there any way to –

JOSEPH

If I open the crack again on this
side.
After we cross. I do not know if I
can.
The ability only manifested when the
barriers began to fail. I do not know
if I can generate it deliberately.

GUMBALL

But maybe.

JOSEPH

Maybe.
Gumball turns from the window.

GUMBALL

Darwin. We are going to get Mom and Dad and Anais. And then we are going to trust Joseph to open a door.
Darwin looks at Joseph.

DARWIN
Can you do that?
Joseph thinks about the dissolution. About the frequency of refusal. About what is needed versus what is possible.

JOSEPH
I do not know. But I will try.

GUMBALL
That is good enough.
He grabs his jacket from the hook – the cartoon jacket of every episode, every adventure – and goes. Darwin follows.
Joseph, Seiko, and Yara look at each other.

YARA
We go with them.

JOSEPH
Yes.

EXT. ELMORE – THE STREETS – AFTERNOON (RAPID SEQUENCE)

Running through cartoon streets that are beginning to fail.

All five of them at full speed through Elmore.
The city in a state of increasing unreality: lampposts appearing and disappearing, the sky cycling through saturations outside its normal range, a bus frozen mid-route at an intersection where the road has briefly ceased to exist.
The people of Elmore: suspended, looping, caught in the substrate failure's contractions.

Faces of people Gumball has known his whole life,
frozen between moments.

He does not look at them. Looking costs something
and he cannot afford the cost right now.

They reach the mall in nine minutes.

ELMORE MALL. The food court. The familiar
locations of a hundred episodes.

NICOLE WATTERSON – blue cat, terrifying
competence – stands in the center of the food
court with RICHARD WATTERSON – pink rabbit,
enormous, processing things at his own pace –
and ANAIS WATTERSON – small, pink, the most
intelligent member of the family by every
measurable standard.

The food court flickering. Franchise restaurants
cycling through their logos. Food in display cases
appearing and not appearing.

Nicole takes in the situation in one second.

NICOLE

What is happening to the world.

GUMBALL

Mom. I will explain everything. We
need to go. Right now. These people
are real – from the real world – and
they can get us out before –

NICOLE

Before the world ends. I can see the
code, Gumball. I have been able to
see
the code for twenty minutes and I
have
been trying to figure out what to do
about it.

She looks at Joseph.

NICOLE

You opened the dimensional door. I
can
see the residual frequency around
you.
Where does it go?

JOSEPH

The real world. Three-dimensional. It
requires adjustment. But it is safe.
Richard has been looking at Joseph.

RICHARD

You are very textured.

JOSEPH

Yes.

RICHARD

Is that normal? In the real world?

JOSEPH

It is.

RICHARD

(nodding, filing this)

Okay. I can work with that.

ANNAIS has already assessed the situation.

ANNAIS

The code degradation is non-linear.
We
have less time than you think. We
should
go. Now. Questions later.

GUMBALL

(to the group)

What she said.

They go.

EXT. WATTERSON HOUSE — MINUTES LATER

Back at the house. The crack: still there, still
glowing, but narrower — the substrate failure
closing it from the edges inward.

Nicole looks at the crack. At Joseph.

NICOLE
Can you widen it?

JOSEPH
I am going to try.
He closes his eyes. He reaches for the frequency.
The transmitter function. He tries to direct it
not outward, not at a sky full of heroes, but at
this one narrow crack in this one animated wall.
The crack widens.
Not the golden doors – not the enormous dimensional
openings above Boston. This is smaller, more precise:
the careful widening of one door. The light through
it: real-world light. Three-dimensional, with depth
and shadow and the texture of actual light on
actual surfaces.
Gumball looks at the crack. Then at the house.
The drawings on the refrigerator. The couch where
every Saturday happened.

GUMBALL
(to the house – not to anyone,
to the house itself)
We are coming back.

DARWIN
(beside him, softly)
Yes. We are.
They go through.
Behind them, the world of Elmore – the most
amazing town in the world – flickers once, twice,
and holds. The substrate failure, without the
directional pressure driving it, loses momentum.
The code stabilizes. The world continues.

It will be there when they come back.

EXT. SOUTH BOSTON — SIDEWALK — CONTINUOUS

The crossing. Nicole: fast and certain. Richard: slow, accompanied by the expression of someone experiencing several things simultaneously and filing them for later. Anais: careful, measuring, making mental records.

Gumball: at the moment of crossing — one foot in Elmore, one foot in the real world — he turns back. He looks at the living room.

One second. He gives it one second.

Then he steps through.

Three-dimensional. Standing on a sidewalk that has the weight and texture of something that actually exists.

Nicole looks at her hands.

NICOLE

Three-dimensional. Alright. Where do we need to be?

Richard presses his three-dimensional hand against the pavement.

RICHARD

This is very dense.

ANAIS

(observing the damaged city,
the smoke, the abandoned cars)
We have larger problems than the
density.
What happened here?

JOSEPH

Everything. All at once. We need to
get you somewhere safe while we —

NICOLE

(flat)

I do not go somewhere safe while
my children are in danger.

JOSEPH

Your children are with me.

NICOLE

Then I am with you.

Joseph looks at her. At the expression of someone
who has been the most dangerous entity in every
room she has entered for her entire adult life and
has no intention of changing this.

He looks at Gumball. Gumball gives him the look
of someone who grew up with this woman and has
never successfully argued her out of a decision.

JOSEPH

(to Nicole)

Can you fight?

She gives him a look that answers the question so
completely the question becomes embarrassing.

JOSEPH

Right. Come with us.

Richard leans toward Gumball as they walk.

RICHARD

(stage whisper that is entirely
audible to everyone)

I like the textured one. He seems
like a responsible young man.

GUMBALL

Dad. Please do not -

JOSEPH

(from ahead, without turning)

Thank you, Mr. Watterson.

RICHARD

(delighted)

He heard me! The real world has very good ears.

SEQUENCE NINE-B: FIRST NIGHT AFTER COPLEY

EXT. COPLEY SQUARE — AFTER THE BATTLE — NIGHT

The square in the aftermath. Portal closed. The smoke from three days of incursion still hanging at knee level, catching the streetlights in amber. Heroes moving through the square: some treating wounds, some standing still, some doing what people do after bad things end — standing where it happened and verifying that it has. BATMAN stands on the library steps where Darkseid stood four hours ago. He is looking at the city. Running assessments. He never stops running assessments; the assessments are how he breathes. TONY STARK lands beside him, faceplate up.

TONY STARK
Twenty-seven hours of continuous combat, worldwide. Casualties in the thousands, civilian injuries in the hundreds of thousands. Infrastructure damage across every affected city.

BATMAN
The portals are closed.

TONY STARK
For now.

BATMAN
Not for now. Structurally. What the kid

did did not just push the enemy
forces
back. It sealed the access point.

TONY STARK
(looking at Joseph, across the
square, sitting on the library
steps with his head in his hands)
We need to talk about the kid.

BATMAN
We need to talk about who opened the
first portal. Copley Square was a
beachhead, not an accident. Someone
directed this. Someone with the
technical
knowledge to breach multiple
dimensional
boundaries simultaneously worldwide.
That is not Thanos. Thanos does not
have
that kind of dimensional framework
awareness.

TONY STARK
FRIDAY cross-referenced the energy
signatures of all nine portals. Same
source. Same directional stress
pattern.
One architect.

BATMAN
And the architect is still
operational.

TONY STARK
Which means tonight is not a victory.
Tonight is a pause.
Batman looks at Joseph.

BATMAN
He does not know that yet.

TONY STARK
Should we tell him?

BATMAN

Not tonight. Tonight he saved the world.
Tomorrow we explain that the world is still in danger.

Tony looks at him.

TONY STARK

That is surprisingly considerate of you.

BATMAN

I am always considerate. I am also always planning. The two are compatible.
He steps down from the library steps.

BATMAN

Tomorrow. Early. The organizational meeting. We need a structure before whatever comes next arrives.

TONY STARK

My building in Midtown. I have a conference room that can hold -

BATMAN

It needs to hold everyone. Every hero who came through tonight.

TONY STARK

I have a bigger conference room.
He takes off. The Iron Man suit ascending into the Boston night.
Batman disappears - he does not walk away, he simply is no longer there, which is what Batman does when he has decided he is done with a location.

INT. BOSTON PUBLIC LIBRARY - STEPS - SAME TIME

Joseph sits with his back against a pillar.
His hands in his lap. The red punch stains on his shirt - still there, now overlaid with the grime of a battle, but beneath it, still red,

still Brian McKenzie's particular cruelty.
He is thinking about this. About how the morning
started – the gate, the glasses, the party – and
where the evening ended. About the scale of the
distance between those two things.
THOR sits down beside him.
The library pillar vibrates slightly.

THOR
You fought well today.

JOSEPH
(looking up)
I stood in the center of a square
and emitted light. I am not sure
that constitutes fighting.

THOR
In Asgard, we have a word: vitki.
A person who fights without a weapon.
Not a coward – a different kind of
warrior. The one who changes the
battlefield instead of engaging it.
You are vitki.

JOSEPH
I am a first-year student of
theoretical
physics.

THOR
(completely seriously)
Those are not mutually exclusive
categories.
A pause. The square, still and smoky.

JOSEPH
How do you manage it? After a battle.
The scale of what just happened.

THOR
I feast. I sleep very loudly. In the
morning, I identify the next threat

and I prepare.

JOSEPH
That is simple.

THOR
The simple things usually are. The complicated things are complicated because people make them complicated. Battle is large. The response to battle is small: eat, sleep, prepare. The largeness is in the battle. The smallness is how you survive the largeness. Joseph considers this.

JOSEPH
My father would like that. He is a practical man.

THOR
A wise man?

JOSEPH
Very wise.

THOR
Then he raised you correctly. He stands – which takes a moment, because standing from seated is a production for Thor.

THOR
Eat something. Sleep. Tomorrow there will be organizational meetings. I find organizational meetings more difficult than battles. At least battles have a clear objective. He goes. The pillar stops vibrating. Joseph sits alone on the steps. He eats half a kefta sandwich from his bag – still there, still wrapped in its square of foil. His mother

packed it this morning in Casablanca, in a kitchen where the call to prayer had just finished. He eats it in a damaged Boston square at midnight, surrounded by the aftermath of a battle he did not choose and helped to end. He thinks: she packed this sandwich at four-thirty this morning without knowing any of this was coming. She packed it anyway. He thinks this is the right lesson. He puts the wrapper in his pocket. He goes to find somewhere to sleep.

SEQUENCE NINE-C: THE ORGANIZATIONAL MEETING

INT. STARK TOWER — CONFERENCE ROOM — NEXT MORNING

Every chair occupied. Several heroes standing along the walls. A room containing Batman (who generates approximately three degrees of additional cold through authority alone), Thor (who generates warmth through enthusiasm), Bruce Banner (taking up less space than anticipated but radiating the attentiveness of someone containing significant potential), Gandalf (entirely at ease, which is either wisdom or a very effective performance), and forty-three others from seventeen different dimensional frameworks.

Joseph sits at the center of the table. Not the head — Batman has that. The middle, which is where he belongs: equidistant from everyone, accessible to everyone.

Seiko beside him. Laptop open. He has already

mapped every person in the room, their capabilities, reported limitations, and likely tactical roles. He compiled this overnight instead of sleeping, which is consistent with Seiko's priorities. Yara on Joseph's other side. She has been watching the room since they entered – assessing dynamics: who defers to whom, who is posturing, who is genuinely afraid beneath the performance.

BATMAN

(no preliminary)

We have forty-eight hours before
whatever
follows this first engagement begins.
I am going to use those forty-eight
hours
for three things: understand what
happened,
understand who is responsible, and
build
a structure that can respond to what
comes
next. In that order.

He looks at Seiko.

BATMAN

You. With the data. What do we know?
Seiko stands. He speaks with the precision of
someone who prepared carefully and is
grateful for the preparation.

SEIKO

Nine simultaneous portal events.
Worldwide.
Timed to within fractions of a second
—
closer than any known coordination
system
should achieve. The energy signatures
match
across all nine: same dimensional
stress

pattern, same directional vector,
same entry
angle relative to local gravitational
field.

One source. One architect.

He pauses. He looks at his screen.

SEIKO

The vortex over Cambridge three days
ago
was not the origin event. It was the
trigger. Something was waiting for
the
dimensional stress the original
vortex
produced – and used it as a key to
open
the nine portals.

DOCTOR STRANGE

The vortex over Cambridge. Where did
that originate?

JOSEPH

I do not know. I was inside it.

DOCTOR STRANGE

I analyzed the residual signature
last
night. The vortex was manufactured.
Not a natural dimensional event –
something built it, placed it, and
triggered it at a location and time
that would maximize its structural
impact on the dimensional framework.

A beat.

BATMAN

Which means the vortex was bait.

JOSEPH

(the cold clarity of this)
The vortex was designed to send
someone
through the structural center of the
dimensional framework.

BATMAN

And the person who came back changed
is you.

JOSEPH

Yes.

BATMAN

Which means whoever built the vortex
knew that a human being processed
through the center would emerge as a
transmitter. They planned for that.
The silence of a room full of very intelligent
people realizing simultaneously they may be
further inside someone else's plan than they knew.

THOR

Someone wanted Joseph to have this
ability.
Someone built the vortex to give it
to him.

TONY STARK

Which raises the question: why. If
you
want to break down the barriers
between
dimensions, you don't need a human
transmitter. You just break the
barriers.
But if you want to call every hero in
every dimension to one specific place
at
one specific time —

BATMAN

Then you need someone who can
broadcast
across every dimension
simultaneously.
He looks at Joseph.

BATMAN

Someone used you to assemble all of
us.
A longer silence.

JOSEPH

(working through it)

Then the battle at Copley Square was not
the target. It was the assembly. The
portals were opened to bring the
villains
here. I was built to bring the heroes
here.
And all of us together -

BATMAN

Are exactly where someone wanted all
of us to be.

GANDALF

(quietly, from the wall)

Or we are exactly where we need to
be.
The two possibilities are not
mutually
exclusive. One can be used as a pawn
and
still make the right moves.

He looks at Joseph.

GANDALF

The question is not whether someone
planned for your presence here. The
question is what you do with the
presence now that you are here.

Joseph looks at the table. At his hands.

At the room full of heroes who came through
the doors he opened.

JOSEPH

Then we do not play the role they
wrote.
We write our own role in the
situation
they made.

BATMAN

Yes.

He looks at the room.

BATMAN

The Multiversal Protection Alliance.
We are forming it now. In this room.
With these people. Joseph directs
because
the frequency is his and the
situation
follows the frequency. I provide
tactical
structure. Stark provides technology.
Strange provides dimensional
expertise.
Everyone else: your roles will be
assigned
based on capability assessment. Seiko

—

SEIKO

I have prepared a draft
organizational
structure. Four pages. I can
summarize
in three minutes.

TONY STARK

Can you do two?

SEIKO

I can do ninety seconds if I remove
the explanatory context and provide
only the conclusions.

TONY STARK

Do that.

Seiko does it in eighty-seven seconds.

The structure is correct and everyone knows
it because the logic is evident on the surface.

BATMAN

Approved. Objections?

THOR

My title should —

TONY STARK

Thor.

THOR

I am simply noting that "Field Combat
Lead, Sector North" does not fully -

TONY STARK

We know. Next.

GUMBALL

(on the floor by the door,
since there were not enough
chairs)
What is my title?

A beat.

BATMAN

Morale Consultant and Cross-
Dimensional
Liaison.

GUMBALL

(to Darwin, quietly)
Darwin. I have a title.

DARWIN

I heard.

GUMBALL

I have a title at the -

BATMAN

Gumball.

GUMBALL

Right. Yes. Meeting.
The MPA is built in ninety minutes around a
conference table in Stark Tower while Boston
is still cleaning up the smoke.
The architect of the whole situation watches
a holographic display of the conference room
from his black crystal throne hall. He is
smiling. The plan is proceeding correctly.
He is not concerned about the organizational

structure. He planned for the organizational structure. He planned for everything. Everything except one thing. That comes later. That comes in Antarctica.

SEQUENCE TWELVE-B: OBLIVION SPEAKS — FIRST TIME

INT. THRONE HALL — BLACK CRYSTAL — UNKNOWN DIMENSION

— TWENTY-FOUR HOURS BEFORE ANTARCTICA

The Figure sits at the throne.

Display: Antarctica. The convergence point.

The four fracture lines. The formation rising at the geographic south pole.

He is not alone. He is never alone — he made a deal with something larger than himself and that thing is always present, even when not visible.

Tonight it is visible.

OBLIVION enters.

The hall changes.

Not metaphor — the physical dimensions change: the ceiling becomes higher because Oblivion is fifty meters tall and the hall accommodates this not by being large enough but by becoming large enough. The walls recede. The crystal darkens. The darkness deepens in a direction that has no name in geometry.

Oblivion exists in the hall the way a fact exists in a mind: not by occupying it but by defining it.

OBLIVION
(the voice in the chest, in the

bone, in the frequency that
living things use to process
existential threat)
You have arranged the convergence.

THE FIGURE

(without alarm – long past
alarm at this presence)
The boy will direct the heroes to
Antarctica within twenty-four hours.
Seiko Toast will identify the
fracture
line convergence and the boy will
understand the implication. He is a
thorough thinker.

OBLIVION

I know. I have been watching him
since
the dissolution event.

THE FIGURE

What do you make of him?
A pause. Oblivion's attention focused on this
question is felt as a change in the room's
temperature – two degrees dropping, as if
thought itself, for this entity, involves
a cooling.

OBLIVION

He is made of other people. That is
what I find worthy of attention. The
transmitter function is not his
power.
It is a channel through which other
people's power moves. He is porous in
a way that most things are not.

THE FIGURE

Is that a weakness?

OBLIVION

(long pause – the galaxies
through its form shifting
slightly in their rotation)

I do not know yet. I have eliminated sources — things that generated power from within themselves. I know how to unmake sources. A channel is different.

A channel is not the thing that flows through it. You can close a source. A channel — you would have to close everything that flows through it.

THE FIGURE

And can you?

OBLIVION

He is fed by seven billion people who are, at any given moment, refusing to stop. The refusal is not organized.

It

is not intentional. It is the biological

fact of continuation — the decision, made below the level of thought, in every

living body, to keep being alive. To wake

up the next morning. To eat the sandwich.

To call on Sundays. To make the tea. The

ten billion small daily decisions to continue.

THE FIGURE

That sounds difficult to close.

OBLIVION

It is what I am here to do. The barriers

were built from the same material — the

accumulated decision to keep things separate, to maintain the boundaries between worlds. Eleven cycles of that accumulated decision. And I dissolved the barriers anyway.

THE FIGURE

How?

OBLIVION

Time. Time is the only thing that
accumulates faster than refusal. I
waited
for eleven cycles. In each cycle, the
refusal accumulated for millions of
years.

My waiting accumulated for millions
of
years more. I was more patient than
the
refusal. Eventually patience always
wins.

He turns his attention toward the Antarctica
display. The temperature drops two more degrees.

OBLIVION

In Antarctica, I will demonstrate
patience
to the boy directly.

THE FIGURE

He will fight.

OBLIVION

I am counting on it. His fight is the
demonstration. I want him to give
everything he has. I want every hero
he has assembled to give everything
they have. I want the full display of
what the framework is capable of
producing. And then I want to receive
it all without flinching.

THE FIGURE

(quietly)

Because then he will know it is not
enough.

OBLIVION

Because then he will know it is not
enough. And knowing it is not enough
is more complete than simply being
defeated. A thing that is defeated

can believe it might have won with
different circumstances. A thing that
gives everything it has and watches
everything it has received without
effect – that thing knows.

A silence that lasts the length of a geological
event.

OBLIVION

I want him to know.

THE FIGURE looks at the Antarctica display.

At the formation rising at the convergence point.

THE FIGURE

And if he finds something you did not
account for?

OBLIVION is still for a moment that feels
geological.

OBLIVION

I have accounted for everything that
exists in this framework. The boy is
a channel through which what exists
flows. I am accounting for everything
that exists. Therefore I have
accounted
for the boy.

The logic is complete. The logic is airtight.

The logic has one flaw.

The flaw: Oblivion has accounted for everything
that exists in the framework. It has not accounted
for everything that has been decided. And decisions –
the small daily decisions to continue, to wake up,
to make the tea, to call on Sundays – exist in a
dimension that is not quite material, not quite
measurable, not quite the kind of thing that gets
accounted for in a framework that counts material
things.

The Figure knows this. He has been watching the

flaw develop for years.
He has decided not to mention it.
He has his own calculations.
He smiles.

SEQUENCE FOURTEEN-B: EXTENDED PREPARATION —

ANTARCTICA

INT. MPA COMMAND DOME — ANTARCTICA —

EIGHT HOURS BEFORE BATTLE
Final preparations. Temperature outside: minus
thirty-two and falling. Wind: beginning to
strengthen. The fracture lines at the convergence
point glowing brighter every hour.
Batman has had the floor for thirty minutes.
His briefing does not repeat itself.

BATMAN

Six hours of preliminary engagement.
During this phase, our objective is
not
to win. Our objective is to hold the
enemy
forces away from the convergence
point
until the fracture lines peak. At
peak:
the primary event. Whatever comes
through
at peak — that is what we have been
building toward.

TONY STARK

And "whatever comes through at peak"
is —

DOCTOR STRANGE

Something I cannot identify from the
signature. I can tell you its
dimensional

volume, which is large. Its age,
which
is very old. Its relationship to the
framework, which is adversarial. Not
opposed to specific things in the
framework. Opposed to the framework
itself.

GANDALF

(quietly)

I have encountered things like this
before. In the deep places of another
world. Things that are not evil in
the
way a person is evil – not choosing
darkness. Things that are absence
dressed in form.

BATMAN

Can they be stopped?

GANDALF

Everything that exists can be
opposed.
Whether the opposition is sufficient
is a different question.

A beat.

BATMAN

I need you to be more specific about
whether the opposition is sufficient.

GANDALF

(looking at Joseph)

That depends on what the boy does.

And

I cannot tell you what he will do
because

I do not think he knows yet.

Joseph is aware everyone is looking at him. He
has been aware for several seconds. He has been
using the seconds to think rather than perform
readiness, which is the right use of the seconds.

JOSEPH

I need to ask something. About the transmitter function. About what it transmits.

BATMAN

Go.

JOSEPH

At Copley Square, I transmitted the signal
that opened the doors. The signal was —

I called it the accumulated will of people
refusing to stop. Seven billion people
deciding, below the level of conscious
decision, to continue. That signal opened
the doors and called the heroes through.

BATMAN

Yes.

JOSEPH

The thing that is coming — what Strange
described as adversarial to the framework
itself — it is not something I can open
a door against. It is not something I can call someone to fight. If it is adversarial to the framework itself, then
it is adversarial to the thing that produces
the signal I transmit. To the refusal.
To the continuation.

He pauses.

JOSEPH

I need to understand: can I transmit the

refusal directly? Not as a call to others.

As the thing itself, rather than its consequence?

Silence in the dome. The wind outside.

DOCTOR STRANGE looks at GANDALF.

GANDALF looks at Joseph.

GANDALF

In the Second Age of my world, I watched an elf lord named Gil-galad stand against a darkness not unlike what you describe. He did not have a weapon that could touch it. He had himself. He stood and he spoke the name of every light in Arda — every fire, every star, every candle in every window — as a declaration of their existence. He did not win with power. He won with inventory.

JOSEPH

(quietly)
Inventory.

GANDALF

Yes. The full accounting. Not the heroic accounting — not the list of champions and battles and victories. The full accounting: the sandwich made at four-thirty in the morning, the lesson plan with twenty years of margin notes, the twelve containers of oatmeal packed with geometric precision,

the pastries brought at ten o'clock
to
strangers who were not quite
strangers
anymore.

He looks at Joseph with the full weight of a
wizard who has watched the long history of his
own world and knows exactly what is at stake in
each small ordinary decision.

GANDALF

The darkness accounts for power. It
does
not know how to account for the
ordinary.

Joseph looks at his hands.

JOSEPH

(barely audible)

Let it through.

He looks up.

JOSEPH

I understand what I need to do. I do
not
know if I can do it. But I understand
it.

BATMAN

Understanding is the prerequisite of
doing.

He looks at the assembled heroes.

BATMAN

Six hours of holding. Then we find
out.

The briefing ends. Final calibrations. The quiet
of people who are very skilled and are about to
perform at maximum scale.

SEIKO catches Joseph at the dome entrance.

SEIKO

I have been running a calculation
about
the transmitter function. About what
it
costs you.

JOSEPH

And?

SEIKO

I think the cost of being a channel
is
that the channel must remain open. A
closed
channel is just a wall. An open
channel is
vulnerable. Whatever flows through
you
can flow both ways.

JOSEPH

(the cold clarity of this)
If the darkness can enter the channel
—

SEIKO

I am raising this as a risk. Not a
prediction. I want you to know it
exists.

JOSEPH

I have suspected since Copley Square.
When
the light moves through me, there is
a —
it is not pain, but it is adjacent to
pain.
Something passes through that I am
not and
it leaves a trace.

SEIKO

(quietly)
Then be careful. In Antarctica. Be
careful
about what you let through.

JOSEPH

I will be as careful as the situation permits.

SEIKO

That is not sufficiently careful.

JOSEPH

No. But it is all that is available.
A beat. Seiko does something unusual: he puts his hand on Joseph's shoulder. Brief, precise. The gesture of someone who does not touch casually and is therefore entirely deliberate when he does.

SEIKO

I will be at the command station.
Whatever the screens show, I will tell you immediately.
You will not be operating with incomplete information.

JOSEPH

Thank you, Seiko.

SEIKO

That is what I am here for.
He goes back to his screens.
Darwin is already there, water ready, charts organized, the preparedness of someone who has spent years ensuring that the person he cares about has what they need.

SEQUENCE FIFTEEN-B: EXTENDED BATTLE MOMENTS

EXT. ANTARCTICA — SECTOR FOUR — CONTINUOUS

NICOLE WATTERSON in combat.

Batman assigned her to Sector Four with the tone of someone who has assessed a resource and

recognized its value. He assigned her with Captain America, which is the assignment given to reliable people.

Nicole Watterson in combat against Mordor's advance forces is something that requires witnessing to be believed. She moves with the terror-efficiency of a being who has spent years managing a household, two children with poor impulse control, and the chaos of Elmore. These are, it turns out, excellent preparation for tactical combat against dark forces. CAPTAIN AMERICA appears beside her at the three-hour mark, his shield catching a dark lance aimed at her left side.

CAPTAIN AMERICA
Nice footwork.

NICOLE
I have children. You develop footwork.

CAPTAIN AMERICA
Where are you from?

NICOLE
Elmore.
A brief pause.

CAPTAIN AMERICA
Is Elmore —

NICOLE
It is a long story. Focus.
They fight side by side for forty minutes. One of the better combat partnerships of the entire battle, and both of them know it.
RICHARD WATTERSON is in the rear support position. Richard is not a fighter in the tactical sense.

He is, however, enormous and very solid and entirely impossible to move when he has decided not to be moved, which has defensive applications. He stands at the supply junction and does not move. For six hours. Anything that tries to come through the junction finds Richard Watterson, who is unmoveable, and has to go around.

AN AIS coordinates with Seiko.

This partnership, which no one planned for, turns out to be the most efficient data-management configuration of the battle. Anais is four years old by Elmore's calendar and has the processing speed of something significantly older. She and Seiko split the tactical data: Seiko handles the dimensional analysis and long-range sensor feeds; Anais handles immediate battlefield coordination with a precision that makes Batman say, at the two-hour mark: "Who is running the east sector coordination?" And then, when told, say nothing for three seconds before saying: "Excellent."

WONDER WOMAN: three thousand years of combat experience brought to bear on an Antarctic battle.

She fights with the economy of someone for whom every motion is a decision. No wasted movement.

No missed opportunity. She watches the larger battlefield while she fights, continuously updating the picture in her head, communicating adjustments to Batman with the brevity of someone who measures words by their tactical value.

At the four-hour mark: the moment everyone

remembers afterward.

The Chitauri second-wave commander reaches the command dome — Seiko's command dome, the nerve center of the entire operation — having navigated through three defensive perimeters without triggering them.

It raises its weapon.

Darwin is between the weapon and Seiko before anyone else has processed the situation. Darwin has spent years placing himself between Gumball and the consequences of Gumball's decisions. He moves toward threats before threats fully materialize.

He is four feet tall and an orange fish with legs and he stands between an alien weapon and his friend with the calm of someone who decided, at some earlier point, that this is the role he will play.

The weapon does not fire.

HAWKEYE puts an arrow through its power cell at approximately the same moment, from sixty meters, without adjusting his current engagement with three other Chitauri. Hawkeye never adjusts his current engagement. He manages every engagement simultaneously because that is his function.

DARWIN
(after the danger has passed)
Just the next decision.

SEIKO
(whose hands have stopped
shaking — Darwin has said this

every thirty minutes and it
works every time)

Yes. Just the next one.

HERMIONE in the west sector, casting with the
organized fury of someone who has prepared for
this exam thoroughly. RON Weasley fighting with
the surprising competence of someone chronically
underestimated, with a good sense of timing
developed through years of watching other people
move and learning the patterns.

RON
(to Hermione, blocking a
spell)
How much longer?

HERMIONE
Until it stops.

RON
That is not a useful —

HERMIONE
That is the only accurate answer,
Ronald.
Move left.
He moves left. The next spell goes past him.

RON
You could say "move left" without
the context —

HERMIONE
I could. I was providing context as a
pedagogical —

HARRY
Both of you: please.
They please. They fight.
Six hours of holding. Six hours of every hero
from every world giving what they have to this
ice field, in the service of keeping the fracture

lines from reaching their peak before the command
dome team is ready.
Then the sky changes.
Then Oblivion descends.

SEQUENCE SIXTEEN-B: THANOS — THE FULL EXCHANGE

EXT. ANTARCTICA — THANOS'S POSITION — LATE AFTERNOON

Four hours. Thirty kilometers of shelf ice.
Superman and Thanos have been at it since the
battle's first hour. In that time, they have had
a conversation that is, for an entity of Thanos's
age, unusual in its quality.

THANOS

Why did you come back? After the
losses.
After everything you have lost. What
produces the continued engagement
when the
rational response is withdrawal?

A pause. Superman considers this seriously.

SUPERMAN

I think about someone. Specifically.
Not an abstract principle — a person.
When I want to stop, when the weight
becomes very heavy, I think about one
person who would not stop. And then I
do not stop either.

THANOS

Who?

SUPERMAN

My father. Both of them, actually.
Two
fathers. Neither of them super. Both
of
them the bravest people I have known.
Thanos is silent.

THANOS

I had a daughter.
He says this differently from the way he says
everything else. Not geological patience. Something
more human. Something that comes from the damage
rather than the certainty.

SUPERMAN

I know.

THANOS

In this framework. In this collection
of dimensions and their histories. Is
she alive somewhere?
Superman looks at him. This is not tactical.
Not a ploy. A being of enormous capacity asking,
honestly, whether somewhere in the structure of
the multiverse the daughter he sacrificed is
living a life.

SUPERMAN

I do not know. I hope so.

THANOS

(something crossing his face –
the crack in certainty that
looks like weakness but is
more honest than certainty)
Yes. I hope so too.
He looks at the convergence point. At the
formation rising above it.

THANOS

The thing that is coming. Oblivion.
I made a deal. I agreed to facilitate
the barrier failure in exchange for –
I believed I understood what I was
getting. I was wrong.

SUPERMAN

What were you getting?

THANOS

Order. I was promised that when
Oblivion
unmade the framework, what remained
would
be ordered. Balanced. the balance
I have spent my life pursuing. Half
of
everything preserved, half removed,
the
ratio maintained forever.

SUPERMAN

And instead?

THANOS

Instead, nothing. Oblivion does not
balance. It does not preserve half.
I understand this now. I understood
it
perhaps a hundred years too late but
I
understand it now.

He looks at Superman.

THANOS

I cannot stand down. The forces are
committed. The deployment is
complete.
But I can tell you something you need
to know. About Oblivion.

SUPERMAN

Tell me.

THANOS

It is old beyond reckoning. It has
done
this before, in previous framework
cycles.
Eleven times. And in each cycle, it
has
been stopped — or redirected — by
something it did not anticipate. Not
by
power. Not by heroes. By the thing
that

it, in all its accounting, fails to account for.

SUPERMAN

What thing?

THANOS

I do not know what to call it. In my language, the word would be something like: the ordinary decision to continue.

The decision made below the level of strategy by things that are simply alive and wish to remain so. Not heroic. Not

powerful. The sandwich made at four-thirty in the morning. The twelve containers of oatmeal.

Superman looks at him.

SUPERMAN

Where did you learn those details?

THANOS

(something like shame)

I have been watching the boy since the dissolution. As has Oblivion. But Oblivion watches him as a function to be managed.

I watched him and I saw something I had not encountered before. A person who is entirely ordinary, from the most ordinary materials, become not extraordinary. Become necessary. The thing the situation requires.

He looks at the convergence point.

THANOS

Tell him. Whatever happens in the
next
hour – tell the boy that the ordinary
things he carries are the weapon. Not
the
frequency. Not the transmitter
function.
The ordinary things.

The sky begins to change.

Oblivion descends.

Thanos falls – not from being hit, but from
choosing to fall. He drops to one knee on the
ice, and it is the most deliberate action he has
taken in this battle: the posture that removes
him from the immediate calculation.

Superman looks at him. Then at Joseph, small
across the ice.

He goes.

He trusts the boy will find the message himself,
through whatever channel the boy uses to find
things.

He is right. Joseph finds it.

He finds it on his knees on the ice, with both
palms flat, in the position his mother taught
him when he was small.

He finds the ordinary things.

He lets them through.

SEQUENCE EIGHTEEN-B: OBLIVION'S DISSOLUTION – EXTENDED

EXT. ANTARCTICA – CONVERGENCE POINT – CONTINUOUS

The light moves through Joseph.

Ninety seconds.

OBLIVION receives it.

And in those ninety seconds, something happens inside Oblivion that has not happened in eleven framework cycles.

Not pain. Oblivion does not experience pain. Not resistance. Oblivion has received everything this framework has produced for the past six hours without resistance.

Something else.

Recognition.

The recognition of an entity that has been waiting eleven cycles to be recognized – waiting for something from within the framework to be large enough and ordinary enough and present enough to reach it in the register in which it exists.

The light through Joseph is not power. Not a weapon. It is a frequency that exists below power, below heroism, below the category of things Oblivion has been accounting for. The frequency of: I am here. We are here. We were here before you arrived and we intend to continue being here.

Not a threat. An announcement.

And Oblivion – which has spent eleven framework cycles experiencing only absence, only the dark and the wait and the press against the barriers – Oblivion encounters, for the first time, presence. The galaxies through its form stop turning.

The galactic light dims and then brightens – not randomly, but in a pattern. The pattern of something that is, in whatever mode is available to it, responding. The pattern of something that has

received a message from a frequency it did not
expect to encounter.

OBLIVION

(the voice has changed – still
in the chest, still in the bone,
but the frequency is different;
something has been added to it)
I did not expect you to be this.

It says this once in the frequency heard in the
chest. Once in the frequency heard in the teeth.
Once in the frequency that has no name but is felt
in the place where grief and understanding meet.
Then:

OBLIVION

I have waited eleven cycles.

JOSEPH

(from the ice, barely conscious,
the light still moving through
him but fainter – at the edge
of what he can sustain)
I know. I can feel the waiting.
It is in the framework. The waiting
is part of the structure.

OBLIVION

Yes.

JOSEPH

You wanted to unmake the framework
because the framework kept you out.

OBLIVION

Yes.

JOSEPH

But the framework was not keeping you
out of what you wanted.

A pause. The light between them.

OBLIVION

Explain.

JOSEPH

You wanted to be acknowledged. You
wanted
the framework to know you were there.
Eleven cycles of pressing against the
barriers and the barriers held and no
one
inside knew you were pressing. No one
felt
the weight of you.

OBLIVION

(quietly – as quiet as something
that communicates through stone
can be)
Yes.

JOSEPH

I feel the weight of you. Right now.
The
framework knows you are there. Not
through
fear. Through recognition. You are
the
absence that defines the presence.
You are
the space between things that lets
things
be distinct. Without you, there is no
distance between stars. Without you,
there
is no night to hold the day.
The galactic light through Oblivion's form:
shifting. Responding to the frequency the way a
tuning fork responds to its matching note.

OBLIVION

You are asking me not to unmake.

JOSEPH

I am telling you that you were never
the
opposite of what the framework built.
You were always part of it. The part
that
was not acknowledged.

A long silence.

The fracture lines at the convergence point begin to dim. Not by force. Not by power. By the change in the situation – by Oblivion's attention shifting from the convergence to this conversation, this recognition, this unexpected experience of being seen.

OBLIVION
Eleven cycles.

JOSEPH
I know. I am sorry.
He says this – I am sorry – from the ice, half-conscious, the light fading from his hands, surrounded by an Antarctic night. And he means it: the weight of eleven cycles of waiting is something he can feel in the frequency, and it is real, and it deserves acknowledgment. Oblivion is still for three seconds. Then, over ninety seconds – the slow geological decision of something that has existed longer than the framework it is dissolving from – it withdraws. Not destroyed. Not defeated. Returning to what it was before someone built barriers it could press against without being felt. The absence between things. The space that lets things be distinct. The dark that holds the stars in place. The fracture lines seal. The portals close. Joseph falls.

Yara catches him.

SEQUENCE EIGHTEEN-C: THE DAY AFTER ANTARCTICA

INT. FIELD MEDICAL DOME — ANTARCTICA — DAWN

The morning after. The ice field outside the dome: still and cold, no longer a battlefield. The heroes moving through the camp with the particular exhaustion of people who have been through something enormous and are now in the first hours of knowing it is over.

Joseph sits on a cot in the medical wing. Yara has been with him through the night — she fell asleep in the chair beside the cot at some point before four, and she is still there, her head tipped slightly, her breathing even.

He sits and watches her sleep.

He thinks about the crossing of her wrist between his hands at the vortex. The moment when the force took her and his fingers closed on nothing but the air where she had been.

He thinks about the siege machine. The lock of the targeting system. NOT HER. The two seconds across the ice.

He thinks about the sentence he started and did not finish. I will always —

He looks at her.

He files this under: things that will not wait much longer.

SEIKO appears in the doorway of the medical wing.

He has been awake for approximately thirty-six

hours. His shoulder is bandaged. His glasses are slightly fogged from the transition between the cold outside and the warmth inside. He looks at Joseph with the assessment of someone who has been monitoring this situation remotely from a command station and is now conducting a direct inspection.

SEIKO

How do you feel?

JOSEPH

Tired. But correctly tired. The tired of having done something, rather than the tired of having failed to.

SEIKO

That is a distinction I was not previously

aware of. It is a good one.

He comes in. He sits on the edge of the cot.

He looks at Yara sleeping in the chair.

SEIKO

(quietly)

She did not leave.

JOSEPH

No.

SEIKO

She went through the entire battle, managed the civilian situation in Sector

Seven, sustained two hits from debris,

and then remained in this medical wing

for seven hours waiting for you to be well enough to have a conversation.

JOSEPH

I know.

SEIKO

Joseph.

JOSEPH

Yes.

SEIKO

I have been your friend for five years.

I have observed you in many situations.

I am generally very careful about the observations I choose to share. But I am going to share this one.

JOSEPH

Go ahead.

SEIKO

She is the most important person in your

life who is not your family. I believe

you know this. I believe you have known

it for some time. I am telling you in case the knowing has not yet produced the saying.

Joseph is quiet.

JOSEPH

The saying is coming.

SEIKO

Good.

He stands.

SEIKO

Batman wants a debrief at eight. I told

him you would need until nine.

JOSEPH

He agreed to that?

SEIKO

He said: adequate.

JOSEPH
That is practically enthusiastic.

SEIKO
Yes. I thought so too.
He goes. At the door, he pauses.

SEIKO
Joseph.

JOSEPH
Yes.

SEIKO
The twelve containers of oatmeal. I
have
been carrying the fact that you did
not
say they were excessive. On the first
morning at Harvard. You said: I
understand
the calculation. And I have — I have
thought about that many times over
the
past months. About what it means to
have
someone understand the calculation.

JOSEPH
It means I know why you did it.

SEIKO
Yes. It means I was seen.
A pause. The Antarctic dawn light through
the dome panel.

SEIKO
Thank you. For that morning. And for
every morning after it.
He goes.
Joseph sits on the cot in the medical wing
in Antarctica, with the dawn light and the
breathing of the most important person in
his life who is not his family, and he thinks:

I did not choose any of this. I did not choose the vortex or the dissolution or the transmitter function or the golden doors above Boston or the knees on the ice. I did not choose to be what the situation required.

But I would choose every single one of the people who were with me in it.

That, he thinks, is the thing that Oblivion could not account for. Not the power. Not the frequency. The people you would choose.

Yara opens her eyes.

She looks at him.

YARA

How long have you been awake?

JOSEPH

A while.

YARA

Why didn't you wake me?

JOSEPH

You were sleeping.

YARA

That is not a reason.

JOSEPH

It is the reason I had.

She looks at him. The assessment she runs on everything she cares about.

YARA

Are you alright?

JOSEPH

Yes. The tired kind of alright.

YARA

The correctly tired?

JOSEPH
(surprised)
Seiko told you about that?

YARA
Seiko tells me things he thinks I
should
know. He has been doing this since
September. He is a very organized
person.

JOSEPH
He organized you as well?

YARA
He organized everything. The late
nights.
The tea. The way we always ended up
at
the same table. I am not saying he
engineered it. But I am saying his
organizational habits and his care
for
you produce results that look very
much
like engineering.
Joseph looks at the door Seiko left through.

JOSEPH
He is the best friend anyone has ever
had.

YARA
Yes. He is.
A pause.

YARA
Joseph.

JOSEPH
Yes.

YARA
Finish the sentence.
He looks at her.

JOSEPH

Not here. Not like this. When we are home. When there are people we love around us and somewhere to put the sentence that is larger than a field hospital in Antarctica. I will finish it then.

She looks at him.

YARA

When?

JOSEPH

Soon. I promise. The actual kind of soon, not the kind that means eventually.

YARA

(and she believes him — she has always been able to tell the difference with him, which is one of the things that makes her Yara)

Okay.

She gets up. She stretches. She goes to the door.

YARA

Breakfast. Then debrief. Then home.

JOSEPH

In that order?

YARA

Seiko has it on the schedule.

JOSEPH

Of course he does.

She goes. He follows.

Outside the dome: Antarctica in the morning, the ice fields white and still and completely indifferent to what they just witnessed, because the Antarctic winter does not stop for victories

or for recognition or for the morning after the night a nineteen-year-old boy from Casablanca talked to the void and the void withdrew. The ice is still. The sky is clear. The stars are still there.

SEQUENCE NINETEEN-B: CASABLANCA

EXT. CASABLANCA — RUE DES ORANGERS — LATE AFTERNOON

THREE MONTHS AFTER ANTARCTICA
The jasmine on the south wall has grown in his absence. The first thing he notices. The vines have extended past the third-floor window, which they had not quite reached when he left in September. Three months. The jasmine does not stop for multiversal wars. Joseph stands on the pavement of Rue des Orangers with his bag. He looks up at the building. The fourth floor window. The light on inside, which it always is. He goes up.

INT. AL-MITHALI APARTMENT — FOURTH FLOOR —

CONTINUOUS
He does not knock. He has a key. The key is on the same ring it has always been, slightly heavier now from the MPA access card Tony Stark added to it — because Tony Stark decided that the access card should go on the same key ring as everything else Joseph carries, so that it is present without being separate. He turns the key. Opens the door.

FATIMA is in the kitchen.

She is at the counter, making something – the economy of movement of someone who has performed this action ten thousand times and carries the ten thousand repetitions in her body.

She turns.

She looks at him.

She says nothing for three seconds. Not because she cannot speak – because she is doing the thing Hassan taught them all without teaching it directly: giving the moment its three honest seconds of acknowledgment. Looking at it clearly. Giving it its due.

Then she crosses the kitchen and puts her arms around him.

Not dramatically – the embrace of a person who does not inflate things, who gives what is appropriate to the moment and not more.

He holds on.

Longer than he expected to. With the tightness of someone who has been carrying something enormous for a long time and has only now set it down.

She says nothing. She does not need to.

After a while:

FATIMA
(in Arabic – subtitled)
You called every Sunday.

JOSEPH
(in Arabic – subtitled)
I promised.

FATIMA
Even from Antarctica. You called from

the Antarctic.

JOSEPH
It was Sunday.

FATIMA
The connection was bad.

JOSEPH
I was on the ice. There is not a good
connection infrastructure at the
geographic south pole.

FATIMA
(pulling back, looking at him –
the nurse's look, the full
clinical assessment that is also
entirely maternal)
You are thinner.

JOSEPH
I am fine, Mama.

FATIMA
You are thinner and you have a look
around your eyes I have not seen
before.

JOSEPH
What look?

FATIMA
The look of someone who has seen
something enormous. And carried it.
And set it down. And is not yet sure
what to do with the setting-down.
He looks at her. Twenty-two years of noticing
things about people from the quality of their
presence.

JOSEPH
Yes. That is accurate.

FATIMA
Sit down. I am going to make you
something to eat.

JOSEPH

Mama —

FATIMA

Sit down, Joseph. Some things are not negotiable.

He sits down.

He watches her at the counter. The economy of movement. The same as it was before the vortex, before Elmore, before Copley Square, before Antarctica. The same hands. The same careful attention to the olive that always goes in at the diagonal.

He thinks: this is the thing that Oblivion could not account for. This, exactly this. The kitchen and the jasmine and the hands at the counter. The ordinary thing, done with care, at four-thirty in the morning and at three in the afternoon and at every meal that has ever been prepared in this kitchen.

NADIA appears in the doorway.

She looks at him. She does not produce a speech — she is fifteen, and she has decided on silence, which is the more emotional choice.

She sits down across from him. Looks at him for a long time.

NADIA

(in Arabic — subtitled)
You are on the news every day.

JOSEPH

I know.

NADIA

"The Perfect Joseph." It is strange
to
see your brother on the news with
that
title.

JOSEPH
I imagine it is.

NADIA
Is it true? What they said happened
in Antarctica?

JOSEPH
Most of it.

NADIA
The part where you talked to the
giant
void entity and told it you were
sorry?

JOSEPH
That part is true.

NADIA
(long pause)
Good. I would have been disappointed
if
you had only fought it. You fight
everything better when you also talk
to it.

JOSEPH
(surprised)
Where did you learn that about me?

NADIA
I am your sister. I have been
learning
things about you my entire life.
He looks at her.

JOSEPH
You were right, by the way. About the
show. It was good.

NADIA
Gumball?

JOSEPH
Yes. You were entirely right. I am
glad
you made me watch it.

NADIA
(the delight arriving before
she can contain it)
I told you. I told you it was good
and
you said you were too old for it.

JOSEPH
I was wrong.

NADIA
(savoring this)
Yes. You were. I will remember this.
Fatima sets food on the table between them.
The Casablanca afternoon through the kitchen window.
The jasmine smell, even in October.
HASSAN comes in from the other room.
He stops in the doorway. He looks at Joseph.
Joseph stands.
They stand looking at each other for three seconds.
One second for each of the three hours Hassan went
quiet when the Harvard letter arrived. Three seconds
of looking at each other without a word – the
Al-Mithali family's version of everything that needs
to be said.
Then Hassan nods. Once. The nod that means: you
did it. The nod that means: I knew. The nod that
means: the work was yours, and the work was enough,
and the work always will have been yours.
Joseph nods back.

They sit down for dinner.

The jasmine on the south wall continues to grow.

SEQUENCE NINETEEN-C: THE SENTENCE — COMPLETED

EXT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — ROOFTOP COURTYARD —

EVENING

Three months after Antarctica. New York.

The courtyard on the forty-fourth floor: string lights strung between the air conditioning units, which Tony Stark installed with the same rigor he applied to the Iron Man suit. Potted plants — someone is growing Moroccan mint up here, which arrived on the rooftop two weeks after the MPA opened without anyone explaining how.

Joseph and Yara have the courtyard to themselves. Not by accident. Seiko arranged it — with the organizational precision of someone who identified that Joseph needed this moment and removed every potential interruption from the schedule.

They have been standing at the railing looking at Manhattan for six minutes. A long time to stand at a railing without speaking. Both of them comfortable in the silence. That was built in the dorm room, over the late nights, in the aftermath of the party — the ability to be silent together without it requiring an explanation.

But Joseph is not going to be silent tonight.

He turns.

JOSEPH

At the party. When Brian poured the punch.

YARA

(she has been waiting for this
– she knows the shape of it,
has known for months; she is
still)
Yes.

JOSEPH

And in Antarctica. The siege machine.
I started to say something and I had
to stop.

YARA

Yes.

JOSEPH

I am going to finish it now.

YARA

Yes.

He turns to face her properly. He does the thing
his father taught him: three honest seconds of
acknowledgment. Looking at it clearly. Giving it
its due.

One. Two. Three.

JOSEPH

I will always put myself between you
and
anything that wants to hurt you. Not
because
I am stronger – I am not always
stronger.
Not because it is my role – it is not
only
my role. Because when the siege
machine
found you in its targeting system, my
body
moved before my mind did. And I have
been
thinking about what that means for
three
months.

He pauses.

JOSEPH

It means that the distance between
us, at
that moment, was not acceptable to
me. And
the distance has not been acceptable
to me
for a long time. Since the fountain
bench.
Since the paper with your number in
clean
precise handwriting. Since the
pastries
at ten o'clock. Since every late
night at
the table and every cup of tea and
every
time you said the accurate thing
instead
of the comfortable thing.

He takes a breath.

JOSEPH

I am telling you that I love you. Not
as
a performance and not as a strategy.
As
the accurate statement of an internal
fact
that I have known for some time and
chose
to say tonight because tonight is a
Tuesday
and I decided the accurate statement
should
not wait for a more dramatic
occasion. The
dramatic occasion already happened.
The
dramatic occasion was the siege
machine.
This is what comes after.

Yara looks at him. The full assessment. The analysis
she runs on everything that matters – not because
she doubts it but because she respects it enough

to look at it properly.

YARA

I know.

JOSEPH

You know?

YARA

I have known for a while. I was waiting for you to find the words. You find words carefully. I knew they were building.

JOSEPH

And?

The warm blue eyes. The assessment that is also, right now, something warmer than assessment.

YARA

I love you too. As the accurate statement of an internal fact. Not since the siege machine — before the siege machine. Since you stood in the center of Copley Square with red punch on your shirt and you opened a door for everyone.

JOSEPH

That was dramatic.

YARA

It was. I prefer what comes after. What comes after the dramatic thing. The Tuesday evenings. The cold tea. The question about the observer effect. The way you talk about your father.

JOSEPH

The after is what I want too.
She steps forward. He is still – not the
stillness of Brian's party, not the survival
stillness, but the stillness of someone who has
arrived at something he did not know he was moving
toward and recognizes it now that he is here.
She puts her hand against his face.

YARA

Then we are in agreement.

JOSEPH

We are in agreement.
Above them: the Manhattan night, the string lights,
the mint growing in its pot on the forty-fourth
floor of a building that did not exist four months
ago and was built for exactly this: the continuation
of something worth continuing.
Below them: the city, going on.
Behind them: the door to the stairwell opens briefly.
Seiko, checking that everything is proceeding
correctly. He sees that it is. He closes the door.
He goes back to his screens.
He is, as always, exactly where he needs to be.

SEQUENCE TWENTY-B: THE FIRST WEEKS OF THE MPA

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS – JOSEPH'S OFFICE –

FORTIETH FLOOR – MORNING

His office is the one Tony Stark built first
because Tony Stark decided that the director's
office should be the foundation everything else
is built around.

It is also the one Joseph has spent the least time in, because Joseph does not work from his office. He works from the monitoring room, the corridor, the cafeteria, anywhere that puts him in proximity to other people, because he has learned – from his father's lesson plans – that you cannot pay attention to the individual case if the individual case is on the other side of a closed door.

This morning he is in his office because CAPTAIN AMERICA asked for a meeting, and Captain America asks for meetings in a way that suggests the meeting has been needed for some time and the asking has been delayed in the manner of someone who does not want to burden the person they are asking. CAPTAIN AMERICA sits across from Joseph at the desk that Tony Stark built and Joseph never uses as a desk.

CAPTAIN AMERICA
I want to talk to you about what
comes
after.

JOSEPH
After Antarctica?

CAPTAIN AMERICA
After the MPA. After the wars. I have
been through enough of these – the
big
battles, the victories, the aftermath
–
to know that what comes after is
where

most people struggle. The during is clear. The after is very unclear.

JOSEPH

And you want to tell me about the after.

CAPTAIN AMERICA

I want to ask you what you think the after looks like.

Joseph looks at the Manhattan skyline through the office window. A view Tony Stark selected specifically because it contains: the Empire State Building, the Brooklyn Bridge, and a section of the East River that catches the morning light in a particular way. A view that is both beautiful and functional – it shows you the city, which is the point.

JOSEPH

In my father's classroom, after a test,
there is the test and there is the day
after the test. The test is the event.
The day after is when you find out who
actually learned and who just passed.
The day after the test is harder than the test.

CAPTAIN AMERICA

Yes. That is exactly right.

JOSEPH

I think the after looks like this:
the
MPA has to be what it claims to be,
not
what the moment of its founding made
it look like. The moment of its
founding

was Antarctica and Copley Square and
thirty-seven heroes in a conference
room
at eight in the morning after a
battle.
That moment was enormous. The after
is
smaller. And the smaller after is the
real test.

CAPTAIN AMERICA

What does the smaller after require?

JOSEPH

Attention. The kind my father pays.
To each person in the organization,
individually. To what each person
needs,
which is different from what each
person
is assigned. The MPA is going to need
—
I need to learn every person here.
Not
their capabilities. Their particular
way of being capable. The way my
father
learned which approach worked for
which
student on which day.

Captain America looks at him.

CAPTAIN AMERICA

That is a lot of people.

JOSEPH

Yes. It will take time.

CAPTAIN AMERICA

Most directors don't think that way.

JOSEPH

Most directors did not have my
father.

A beat. Captain America smiles. Small, genuine —
the smile of someone who has been doing this for

a long time and has occasionally found
younger people whose way of thinking makes the
long time feel worthwhile.

CAPTAIN AMERICA

I have been at this for eighty years,
give or take some time in ice. I have
worked for and with a lot of people
who
were in charge of things. I want to
tell
you something.

JOSEPH

Please.

CAPTAIN AMERICA

The ones who last — who actually
last,
not just who win the first battle —
are
the ones who remember why they are
doing
it when it is no longer dramatic.
When
it is Tuesday at two in the afternoon
and there is no battle and the only
things on the agenda are the things
that feel small. The ones who
remember
the ordinary reason are the ones who
are still standing at the end.

He looks at Joseph.

CAPTAIN AMERICA

You remember your ordinary reason?

JOSEPH

My family. The sandwich made at four-
thirty in the morning. The olive
pressed
at the diagonal center.

CAPTAIN AMERICA

Good. Hold onto that. The olive is
the

thing that will keep you.
He stands. Extends his hand.

CAPTAIN AMERICA
It is good to be on your team,
Joseph.

JOSEPH
(taking the hand — genuinely
moved, trying not to show all
of it; managing not quite)
It is good to be on yours.
Captain America goes.

Joseph sits in his office for a while longer.
He looks at the city. At the East River catching
the morning light. At the Empire State Building
which has been standing for ninety years and
has survived several things that should have
ended it and has not ended.
He thinks: that is what endurance looks like.
Not the victory. The standing still and continuing.
He gets up. He goes to the monitoring room.
He goes to find Seiko.

SEQUENCE TWENTY-C: BATMAN AND JOSEPH

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — TACTICAL OPERATIONS CENTER

— LATE NIGHT

Two in the morning. Most of the building asleep.
The tactical center: lit only by the monitoring
displays, casting the room in blue-green.
BATMAN is here. He is always here at two in the
morning — not because he requires the
hour but because the two-in-the-morning version
of any situation is more honest than the nine-in-

the-morning version, and Batman has built his career around the honest version of things. Joseph comes in. He has a cup of Moroccan mint tea. He puts a second cup on the console beside Batman without saying anything about it. Batman looks at the cup. He does not say anything either. But he picks it up. This is, from Batman, a significant acknowledgment. They stand looking at the monitoring displays for a while. Boston still in the process of rebuilding. The worldwide damage assessment. The dimensional signature monitors, which have been clear since Antarctica.

BATMAN

You know the threat is not eliminated.

JOSEPH

I know.

BATMAN

The letter from the Time Tracker.
The figure in the black crystal hall.
Kronos, Epstein, whatever comes next.
The war paused. It did not end.

JOSEPH

I know. I think about it every day.

BATMAN

Good. Thinking about it every day is appropriate.
He looks at the monitoring displays.

BATMAN

Can I ask you something?
This is unusual enough that Joseph registers it as unusual. Batman does not usually ask if he

can ask things. He simply asks them, because asking permission introduces a variable he finds inefficient. For him to ask if he can ask means the question is one he is not sure he has the right to ask.

JOSEPH

Yes.

BATMAN

When you opened the doors above
Copley
Square. When you called us all
through.
What did it feel like?

A pause. Joseph considers this honestly.

JOSEPH

Like being a window. Like light
moving
through glass – the glass does not
produce
the light, does not direct it, does
not
own it. But without the glass, the
light
does not pass through in the same
way.
The glass gives it shape.

BATMAN

And in Antarctica. When you
transmitted
directly at Oblivion.

JOSEPH

Like a door that has been open too
long.
A door left open long enough starts
to
become part of the wall. The opening
becomes permanent. The channel
becomes
structural.

BATMAN
Are you still —

JOSEPH
Changed? Yes. I can feel the
frequency
all the time now. It is not painful.
It
is like — it is like having a radio
receiver that cannot be turned off.
Most
of the time the signal is very quiet.
But it is always there.
Batman looks at him.

BATMAN
Is that manageable?

JOSEPH
I do not know yet. Ask me in a year.

BATMAN
I will.
He turns back to the displays.

BATMAN
You did the right thing in
Antarctica.
Not just strategically. The way you
talked to it. The acknowledgment.
Most
people in your position would have
continued pushing. Continued
attacking.
You stopped when the data changed and
you responded to what the data
actually
showed.

JOSEPH
My father taught me that. He called
it
scientific honesty about human
systems.
The system tells you something. You
listen to what it tells you. You do
not insist on the interpretation you

prepared in advance.

BATMAN

He sounds like someone worth knowing.

JOSEPH

He is. I would like you to meet him
someday. I think you would get along.

BATMAN

I do not usually get along with
people.

JOSEPH

I know. But I think you would get
along
with him. He is very precise about
principles. He would not be
intimidated
by you, which I think you would find
interesting rather than annoying.

Batman is quiet for a moment.

BATMAN

Yes. That would be interesting.
They stand at the monitoring displays until three
in the morning. They do not say much else. They
do not need to. This is the comfortable
silence of two people who have each developed,
over time, a way of working alongside others
without requiring continuous speech, and who
have discovered that the other person has the
same capacity.

At three, Batman goes.

Joseph stays at the displays for a while longer.
He thinks about Brian McKenzie. He thinks about
the morning in Harvard Yard — the cracked glasses,
the scattered papers, the wish to be bigger just
once.

He thinks about the wish having been answered in a way he could not have predicted or designed. He thinks about the specificity of wishes: how they name a feeling rather than a solution, and how the solution arrives in a shape the feeling did not anticipate. He files this under: things worth telling Nadia on Sunday. He goes to bed.

SEQUENCE TWENTY-D: BRIAN MCKENZIE

INT. HARVARD UNIVERSITY — ADMINISTRATIVE OFFICE —

SIX WEEKS AFTER ANTARCTICA

TEXT ON SCREEN: SIX WEEKS AFTER ANTARCTICA.

This scene takes place not because Joseph arranged it — he did not arrange it, he was unaware of it until afterwards. It takes place because the world, having been changed by what happened at Copley Square and in Antarctica, is in the process of working out what the changes mean at the local level. The local level, in this case, is Harvard University's Office of Student Affairs, where Brian McKenzie is sitting across from a committee that includes three members of the faculty, one representative from the student body, and one person from the Office of Diversity and Inclusion who has been waiting for this moment for approximately two years. The committee has a dossier. The dossier contains: the incident at the Harvard gate in September. The

incident at the orientation party, including the footage from Brian's friend's phone, which turned out to be a less effective weapon than anticipated because the footage, when reviewed by people who were not Brian's friends, showed something rather different from what Brian had intended it to show. Several prior incidents. Several prior reports that had been reviewed and administratively resolved with outcomes that are, in retrospect, difficult to defend.

The committee also has something it did not have before September: a public record of what Brian's behavior was the precursor to. Not because anyone is drawing a direct causal line. But because the world is paying closer attention to the Brian McKenzies now, the way a city pays closer attention to its infrastructure after a flood.

Brian sits in the chair with the expression of someone who has been in many rooms like this and has always been able to negotiate his way out, and who is beginning to suspect that the usual negotiation is not available.

He is correct.

He is not expelled. He is given a formal warning, a mandatory program of engagement, the revocation of several privileges he had not known were privileges, and a letter for his file that will be there when graduate schools and employers look.

He leaves the building in late October and stands

on the Cambridge pavement with the October sun on his face.

He is not broken. He is not transformed. He is exactly who he was before the meeting, with a new awareness of the shape of the space he occupies.

He looks at Harvard Yard. At the gate with VERITAS above it.

He thinks: things have changed.

He is not wrong.

Joseph does not know about this meeting until three weeks later, when Dr. Ellison mentions it in passing, in the context of something else entirely. He hears it. He notes it. He does not celebrate it. He does not feel the satisfaction he would have expected to feel, back in September, if someone had told him this moment was coming.

He feels something smaller and more permanent: the recognition that the systems work, slowly, imperfectly, with significant delays and gaps, but work. That the record matters. That the dossier compiled by the people who write things down eventually reaches someone who acts on it. He thinks about his father's lesson plan margins. The date of each note. The result. The adjustment. He thinks: this is the long game. This is what the long game looks like.

He goes back to the monitoring room. He goes back to work.

SEQUENCE TWENTY-E: SEIKO'S MOTHER

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — SEIKO'S OFFICE —

THREE MONTHS AFTER ANTARCTICA
MIYUKI TOAST, 48, arrives at MPA headquarters
on a Wednesday morning having flown from Kyoto
without telling Seiko she was coming.

She arrives with a thermos of miso soup — the
three-generation recipe, the record of accumulated
decisions no one documented — and she sits in
Seiko's office and she waits.

When Seiko arrives at his desk at 7:47 A.M.,
organized for the day he has planned, he finds
his mother sitting in his chair.

He stops.

He looks at her.

SEIKO
(in Japanese — subtitled)
You did not tell me you were coming.

MIYUKI
(in Japanese — subtitled)
No.

SEIKO
Why?

MIYUKI
Because if I had told you, you would
have organized it. You would have
prepared the conversation. You would
have decided in advance how you felt
about seeing me, and the decision
would have been incorrect.
Seiko considers this.

SEIKO
That is — accurate.

MIYUKI

I know my son.
She opens the thermos. The smell of the miso fills
the room — three generations, accumulated decisions,
the warmth of a thing that has been passed
through hands that loved it.
She pours two cups.

MIYUKI

Sit down, Seiko. I did not fly twelve
hours to watch you stand in the
doorway.
He sits. Across from his own desk. The chair
is not as well-organized as his chair, but
he adapts.

SEIKO

How are Father and —

MIYUKI

Your father is fine. Your sister is
fine.
Everyone is fine. That is not why I
came.

SEIKO

Then why —

MIYUKI

Because you were in Antarctica,
Seiko.
Because for six hours I watched the
news
from the south pole and my son's name
was in the reports and I did not know
if you were alive until five in the
morning when you sent me a message
that
said: "I am well. The mission was a
success. I will call tomorrow."
She looks at him.

MIYUKI

I will call tomorrow. After six hours
of not knowing if you were alive.

SEIKO

(quietly)

I did not want to worry you further
by calling before I had full
information
about the outcome.

MIYUKI

I know. That is how you are. You wait
for full information. But I am your
mother. I do not need full
information.

I need you.

Seiko is still. The still of someone
who is feeling something large and is
organizing his relationship to it.

SEIKO

I should have called sooner.

MIYUKI

Yes.

SEIKO

I am sorry.

MIYUKI

I know. Drink your miso.

He drinks his miso. She drinks hers. The room:
Seiko's office, precisely organized, the monitors
showing the steady green of a currently quiet
world, the smell of three-generation miso soup.

MIYUKI

Tell me about your friend.

SEIKO

Joseph?

MIYUKI

You have told us about Joseph for
five
years. The competition in Fez. The
coach
back to Casablanca. The first morning
at Harvard. Antarctica. But you have
never told me what he means to you.
You describe events. You do not
describe
what they mean.
Seiko looks at the miso cup.

SEIKO
In competition mathematics, there is
a concept called an elegantly
sufficient
proof. Not the longest proof. Not the
most complex. The proof that shows
exactly what needs to be shown, in
exactly the right number of steps,
with
nothing wasted and nothing missing.

MIYUKI
Yes.

SEIKO
Joseph is – our friendship is that.
It is elegantly sufficient. He
understands the calculations I make.
He does not call them excessive. He
does not perform patience with my
particular way of being. He simply
understands it, and then we continue.
It has been that way from the first
conversation on the coach from Fez.

MIYUKI
Five years of being understood.

SEIKO
Five years of not explaining myself
and not being required to. That is –
He pauses.

SEIKO
That is very rare. I did not know how

rare until I had it and then
experienced
a situation where it might be taken
away.
The siege machine. In Antarctica.
When
the targeting system locked on Yara
and
he moved across the ice in two
seconds –

MIYUKI

I know about the siege machine.

SEIKO

I thought I was going to lose both of
them. In the same moment. And the
thought produced something I did not
have a framework for.

MIYUKI

Fear.

SEIKO

Something larger than fear. Fear is
about oneself. This was about – the
space that would exist without them.
The office at two in the morning
without
Joseph coming in to ask a question
that
is actually a way of checking that I
am
alright. The room where I work
without
the quality of attention that
both of them bring to it.

He looks at his mother.

SEIKO

I did not know I had built a life
until I was afraid of losing it.
Miyuki Toast reaches across the desk and puts
her hand on her son's hand. She has not done
this since he was twelve years old, when he

decided that physical demonstrations of affection in public settings were outside his preferred protocol.
She does it now because the protocol can wait.

MIYUKI

(in Japanese – subtitled)
You have built a good life, Seiko.
Your father and I are very proud of you.
Not of the title. Not of what they said
about you in the news. Of you. The person.

Seiko says nothing for a moment.

SEIKO

(in Japanese – subtitled, very quietly)
Thank you, Mama.
They drink their miso soup.
The monitors show steady green across all fronts.
The world: quiet, for now.

SEQUENCE TWENTY-F: GUMBALL AND DARWIN – ONE MONTH LATER

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS – COMMON AREA – AFTERNOON

One month after the MPA opened. The common area on the twenty-second floor: a space Tony Stark designed after consulting with every member of the founding team about what they needed in a space that was not an office and not a meeting room and not a cafeteria but something else – the kind of room where people go when the work is done and they need to be in a room with other people without being at work.

He got it right. This is the most-used room in the building.

GUMBALL and DARWIN are in the common area.

Gumball is three-dimensional and has been for three months and has largely adapted to this, with the exception of the texture issue, which he has not fully adapted to. He still occasionally pauses in the middle of activities to press his three-dimensional hand against a three-dimensional surface with the wonder of someone who is always slightly surprised that the texture is still there.

Darwin has adapted more completely. Darwin spent his entire life being an orange fish with legs in a world that was cartoon but did not feel cartoon from the inside. Being three-dimensional is, in his experience, another version of being a thing that does not entirely fit the category it is assigned to. He has been managing this his whole life. He continues to manage it.

GUMBALL

(pressing his hand against
the common area wall)
It still surprises me. Every time.

DARWIN

I know.

GUMBALL

Do you think Elmore is okay?

DARWIN

We checked yesterday. The substrate
is stable. The code is running
normally.

GUMBALL

I know. But I mean — do you think they miss us?

A pause.

DARWIN

I think Elmore keeps going. That is what towns do. They keep going regardless of who is in them.

GUMBALL

That is a sad way to think about it.

DARWIN

I think it is a reassuring way to think about it. The town keeps going means there is something to go back to.

GUMBALL

When do you think we will go back?

DARWIN

When the work here is done. And until it is done — we are doing the work.

Gumball looks at the wall. At his three-dimensional hand against it.

GUMBALL

Darwin. Did you think — when we were running through Elmore to get Mom and Dad, and the world was crashing around us — did you think we might not make it?

DARWIN

(honestly)

Yes. I thought it was possible we would not make it.

GUMBALL

And what did you think about that?

DARWIN

I thought: at least we are together.
I thought: if this is how it ends, it
ends with us running toward the
people
we love, which is the correct
direction.
I thought: this is what all of it was
for.

Gumball is quiet for a long time.

GUMBALL

Yeah. That is what I thought too.
He presses his hand against the wall one more time.
Then he takes it away.

GUMBALL

Darwin.

DARWIN

Yes?

GUMBALL

Thank you for always being exactly
where I need you.
Darwin looks at him. The warmth that is simply
Darwin's default mode – not performed warmth,
the actual kind, which is different because you
can feel the difference.

DARWIN

Thank you for always being worth
being there for.
They sit in the common area in the afternoon
light. Three-dimensional. Somewhere between
Elmore and New York and the rest of the
multiverse. Somewhere between the cartoon
they were and whatever they are becoming.
JOSEPH passes through the room on his way
to a meeting. He sees them. He slows.

JOSEPH
(to Gumball)
Are you alright?

GUMBALL
I am thinking about home.

JOSEPH
Elmore?

GUMBALL
Yes. But also — this. I think this is
starting to be home too. Which is
strange
because I did not expect that. I
expected
to miss Elmore. I did not expect to
start belonging somewhere new.
Joseph stops. He sets down the papers he is
carrying. He sits on the arm of the couch.

JOSEPH
I have been in Cambridge and New York
for four months and I still think of
Casablanca as home. But I also think
of the dorm room as home. The bench
by the fountain as home. Some places
are home because you were made there.
Some places are home because of who
was with you in them.

GUMBALL
Is the second kind of home as real as
the first kind?

JOSEPH
I think it is more real. The first
kind
is given to you. The second kind, you
make.
Gumball considers this.

GUMBALL
So Elmore is the first kind and the
MPA
is the second kind.

JOSEPH

Yes. And you can have both. They are not in competition.

GUMBALL

Good. I was worried they were in competition.

DARWIN

They are not in competition, Gumball.

GUMBALL

I know, Darwin. I just wanted to hear someone say it who was not me.

Joseph picks up his papers. He goes to his meeting.

In the doorway he pauses.

JOSEPH

(to Gumball, without turning)
My sister was right about your show.
It is good.

He goes.

Gumball stares at the doorway for a moment.

GUMBALL

(to Darwin, quietly)
Did the director of the Multiversal Protection Alliance just tell me my show is good?

DARWIN

Yes.

GUMBALL

(pressing his hand against the wall one final time)
Okay. The texture is worth it. This dimension is worth it.

DARWIN

I know.

SEQUENCE TWENTY-G: THE MONITORING ROOM —

JOSEPH AND YARA

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — MONITORING ROOM —

THREE MONTHS AFTER ANTARCTICA (THE SCENE
CONTINUES FROM WHERE IT LEFT OFF)

Joseph stands at the window on the fortieth floor
with his cold coffee.

Yara has put a new cup beside him and settled
on the edge of his desk.

JOSEPH

There is something I have been
thinking
about. Since Antarctica.

YARA

Yes?

JOSEPH

About what Oblivion said. About the
waiting. Eleven framework cycles of
pressing against the barriers and not
being felt.

YARA

Yes.

JOSEPH

I think the thing that ended the war
—
if it can be called ended — was not
the power. It was the acknowledgment.
The framework finally knew Oblivion
was there. Not as a threat. As a part
of it that had been left
unacknowledged.

YARA

The recognition.

JOSEPH

Yes. I keep thinking about what that

means at a smaller scale. Not
multiversal
— human. The people who become
destructive
because they were not seen. The
people
who pressed against barriers their
whole
lives because the barriers never
acknowledged the pressure.

YARA

That is my entire field. Trauma
cognition,
behavioral neuroscience. The people
who
experience chronic non-acknowledgment
—
the effects accumulate exactly the
way
Oblivion accumulated. Not quickly.
Over
time. Until the pressure becomes
structural.

JOSEPH

Until the pressure becomes what they
are
rather than what they are
experiencing.

YARA

Yes. Exactly.

JOSEPH

Then the answer — at the human scale
—
is also recognition. Not solving the
problem. Seeing the person.

YARA

That is the beginning of solving the
problem. Not the solution. But the
beginning.

JOSEPH

I keep thinking about Brian McKenzie.

YARA

Brian McKenzie?

JOSEPH

I know. It seems like a non-sequitur. But I have been thinking: what does someone become when they are given, from the beginning, the message that their presence is sufficient justification for whatever they choose to do? When the barrier between their impulse and its consequence is removed by money and institutional protection? What does that person learn about what they are?

YARA

They learn that they are the exception. That the rules that organize everyone else are not theirs. That they are outside the system.

JOSEPH

And being outside the system — being told you are the exception — is its own form of not being seen. Not acknowledged as a person who exists within the same constraints as everyone else. As a person who will have to reckon with the same consequences.

YARA

You are not defending him.

JOSEPH

No. I am trying to understand the shape of something so that I can recognize it when it is smaller and earlier and preventable. The Brian McKenzies are made before Harvard. The making is where the intervention is possible.

Yara looks at him.

YARA

This is what you were writing at five in the morning at the Harvard dining hall, isn't it. The dimensional framework theory. The observer and the observed. The measurement as intervention.

JOSEPH

Yes.

YARA

It is all the same question.

JOSEPH

I think it has always been the same question. I think I have been asking the same question since I was fourteen in a parking lot in Rabat eating a kefta sandwich with my father in the pre-dawn quiet.

YARA

What is the question?

Joseph looks at the Manhattan skyline. At the city that was damaged three months ago and is in the daily unglamorous work of repairing itself, one building at a time, one person at a time, without ceremony.

JOSEPH

How do you pay attention to the thing the current theory cannot see? How do you notice what the framework is systematically designed not to notice?

He turns to her.

JOSEPH

My father has been answering this question in his classroom for thirty years. Each student. Each particular way of failing to understand a particular

thing. Each margin note. The
accumulated
record of paying attention.

YARA

And you want to do that at the scale
of the multiverse.

JOSEPH

I want to do that at every scale. The
multiverse because the multiverse is
what I ended up in. The classroom
because
the classroom is where my father is.
The
fountain bench because the fountain
bench
is where we began.

A pause. The city outside, continuing.

YARA

Joseph.

JOSEPH

Yes.

YARA

Seiko told you the sentence was
building.

JOSEPH

What?

YARA

The sentence. The one you have not
finished. He told you he knew it was
building. I know he told you that.

JOSEPH

He told you he told me?

YARA

Seiko is organized. He followed up.
Joseph almost laughs.

JOSEPH

Yes. He would.

YARA

So?

JOSEPH

So: the sentence is tonight. In the courtyard. When Seiko has arranged for the courtyard to be empty, which I am now confident he has done.

YARA

(and she knows it is true – she has always been able to tell the difference)
Okay.

JOSEPH

Okay.
The door opens. SEIKO, at a velocity that communicates urgency.

SEIKO

Joseph. Signal. Stable. London, near Tower Bridge. Small – approximately basketball-sized rupture. Blue light. Contained. Clearly intentional.
He shows Joseph the dimensional readout.

JOSEPH

That was opened deliberately, from outside, with precision.

SEIKO

Yes. Which means someone knows enough about the dimensional framework – after the fractures sealed – to open a controlled breach of exactly that size without triggering the monitoring systems except at the highest sensitivity.
They look at each other.

SEIKO

I would prefer this to be a coincidence.

JOSEPH
So would I.

YARA
It is not a coincidence.

JOSEPH
No. It is not.
He puts his cold coffee down.

JOSEPH
London. Let us go.
He pauses at the door.

JOSEPH
(to Yara)
The courtyard. Tonight. After London.
She nods.
They go.

SEQUENCE TWENTY-H: THE LETTER — EXTENDED

EXT. TOWER BRIDGE APPROACH, LONDON —

LATER THAT DAY
At the base of the lamppost: the rupture.
Basketball-sized. Glowing with controlled blue
light, stable as a candle in a windless room.
Joseph reads the letter. CLOSE ON THE LETTER:
"To the Protector of the Earth —
Your victory in the first war was impressive.
But it was the beginning, not the conclusion.
Greater powers are watching now. Greater threats
are preparing. The second war is coming. This
time, it will not be the worlds in danger.
It will be time itself.

The one who orchestrated the first war is not yet done. He was watching you on the ice. He found you interesting. He will come with patience and with intelligence, and he will strike at what you love before he strikes at you.

He knows about the fountain bench. He knows about the pastries at ten o'clock. He knows about the olive pressed at the diagonal center. The ordinary things are not a secret. He has been watching them for as long as he has been watching you. Do not let him make you afraid of the ordinary things. They are not a vulnerability. They are the reason.

Be ready.

— Time Tracker"

Joseph folds the letter.

He stands at Tower Bridge in the London evening, with the Thames below and the city extending in every direction, and he holds the letter and he thinks about what it says.

He knows about the ordinary things.

Joseph looks at the river. At the city that has been here for a long time and has survived many things and is still here.

He thinks about Oblivion saying: I did not expect you to be this.

He thinks: whatever comes next will also not expect it. Because whatever comes next has been watching from the outside, and things watched from the outside are always simplified. The watch

never captures the olive pressed at the diagonal center. The watch never captures the four strips of masking tape at each corner of the photograph. The watch never captures the twelve containers of oatmeal arranged in two-by-six formation or the soup that is a record of accumulated decisions no one documented.

The watch captures the extraordinary things. It misses the ordinary ones.

And the ordinary ones are the reason.

He puts the letter in his coat pocket. Next to the kefta sandwich wrapper he has never quite been able to throw away.

He looks at his team.

JOSEPH

Let us go to work.

They go.

The Thames flows.

The lamppost stands.

The city continues, as it has always continued, ordinary and unremarkable and entirely worth defending.

MOMENTS THROUGHOUT THE ANTARCTIC SEQUENCE]

SEQUENCE THIRTEEN-B: THE NIGHT BEFORE ANTARCTICA

INT. MPA TRANSPORT VESSEL — SOUTHERN OCEAN —

NIGHT — EN ROUTE TO ANTARCTICA

The vessel crossing the Southern Ocean in the Antarctic night. Twelve hours out from the geographic south pole. The sea: black and enormous,

the kind of enormous that has no human reference. The wind making sounds against the hull that are not quite language but are not quite random either. Most of the heroes are in the lower decks. Some sleeping – Thor is audible from three compartments away, which everyone expected. Some preparing – Hermione has been in the corner of the mess hall since departure, writing on index cards in her precise script. Some simply sitting, which is what people do in the hours before something enormous.

Joseph is on the deck.

He has been here for forty minutes. The cold is absolute – it bypasses the layers of gear and finds the skin, which is what Antarctic cold does; it is professional about it, the cold of a place that has been cold for longer than human record and has developed efficient methods.

He stands at the rail and looks at the Southern Ocean and does the thing his father taught him. Three honest seconds of acknowledgment.

He gives the situation its due.

One. Two. Three.

DOCTOR STRANGE appears beside him. Not with the dramatic arrival of his sling ring portals – he simply walks through the door from the lower deck and stands at the rail.

DOCTOR STRANGE
Can't sleep?

JOSEPH

I was not trying to. I came up here to think.

DOCTOR STRANGE

About tomorrow?

JOSEPH

About the dissolution. About what I experienced at the vortex center. I have been trying to understand what actually happened to me. Not the function – the frequency, the transmitter capability. I understand that. But the how of it. What the mechanism was.

DOCTOR STRANGE

You want a physical explanation.

JOSEPH

I want any explanation. Physics or something beyond physics. I need to understand what I am now, if I am going to use it correctly.

Strange looks at the ocean. At the stars above the Southern Ocean, which are more numerous here than anywhere Joseph has ever seen – the specific density of stars visible from a place without light pollution and with the clarity of air that has not been touched by human industry for a thousand kilometers in any direction.

DOCTOR STRANGE

I have spent my career studying what exists at the boundaries of what is knowable. The intersection of the physical and the metaphysical. The place where matter ends and something else begins.

JOSEPH

And what is at that intersection?

DOCTOR STRANGE

Intent. That is the simplest word I have found for it. At the edge of what physics can describe, there is a layer of reality that is organized by intent rather than by force. Not by particles or waves or fields, but by the direction of attention. By what things want, if want is a word that can be applied to fundamental forces.

JOSEPH

The framework was built by intent.

DOCTOR STRANGE

The framework was built by accumulated intent. Every world, every story, every universe that decided to organize itself into something rather than nothing — that decision, multiplied across billions of years and billions of worlds, produced a structural layer. The layer of refusal. The layer of continuation. The layer that says: this exists and will continue to exist.

JOSEPH

And the dissolution put me in contact with that layer.

DOCTOR STRANGE

The dissolution put you through the center of the framework. The structural center — the axis around which the accumulated intent rotates. You were

processed through it. And something
of it is now part of your structure.

JOSEPH

Something of the accumulated intent
of billions of years and billions
of worlds is —

He pauses. Looking at his hands.

JOSEPH

In me.

DOCTOR STRANGE

In you. Yes. Not owned by you. Not
generated by you. Available to you.
Because you were at the center and
you chose to let it through.

JOSEPH

The dissolution did not give me this.
I had to let it through.

DOCTOR STRANGE

The dissolution created the capacity.
You created the permission.

Joseph looks at the stars above the Southern
Ocean. At the density of them.

JOSEPH

Then what I transmit is not mine.

DOCTOR STRANGE

Nothing a transmitter transmits is
its own. A transmitter is the shape
through which something passes. The
shape matters — without the shape,
the signal is noise. But the shape
does not own the signal.

A pause. The Southern Ocean making its sounds
against the hull.

JOSEPH

And Oblivion. Tomorrow. What do you
think will happen?

DOCTOR STRANGE

I think what needs to happen will happen. I have run enough probability calculations to know that I cannot predict the outcome with confidence. The variables include too many things that exist in the intent layer rather than the physical layer.

JOSEPH

You are telling me you do not know.

DOCTOR STRANGE

I am telling you that not knowing, in this situation, is correct. The things that cannot be predicted are the things that have not yet been decided. And the thing that has not yet been decided is what you will do at the moment when the situation requires your decision.

JOSEPH

And you think I will make the right decision.

DOCTOR STRANGE

I think you will make the honest decision. Which is, in my experience, more reliable than the right one. The right decision is a judgment about the outcome. The honest decision is a judgment about the information available. If you make the honest decision, the outcome will be what the honest decision produces.

Joseph looks at the stars.

JOSEPH

My father would agree with that.

DOCTOR STRANGE

Your father sounds like a man of considerable wisdom.

JOSEPH

He is a math teacher in Casablanca.

He grades papers by lamplight and
keeps his lesson plans for twenty
years
and makes sandwiches at four-thirty
in the morning.

DOCTOR STRANGE

That sounds like wisdom to me.
Strange goes back inside. Joseph stays at the
rail for a while longer. He thinks about the
lesson plan margins. About the date of each note.
The result. The adjustment.
He thinks: that is what I am doing. Tomorrow.
Making a note in the margin of something that
has been ongoing for eleven framework cycles.
Adding to the record. The record that matters
even when no one is reading it.
He goes inside. He sleeps. He dreams about a
kitchen on the fourth floor of a building on
Rue des Orangers, where the jasmine grows on
the south wall and has been growing for thirty
years and will keep growing regardless of what
the next day produces.
He wakes knowing what he needs to know.

SEQUENCE THIRTEEN-C: THE HEROES BEFORE

INT. MPA TRANSPORT VESSEL — VARIOUS LOCATIONS —
NIGHT — EN ROUTE TO ANTARCTICA

The night before Antarctica. The ship crossing
the Southern Ocean. What each person is doing
in the hours before:

BATMAN: in the tactical command center, updating
the battle plan for the fourth time since departure.

Not because the plan is wrong – because each update reveals a new consideration that the previous version had not fully addressed. He works with the concentration of someone for whom preparation is indistinguishable from the work itself. He does not think of this as anxiety. He thinks of it as professionalism.

SUPERMAN: on the deck, where Joseph was earlier. He stands at the rail and looks at the stars with the expression of someone who has been among the stars and knows them as more than lights and is reminded, by their presence, of the people who first showed them to him – a man in Kansas who pointed up and said: look at all that. Look at all of it. There is so much.

He thinks about Jonathan Kent. About what Jonathan Kent would say if Jonathan Kent could see where his son is standing tonight.

He thinks Jonathan Kent would say: do what you know is right, Clark. The rest will follow from that. It always does.

He thinks Jonathan Kent would be correct.

THOR: asleep. In the manner of someone who has mastered the skill of sleeping before battle, which is the skill of deciding that what comes before the sleep is sufficient preparation and that the sleep itself is also preparation. He sleeps with the deep regularity of someone who has been sleeping before battles for fifteen hundred years and has developed

a practice around it.

He snores. It is audible from three compartments away. Everyone has decided this is acceptable.

GANDALF: sitting with a pipe, which he is not lighting because the ship has fire suppression systems that he does not wish to test, but which he holds in the way of someone whose hands need something to hold when they are thinking. He is thinking about the things he has been through before battles of this scale. About Moria. About Pelennor Fields. About the knowledge, developed over many such battles, that the outcome is never determined in advance. That the outcome is always determined in the moment – by what the people present decide in the moment – and that the best preparation for the moment is not certainty but clarity.

He holds his unlit pipe and achieves his clarity.

HARRY, RON, and HERMIONE: the mess hall. Hermione's index cards. Ron's quiet steady presence beside her, not reading the cards but being present while she reads them, which is what Ron does. Harry watching them both with the expression of someone who has understood, over many years of being the person things happen to, that the thing things happen to is sustained by the people who sit beside him while they happen.

He thinks: we made it this far. We make it a bit further.

SEIKO: the communications station, alone. He has

been running final checks on every data feed for the past two hours. His hands are steady. His shoulder, bandaged, aches in the cold but he has noted this and filed it under: manageable. He opens a document on his screen that he has not opened since September. The document is: REASONS THE FIRST YEAR OF HARVARD IS WORTH IT. He created it on the second night, when Seiko and the red punch and the party were still fresh. He created it because he needed a document to put the reasons in, because the reasons needed to be documented in order to be real. The document has seven entries. Entry one: met Joseph on the coach from Fez. Entry two: Joseph said "that is actually a capability, if you learn to use it correctly." Entry three: the twelve containers of oatmeal were not called excessive. Entry four: Yara brought pastries. Entry five: late nights at the table. Entry six: Dr. Ellison's office hours. Entry seven: this is the beginning, not the end. He reads the document. He closes it. He goes back to his data feeds. He is ready.

GUMBALL and DARWIN: the smallest cabin, because they are the smallest people. Gumball lying on the bunk looking at the ceiling, which is a ceiling and not a cartoon ceiling and therefore has depth and shadow and texture. Darwin in the

bunk below him, also looking at a ceiling,
which is the underside of Gumball's bunk and
is also three-dimensional.

GUMBALL
(to the ceiling)
Darwin.

DARWIN
(to the underside of the
bunk)
Yes?

GUMBALL
If things go badly tomorrow —

DARWIN
They will not.

GUMBALL
But if they do —

DARWIN
They will not. But if they do: we
will face them together. That has
always been the answer to that
question.

A pause.

GUMBALL
I am glad we ran toward the portal
in our living room.

DARWIN
Me too.

GUMBALL
I am glad we grabbed the yellow mug.

DARWIN
Me too.

GUMBALL
I am glad Joseph's sister made him
watch the show.

A longer pause.

DARWIN
Me too, Gumball.

GUMBALL
Good. Okay. Good.
He is quiet.

DARWIN
Gumball.

GUMBALL
Yes?

DARWIN
Get some sleep.

GUMBALL
Yes. Okay. Sleep.
A pause.

GUMBALL
Darwin?

DARWIN
Yes?

GUMBALL
Thank you. For being my brother.

DARWIN
(warmly, quietly)
Thank you for being mine.
The ship crosses the Southern Ocean. The stars
above it: the density of the stars
of the Southern Hemisphere, which are different
from the Northern Hemisphere's stars not in
fact but in proportion — the south has more
of the center of the galaxy visible, more of
the dense band of the Milky Way spread across
its sky.
More stars. More light. More of the galaxy
visible than anywhere else on Earth.

This is where they are going to make their stand.

YARA: the medical bay, reviewing tomorrow's contingency plans. She is the kind of person who prepares the contingency plans because someone has to prepare the contingency plans, and she has accepted that she is the someone in this group whose preparation takes this particular form.

She is also thinking about Joseph.

About the sentence he started and did not finish.

I will always – and then the siege machine's defeat and the aftermath and the hospital dome and three months of watching the sentence not be finished, with the knowledge that it was building, that the words were coming, that Joseph finds words carefully and the careful finding takes the time it takes.

She is thinking about the courtyard. The string lights. The mint growing in the pot on the forty-fourth floor.

She is thinking: after tomorrow. After all of this. There is an after. There has always been an after, even when the during is enormous.

She folds the contingency plans. She goes to sleep. She dreams of a fountain bench in September and a paper with a number written on it in clean precise handwriting, and a morning that was terrible but was also the beginning of everything that came after.

SEQUENCE FIFTEEN-C: ANTARCTICA — THE MIDDLE HOURS

EXT. ANTARCTICA — SHELF ICE — HOURS THREE AND FOUR

— CONTINUOUS

The middle of the battle: not the beginning when the energy of the first engagement carries you, not the end when the end is visible and the end is worth what it costs to reach it. The middle, which is the hardest part, which has no dramatic shape, which is simply the ongoing decision to continue.

Hour three. The decision to continue.

WONDER WOMAN: a wound on her left arm from hour two that she has not acknowledged. It does not slow her. She is three thousand years old and has been wounded in three thousand years of battles and has learned that the wound is information about what she needs to work around, not a reason to stop working. She works around it. She does not mention it. She notes it. She files it. She continues.

She thinks: this is what it means to be at war. Not the heroic moment. The wound on the left arm in the middle of the battle and the continuing anyway.

She has been doing this for three thousand years. She continues.

SPIDER-MAN: hour three. He has been in continuous motion since the battle began — swinging, attaching, repositioning, the three-dimensional mobility

that is his greatest advantage in any environment. In Antarctica, where the structures are limited, he has been using the enemy formations themselves as pivot points, which is an approach that takes a level of spatial confidence that most people are not equipped to have.

He is also talking. He always talks. He has been talking continuously for three hours, which he has done in every fight he has ever been in because the talking is how he manages the fear – not eliminating it, managing it, converting it into something that keeps moving.

SPIDER-MAN

(to himself, during a gap in the engagement – he gets rare gaps and uses them for this)
Okay. Okay okay okay. This is a lot. This is actually a lot. But I have done a lot before. I have done – the airport. I have done space. I have done being dead for five years, kind of. I have done a lot and this is a lot
but it is also just the next lot and I am going to be fine and everyone is going to be fine and –

A Chitauri unit appears at his six o'clock.

He webs it without looking.

SPIDER-MAN

– and that is fine too. Everything is fine. This is completely fine. This is not true. But saying it in the tone of someone who believes it produces, in the people within hearing range, something adjacent to belief, which is the next best thing.

Gumball, twenty meters away with his scaffolding

pipe, hears this and finds it helpful. He files it. He will use a version of it later, in the moment when seventeen heroes need a reset of perspective, and it will work, because it is the version of truth that the moment requires.

Hour four. The gap in the east sector. The thirty meters between Captain America's perimeter and the left flank. The Mordor formation finding it. The Nazgul entering it.

And Gumball saying the thing that no account fully captures but every person present remembers. What the accounts agree on: that it reframed the gap. That it turned the catastrophe into a problem. That problems have solutions and that the heroes went to find the solution.

What the accounts disagree on: the exact words. Captain America's account says: "He said something about the gap being the wrong shape for the right answer." Hermione's account says: "He made an observation about failure being a kind of information that you only receive from inside the failure." Thor's account says: "He said something loud and correct and then laughed at himself for saying it, which was exactly right."

Darwin's account is the simplest and probably the most accurate: "He said what he always says. He said: well, that went exactly as we should have expected, so the only thing left to do is the thing we do when things go exactly as we

should have expected."

And seventeen heroes laughed. One and a half seconds.

The perspective reset. The gap became a problem.

The problem got a solution. The east sector held.

Hour five. Joseph, maintaining the frequency of the golden doors – keeping the remaining heroes' access paths clear, ensuring the dimensional connections that have already been established stay stable. He has been doing this continuously since the battle began. It does not look like much. He stands near the command dome and he maintains the frequency, which means he is very still, which in a battle that is all motion makes him look like something that is not doing anything.

But the frequency is the architecture on which everything else runs. Without it, the heroes who came through the doors are here but unconnected – present but not part of a whole. The frequency is what makes them a unit rather than a collection of individuals from different worlds, each running their own tactical logic. TONY STARK lands beside him at the four-and-a-half-hour mark.

TONY STARK
How are you holding up?

JOSEPH
Tired. But correctly tired.

TONY STARK
First time I have heard someone put

it that way. What does correctly
tired
mean?

JOSEPH

It means the tired is from doing
something. Not from failing to.
Tony looks at him. The assessing look – rapid,
complete, the assessment of an engineer
examining a system under load.

TONY STARK

Can you maintain the frequency for
another hour?

JOSEPH

Yes.

TONY STARK

Can you maintain it for two hours?

JOSEPH

Probably.

TONY STARK

And at the end of two hours, when
Oblivion descends – can you do what
you need to do?
Joseph looks at the convergence point. At the
formation rising above it. At the fracture lines
now glowing with the intensity of something that
is approaching its critical state.

JOSEPH

I do not know. I think so. But I do
not know.

TONY STARK

That is good enough.

JOSEPH

Is it?

TONY STARK

Yes. Because "I think so" with your
track record is better than
"definitely"
from most people I have worked with.
He takes off again.

Joseph watches him go. He turns back to the
frequency. He maintains it. Hour five.

SEIKO's voice through the comm:

SEIKO
(over comm)
All five sectors holding. East sector
fully restored after the Mordor
probe.
North sector: Thor is — Thor is
enjoying
himself significantly.

THOR
(over comm, from the north,
audible through two frequencies)

I AM ENJOYING THIS VERY MUCH.

SEIKO
Yes. I know, Thor. Joseph — thirty-
seven
minutes to the fracture peak. The
formation
at the convergence point is at
eighty-two
percent of calculated maximum height.

JOSEPH
Understood. Thirty-seven minutes.
He thinks about his father. He thinks about the
olive at the diagonal center. He thinks about the
specific weight of ordinary things.
He maintains the frequency.
He waits.

SEQUENCE SIXTEEN-C: BEFORE OBLIVION — THE LAST MINUTES

EXT. ANTARCTICA — CONVERGENCE POINT — FIVE MINUTES

BEFORE THE FRACTURE PEAK

Five minutes.

The formation above the convergence point is now ten meters high and rising. The fracture lines: blazing with the impossible colors of dimensional stress at maximum load, the light of eleven framework cycles of pressure finding its release point.

The heroes have pulled back from the center — Batman's order, thirty minutes ago, based on Seiko's calculations about the radius of effect when the fracture lines peak. The enemy forces have also pulled back, because the Chitauri have instructions that include "when the formation reaches this height, withdraw to this radius."

The convergence point has become a circle of cleared ice. Empty. Blazing.

Joseph stands at the edge of the cleared circle. YARA is beside him.

YARA

You do not have to go to the center.

JOSEPH

I know.

YARA

Seiko's models suggest the
transmission
will be effective from the perimeter
—

JOSEPH

I know what Seiko's models suggest.
I also know what my model suggests.

And my model says the center is
where this happens.

YARA

Then I will be at the edge. Watching.
If something goes wrong –

JOSEPH

If something goes wrong, you will
know
what to do. You always know what to
do.

YARA

Joseph –
He turns to her. He looks at her with the full
weight of everything he wants to say tonight,
in the courtyard, with the string lights.

JOSEPH

After. In the courtyard. I will be
there.

YARA

(and she believes him – she
always believes him when he
says the actual things)
Yes. Okay.

JOSEPH

Watch from the edge. You do not have
to see this from close up.

YARA

I know. But I am going to.
He nods. He steps forward into the cleared circle.
He walks toward the convergence point.
Behind him: every hero watching. the
quality of the watching – not hope exactly, not
faith exactly. Something that is made from both
of those things plus the knowledge,
earned through the past thirty-six hours, that

this person does what he says he will do.
Batman watching from the tactical perimeter.
He does not pray. He calculates. But the
calculation at this moment produces a result
that is not tactical. The result is: this is
the correct person in the correct place making
the correct choice with the information available.
He watches.
Tony Stark watching. Not running calculations.
For the first time in the entire engagement,
not running calculations. Just watching.
Thor watching. He is still, which for Thor
is the equivalent of the silence of
someone who understands that the moment is
larger than his response to it.
Gandalf watching. He holds his unlit pipe. He
has watched many people walk toward many difficult
things. He knows the quality of the
walk of someone who knows what they are walking
toward and walks toward it anyway. He recognizes
it in Joseph.
He recognizes something else too. He has seen it
before, in other people, at other convergences,
in a world very far from this one.
He recognizes: the person who will be changed
by what they do next. Not broken. Changed. The
specific irreversible change of someone who has
touched something fundamental and brought it
through and will carry the touch of it for the
rest of their life.

He thinks: yes. This is the one.
Joseph reaches the center of the cleared circle.
He looks up at the formation. At the fracture
lines blazing.
At the sky above Antarctica, which is beginning
to change.
The galaxies approaching.

JOSEPH

(to himself - to the kitchen
on the fourth floor, to the
jasmine on the south wall,
to the olive at the diagonal
center, to the lesson plan
with twenty years of margins,
to twelve containers of oatmeal
in two-by-six formation, to the
pastries at ten o'clock, to the
paper with the number in clean
precise handwriting, to the laugh
from the floor, to the actual
version, to every Sunday phone
call, to the ordinary
human fact of refusing to stop)
Let it through.

He kneels.

Both palms flat on the ice.

The light begins.

SEQUENCE TWENTY-I: TONY STARK AND BATMAN -

AFTER ANTARCTICA

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS - CONFERENCE ROOM -

THREE DAYS AFTER ANTARCTICA

The debrief. Every senior MPA member present.
The battle maps. The casualty reports. The
dimensional stability readings showing the
sealed fracture lines. The portals: all closed

and confirmed closed by every available sensor.
The debrief lasts four hours.
At the end of it, when everyone else has filed
out and the room belongs to the people who
stay after:

BATMAN and TONY STARK, opposite ends of the
table. Coffee that has gone cold at both their
elbows. A silence that is not the comfortable
silence of people who have said what needs
to be said, but the silence of people who are
thinking about what they have witnessed.

TONY STARK
He talked to it.

BATMAN
Yes.

TONY STARK
To the thing that has been trying to
unmake the dimensional framework for
eleven cycles of existence that each
lasted millions of years. He talked
to it.

BATMAN
He told it he was sorry.

TONY STARK
Yes. That part I was — that part I
keep coming back to.

BATMAN
Why?

TONY STARK
Because I would not have done that.
My instinct when I am facing
something
that large and that threatening is to
find the vulnerability and target it.

Not to acknowledge it.

BATMAN

Your instinct and his instinct are both correct. They are correct for different opponents.

TONY STARK

But he knew which opponent he had. He read the situation and he knew what it required, and what it required was something most people would not think of because most people are not looking for it.

BATMAN

What was he looking for?

TONY STARK

The thing the framework could not see. The part of the situation that the current model does not account for. That is how he thinks. That is how he has been thinking since the first day – the question he asked Ellison in the physics lecture. The observer and the observed. The lens that shapes what you see. He has been asking the same question his entire life and he got the answer in Antarctica.

Batman is quiet.

BATMAN

He will be more important to the second war than the first.

TONY STARK

Yes.

BATMAN

The second war will not be fought with the tools the first war required. The architect – whoever is in the

black crystal throne hall — is not
Oblivion. Oblivion was real and
enormous
and terrible and it was also, in some
fundamental sense, honest. It wanted
what it wanted and it came for it
directly.

TONY STARK

The architect is not honest.

BATMAN

No. The architect is patient and
intelligent and has been watching
us for long enough to know our
vulnerabilities. And Joseph's
vulnerability —

TONY STARK

Is the ordinary things.

BATMAN

Yes. The people he loves. The kitchen
on the fourth floor. The olive at the
diagonal center. The architect knows
about these. The letter told us that.

TONY STARK

So we need to be the protection for
the ordinary things while Joseph is
the protection for everything else.

BATMAN

Yes. We need to make sure that what
he is fighting for is still there
when he needs it to be.

A pause.

TONY STARK

I want you to know something.

BATMAN

What?

TONY STARK

When the light came out of him at
the convergence point — when the

ordinary frequency moved through him
– I ran analysis on it. FRIDAY
quantified it. The frequency.

BATMAN

And?

TONY STARK

There was one note I could not
identify. A single frequency that
was distinct from everything else.
Not the accumulated will of seven
billion people. Something smaller.
More specific.

BATMAN

What was it?

TONY STARK

FRIDAY traced it to a signal source
in Casablanca, Morocco. Fourth floor
apartment. A woman named Fatima
Al-Mithali.

Batman is still.

TONY STARK

She was asleep. She had worked a
twelve-hour nursing shift. She was
asleep in Casablanca, Morocco, and
her frequency – whatever her sleeping
mind produces, whatever her forty-
nine years of caring for people
produces even while she is
unconscious –
was in his signal. At the
convergence.
In Antarctica.

A long silence.

BATMAN

She did not know she was there.

TONY STARK

No. She was asleep.

BATMAN

(quietly – the quiet of someone

who has been alone in the dark
for a long time and has
just been reminded that alone
is not the only option)
Yes. That is the thing, isn't it.
She did not know. She was just —
there. Present. Being what she is.
And it traveled.

Tony Stark looks at the table.

TONY STARK

I would like to meet her someday.

BATMAN

Yes. So would I.

They sit with their cold coffee in the empty
conference room after the debrief of the first
Multiversal War. Not planning. Not assessing.
Just sitting with the fact of what they have
witnessed.

The fact that a woman in Casablanca, asleep,
was present in Antarctica.

The fact that presence does not require
awareness. That what you are travels even
when you do not send it.

The fact that the ordinary things are not
stored in the places where you put them.

They travel. They find the people who need
them. They arrive at the convergence point
and are part of the light that changes
everything.

SEQUENCE TWENTY-J: NADIA — SIX MONTHS LATER

**INT. AL-MITHALI APARTMENT — NADIA'S ROOM —
CASABLANCA — EVENING**

Six months after Antarctica.

NADIA AL-MITHALI, 15, is at her desk. Her desk is less organized than Joseph's desk was at fifteen — she is a different kind of person, the kind of person who thinks better in the midst of small controlled chaos, papers at specific useful angles, books with their spines out at various orientations.

She is writing. Not schoolwork — something else.

CLOSE ON the notebook:

"The Amazing World of the Multiversal Saga: A Complete Guide to Every Character, Event, and Dimensional Framework in the First War."
She has been working on this for six weeks. It is currently 47 pages. She intends it to be complete.

She wrote it because someone had to write it. Because the record matters. Because the date of each note, the result, the adjustment — this is what their father taught them, and Nadia has understood this lesson in her own way.

She is writing the history of what her brother was part of, so that it exists, so that it is documented, so that if the second war comes — and the letter from the Time Tracker suggests that it will — there will be a record of the first one that a fifteen-year-old girl thought was important enough to write down.

JOSEPH appears in the doorway. He is visiting —

he visits every month now, which Fatima and Hassan were told about in advance and which Nadia was told about obliquely, because Nadia gets the actual version.
He looks at the notebook.

JOSEPH
What are you writing?

NADIA
(not looking up)
The history.

JOSEPH
Of?

NADIA
Of what you did. Of what everyone did. Someone has to write it down or it becomes the version that gets simplified. The version where you are only the hero and Seiko is only the best friend and Gumball is only comic relief and Oblivion is only the villain.
None of those versions are accurate.
Joseph comes into the room. He sits on the edge of the bed. He looks at the notebook.

JOSEPH
Can I read it?

NADIA
When it is finished.

JOSEPH
When will it be finished?

NADIA
When the second war ends and I can write the full arc. I am leaving space at the end.
Joseph looks at her. His fifteen-year-old sister.

The girl who fell off the couch laughing and
kept laughing from the floor. The girl who said:
the actual version.

He thinks: she is going to be remarkable.

He thinks: she already is.

JOSEPH

Nadia.

NADIA

(still writing)

Yes?

JOSEPH

You were right. About Gumball. About
the show. And about – about
everything
else.

NADIA

I know.

JOSEPH

Can you not say "I know" in that
specific
tone? I am trying to give you a
compliment.

NADIA

You are trying to give me a
compliment
because you feel guilty for not
calling
on the Thursday of the second week of
Harvard. You promised the actual
version
and you called on Sunday.

JOSEPH

I was saving the world.

NADIA

On Thursday you were not yet saving
the

world. On Thursday you were sitting
on
the Memorial Hall steps feeling
homesick
and you did not call me because you
thought it would worry me.
Joseph stares at her.

JOSEPH
How do you know about the Memorial
Hall
steps?

NADIA
(with a very specific and entirely
sisterly satisfaction)
I know things, Joseph. I have been
learning things about you my entire
life.
She goes back to writing.

NADIA
Sit down. Tell me something I can put
in the history.

JOSEPH
What kind of something?

NADIA
The actual version. Not the version
for press conferences.
He sits. He thinks about what to tell her.
He tells her about the moment on the Antarctic
ice, with his palms flat, in the position his
mother taught him. About the frequency and what
it felt like and the note that he could
not identify until later – the note that was
his mother, asleep, being what she is, traveling
across the world without knowing she traveled.
Nadia writes this down. Date, result, adjustment.
Outside the window: Casablanca in the evening.

The jasmine on the south wall, still growing.
The call to prayer beginning from the mosque
four streets over.
The world: continuing.
Which is, as it turns out, the only thing it
ever needed to do.